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UNIVERSITY OF SOUTHAMPTON

Faculty of Arts and Humanities
Winchester School of Art

**Altercharacter and Identity:
The Practice of Choice-Making in Narrative
Video Games**

by

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*A thesis for the degree of
Doctor of Philosophy*

November 2022

University of Southampton

Abstract

Faculty of Arts and Humanities
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This thesis investigates the relationship between player and video game through player-character relationships, choice-making, and the player's emotional engagement. Specifically, it rethinks the relationship between player and player-character in the context of player choice, emotion, and subjective experience. It addresses the role the different facets of the player-game relationship play in the player's choice-making processes, as well as the driving factors behind the player's choice-making behaviours in the context of the player's subjectivity, interpretation, and emotional engagement. This thesis also puts forward a comprehensive method encompassing gameplay analysis, autoethnographic research with a focus on the player-researcher perspective, and ethnographic research in the form of participant observation and semi-structured interviews to enable an in-depth analysis of the different aspects of the gaming experience, offering new ways to address the subjective and emotional dimensions of this experience.

Throughout this thesis, I establish that the dynamics of the player-game relationship in narrative video games are not only informed by, but actively shape the player's engagement with an interactive narrative, drawing on a notion of agency as a communicative, interreactive process in which player and game affect each other reciprocally. The framework of the gaming experience that is formulated in this thesis acknowledges this interreactive relationship and the player's active role of interpretation, meaning-making, and choice-making by setting out the concept of the *altercharacter* as the entity that is formed through the process of making choices. Building on the foundation of the player's subjective experience and the communicative nature of the gaming experience, I establish choice-making as a practice that is shaped by both player *and* game, and is embedded within a wider cultural framework of gaming behaviours and literacies. The player's choice-making practices are also shaped by the altercharacter, whose construction has emotional consequences for the player via a shared sense of responsibility.

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Declaration of Authorship

I declare that this thesis and the work presented in it is my own and has been generated by me as the result of my own original research.

I confirm that:

1. This work was done wholly or mainly while in candidature for a research degree at this University;
2. Where any part of this thesis has previously been submitted for a degree or any other qualification at this University or any other institution, this has been clearly stated;
3. Where I have consulted the published work of others, this is always clearly attributed;
4. Where I have quoted from the work of others, the source is always given. With the exception of such quotations, this thesis is entirely my own work;
5. I have acknowledged all main sources of help;
6. Where the thesis is based on work done by myself jointly with others, I have made clear exactly what was done by others and what I have contributed myself;
7. Parts of this work have been published as:
 Schäfer, Samantha (2018). 'Agency and Authorship in Ludic Narrative Environments'. In: *Interactive Storytelling*. Ed. by Rebecca Rouse, Hartmut Koenitz, and Mads Haahr. Cham: Springer International Publishing, pp. 185–189.

Signed:.....

Date:.....

Acknowledgements

This thesis would not have been possible without many people, and I can't name them all. First and foremost, my thanks go to my supervisors Seth Giddings and Dan Ashton, and in my first years Calum Kerr, who have been nothing but inspiring and fun throughout this entire process, and whose continued understanding and encouragement were fundamental in getting me through this in turbulent times in which everyone's world was falling apart quite a bit.

There are many people that had a part in my academic journey. In particular, I would like to thank Connie Veugen, who during my Master's showed me how wonderful and exciting game studies can be, and Dave Millard, who effectively adopted me as a PhD student over the last few years, too. My colleagues at Winchester School of Art have been an integral part of my development, and I'm grateful for everyone who supported my teaching and research practice. I also thank the people who participated in my study; this research would literally have been impossible without you.

Naturally, I thank my family, who have continuously supported me as I jumped from country to country and subject to subject until I found one that fit, and who have not only endured, but very much fuelled my interest in video games ever since my hands were big enough to use mouse and keyboard.

I would also like to thank the friends that have listened to and encouraged me all these years. There are too many to list (and you know who you are), but to highlight just a few: Bertina and her family, who have always been there for me no matter what; Anna, who has been part of my academic journey since the beginning of my Bachelor's; Laura, Kim, and Jenny, who are always ready to lend an ear; Charlie, who is always excited to hear about my research; and my role-playing groups who regularly allow me to forget about all of this and instead be a bard, a werewolf, a vampire, or a Space Marine: Cassian, Chris, Nils, Björn, Daniel, Ash, Joey, and Lesia. Special thanks to Lesia for pushing me into the most interesting creative projects, and to Joey for our countless study sessions – this thesis would not have been written without them.

Oz – thank you for being the best rubber duck that I could have asked for, for being part of this PhD since the first day and listening to and reading so many iterations of it. It was such a gift to be able to grow together as researchers, teachers, and people.

Last but definitely not least, Andy – I can't thank you enough for being there for me and believing in me every day, for joining forces with the cats to make sure that I stop writing at a reasonable time, and for so much more.

*To my mother Ute, who is one of the strongest people I know, and
my father Norbert, who has always believed that I would get
here.*

Chapter 1

Introduction

The Principal turns around and addresses the group. 'Now, I know today was difficult for everybody, but I'm so proud of the way Blackwell Academy pulled together to save a young girl's life.' In the real world, I frown. 'Well, I pulled together,' I tell the screen pointedly. I have just been through a stressful situation talking a girl off a roof, and none of these people here were particularly helpful – quite the opposite, in fact. The teacher Mr. Jefferson, the security guard Mr. Madsen, and my fellow student Nathan are all equally shady to me. The atmosphere is tense, and it's clear that everyone here is in trouble. 'Of course, you're quite a hero for getting Kate to come down, Max,' the Principal continues.

'I didn't do much,' Max replies in her usual shy manner.

'She's modest. Like a real hero,' Mr. Jefferson pipes up, and Mr. Madsen grumbles sarcastically, 'Yeah. 'Real hero.'" Clearly not everyone here is a fan. Principal Wells continues with his speech about how he takes the well-being of his students seriously and admonishes the men for their potential role in the situation. Eventually, he sits down and addresses the player-character Max – and, by extension, me, asking us to tell him everything that we know. Max looks deeply uncomfortable, and the game offers me three options to reply. I can tell him that Nathan dosed Kate, that Mr. Jefferson made her cry, or that Mr. Madsen bullied her.

I, the player, groan slightly. 'Oh God,' I mumble to myself, then I start talking myself through the different options – I can't prove that Nathan drugged her, and even though I know from a previous playthrough that Mr. Jefferson is not as nice and innocent as he seems, I feel bad for calling him out like that – despite the fact that he very likely was the trigger for Kate's suicide attempt, as I had witnessed him be harsh to her just before the incident. Listening to my own reasoning, I select Mr. Jefferson, and Max explains, 'I saw Mr. Jefferson talking to Kate right before our class... then she ran off crying...'

Mr. Jefferson explains how withdrawn Kate has been of late, and how the video after the Vortex Club party seems to have made matters worse. In the interest of avoiding negative publicity, Principal Wells doesn't want him to represent the Academy at the upcoming photography contest in San Francisco, and while he is clearly disappointed, Mr. Jefferson makes himself sound genuinely apologetic – knowing everything that I know about him, it makes me dislike him even more. Principal Wells asks Max to sign her statement of the events, and this is when the game gives me back control. Nobody here knows about Max's powers to rewind time, and since I am very indecisive – there is plenty of blame to go around –, I rewind to see what the alternatives are. Pointing out how Kate was bullied by Mr. Madsen leads to my suspension while the Principal looks into the accusations, though he doesn't seem to believe me much. Max and I are both worked up about the accusations that are thrown at us, and grumpily, I rewind again, figuring that my accusations of Nathan wouldn't be taken too seriously, either. To my surprise, Principal Wells decides to suspend the completely unapologetic and arrogant Nathan while he looks into this matter, and once again I am faced with the choice of signing or rewinding.

I find this choice particularly difficult, and having seen the different immediate outcomes, I am unsure which one to go with. Eventually, I decide to stick with my last choice, but there is something fatalistic about it. 'No matter what I do, it's going to be something wrong,' I say to myself. If there is one thing I have learned from this game so far, it is that, indeed, my actions have consequences – and not always positive ones, either...

This scene from *Life is Strange* (Donnod Entertainment, 2015) hints at the complex interaction between player and video game in justifying, making, and processing choices. *Life is Strange's* main theme is choice and consequence in presenting the player-character with the possibility to rewind time, allowing the player to explore alternatives before committing to their decisions – a mechanism that, as the autoethnographical account shows, is direly needed. Any other game would have forced me to go through with my decisions, accepting the consequences no matter how unpleasant they might be, but by now, I have discovered that this mechanism is not always a blessing, fully expecting that eventually, my choices will be twisted into something I did not intend. But if they weren't, would the game still be as enjoyable?

This thesis aims to provide insights into the complexity of the interplay between the player as an entity as well as a person, the narrative, and choice-making, investigating more specifically the ways in which the player and the game system work together to create a coherent, individual gaming experience. In particular, I discuss video games that have a strong narrative and character focus, and that are explicitly dependent on player choice to inform the development of story and character. While some of the insights emerging from the analysis may be applicable to other types of games, the

relationship between player and player-character will be different in games that have a greater ludic focus and are less character-driven. The findings presented throughout this thesis, then, are not meant to be generalisable to all video games and are instead applicable mainly to narrative video games. Specifically, the player-game relationship is analysed in this thesis on the basis of *Life is Strange* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2015), *Life is Strange 2* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2018), *Detroit: Become Human* (Quantic Dream, 2018), and *Horizon Zero Dawn* (Guerrilla Games, 2017).

Rather than focusing solely on the player's power through agency, i.e. the player's ability to impact the game by making choices that are perceived as *meaningful* (Murray, 1997; Wardrip-Fruin et al., 2009), I consider gaming to be a largely symbiotic relationship, drawing on the understanding that 'video game players are acted on as much as they act' (Giddings, 2009, p. 151). Giddings suggests that the relationship that is formed during gameplay is underpinned by a constant redefining and managing of one's expectations and adaptation to the other entity's behaviour. This means that player and video game act in a complex feedback loop in which the actions of the one entity are made because of and towards the other, creating less of a hierarchical structure and more of an equal partnership.

With this notion at the core of the player-game relationship, this thesis considers agency and interactivity as a communicative or collaborative experience that is based not only on the player's input and the technical structures of the game, but is also guided by the game's feedback and the player's interpretation of their own role and actions within the game. I therefore contribute to the understanding of the player-game relationship by focusing specifically on the ways in which it is primarily determined through the player's relationship with the player-character, which in turn is established by a constant negotiation of player and character personalities, the player's choice-making practices, and the control and responsibility that is passed between player and game. Rather than merely considering the different functions of the player-character as an avatar or a narrative character, I establish the *altercharacter* as a separate entity that is unique to the individual gaming experience and whose construction has emotional consequences for the player via a shared sense of responsibility. As this thesis will show, the *altercharacter* is developed through the player's engagement with and interpretation of the video game and their place within it, and can be considered the product of the communication and cooperation between game and player. With the *altercharacter* representing the point where the different aspects of the gaming experience intersect, this thesis further conceptualises the player's choice-making behaviour as a practice that is developed through continued engagement with other games and the different types of literacy that are refined through this engagement.

Apart from theoretical contributions, this thesis also makes a methodological contribution to address the marked methodological incoherence in the field of game studies (cf. Consalvo and Dutton, 2006; Koenitz, 2018), a side-effect of the debates that took

place in the early years of game studies, after which '[s]cholarship on narrative aspects of video games became marginalized and academics working on the topic in the context of games still face considerable resistance and lack of recognition' (Koenitz, 2018, p. 38). The complexity of the medium lends itself to research from a variety of disciplines, further widening the gap between different methodological approaches. Only some such approaches include close readings or textual analysis (cf. Atkins, 2003; Ip, 2011a; Veugen, 2011; Fernández-Vara, 2014), quantitative research in the form of surveys (cf. Davis et al., 2005), qualitative research in the form of interviews (cf. Jørgensen, 2009; Buchanan-Oliver and Seo, 2012; Muriel and Crawford, 2018), ethnographic and autoethnographic research (cf. Giddings and Kennedy, 2008; Harvey, 2009; Klastrop, 2009; Thornham, 2016), and protocol analysis (cf. Kway and Mitchell, 2018). Often, researchers combine a variety of these and other methods to gain deeper insights into the gaming experience; at other times, the exact methods are not revealed. In light of this, I put forward a method encompassing gameplay analysis, autoethnographic research with a focus on the perspective of the player-researcher (Aarseth, 2003; Karppi and Sotamaa, 2012), and ethnographic research in the form of participant observation and semi-structured interviews. This methodology aims to address the complex relationships and behaviours that are at play throughout the gaming experience by incorporating both an overall design perspective and the player's behaviour and thought in the moment of play.

1.1 Research Questions

The main questions guiding this thesis focus on the development and maintenance of the relationship between game and player, as well as the ways in which this relationship informs the gaming experience. Specifically, two main questions underpin this research:

- How can the relationship between player and player-character be rethought in the context of player choice, emotion, and subjective experience, and how does this transform the way we think about contemporary video games?
- What are the driving factors behind the player's choice-making behaviour, and how does this behaviour intersect with the player's subjective experience, interpretation, and emotional engagement?

These questions are formulated to arrive at an in-depth understanding of the human and non-human behaviours that frame the gaming experience, focusing both on the different formal aspects of the player-game relationship, such as communication, cooperation, and competition, and the player-game interaction within the specific context of

choice-making and agency. In this, the subjectivity of the gaming experience and the impact of the player's understanding not only of their own actions, but also of their interpretation of characters and narrative are highlighted in their intersection with the player's behavioural patterns. In order to address these questions, the different facets of the player-game relationship and their role in the player's choice-making processes will be investigated. Fundamentally, the rethinking of the relationship between player and player-character inevitably leads to a consideration of which approaches and methods, both established and new, are needed to address the subjective and emotional dimensions of the gaming experience. This in turn leads to the formulation of a new game analysis method, which will be laid out in chapter 2 and demonstrated throughout the rest of the thesis.

1.2 Fundamental Concepts of Interactive Digital Narrative

In order to be able to conceptualise the player's behaviour within narrative video games and their relationship with the game itself, it is necessary to set out some of the concepts that underpin this thesis, many of which will be returned to in greater detail in conjunction with the analyses in the later chapters. This section outlines fundamental concepts of the medium of the video game, with a focus on the interplay between interactivity, narrative, and choice-making, all of which are closely related but different aspects of the gaming experience. Agency and choice-making in particular form an important part of this thesis as they are crucial in the relationship between player and video game. Following this, section 1.3 highlights the different elements of the player-game relationship by distinguishing between the experiential and cognitive modalities of the gaming experience.

1.2.1 Interactivity, Spatiality, and Narrative

The early years of game studies were in part informed by the debate between ludologists and narratologists, where the former camp foregrounds the formal rule-based structures of video games and the latter considers video games as a narrative medium, suggesting that fundamentally, the two formats do not mix well. This debate was caused primarily by theoretical and conceptual misunderstandings between the two groups (Frasca, 2003; Veugen, 2011) and focused on the interactive nature of video games. *Interactivity* here refers to the way in which the player is able to affect the game through the use of technology, i.e. 'the user's direct influence in navigating through the digital text' (Cheng, 2007, p. 16). It is important to note at this point that the term itself is not coherently defined, leading to some of the conceptual issues that underpinned

the debate in the first place. Stang (2019, par. 4) for instance argues that video game interactivity takes place in terms of fan cultures and the fans' relationship with the game developers, but that it does not seem to truly exist in a mechanical sense:

Videogame interactivity, and the sense of control that it elicits in players, is illusory. Player input causes the game system to react in a specific, pre-coded way and, given our current lack of true artificial intelligence able to adapt and generate content in reaction to unpredictable human behaviour, player choice is necessarily limited.

In the context of this thesis, Stang's notion of interactivity here seems to be conflated with agency, i.e. actual control over the outcome of a narrative. Although I acknowledge that video game content is pre-designed, my understanding of interactivity refers to the technical feedback loop between player and video game in terms of the player's input, the game's output, and vice versa. Interactivity does not presuppose anything about the *nature* of this influence – whether it is narrative, gameplay-related, or technical, or even the exact degree of control it affords –, but principally relates to the player's navigational freedom.

The idea of interactivity or freedom complicates the establishment of a coherent, compelling narrative in the traditional sense, which would require a high degree of authorial control (Ryan, 2009; Ip, 2011a). In order to assign overall narrative control to the game designers, the main narrative techniques in video games tend to borrow from other media (Atkins, 2003; Harvey, 2009), for instance in the form of cinematic sequences called cut-scenes, which, amongst other functions, are typically used to direct the narrative and to give contextual information that is relevant for both gameplay and the understanding of the story (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008). This technique is often criticised because the player is forced to relinquish agency to the game, thereby giving up an important part of their gaming experience for the duration of the cut-scene and causing a kind of temporal disruption (Juul, 2004).

Other scholars argue in favour of the cut-scene due to the different functions that it can contribute to the gaming experience, such as technical or narrative progression. Newman (2004, p. 74), for instance, argues that non-interactive aspects 'may be considered to be central to the videogame experience rather than merely peripheral or counter-productive' by fulfilling a variety of technical and narrative functions. Klevjer (2002, p. 195) also highlights that cut-scenes can fulfill a specific ludic function by providing information about the environment and characters that the player can use to plan out their next actions or movements, arguing that '[a] cutscene does not cut off gameplay. It is an integral part of the configurative experience. Even if the player is denied any active input, this does not mean that the ergodic experience and effort is paused.' In some cases, the need for both narrative direction and interactivity can be combined

through for instance the use of scripted events, in which the game takes control of the camera perspective to focus the player's attention to a specific area while the player is still in full control of the player-character (Dansky, 2007), or through the use of quick-time events, where the player needs to respond to certain prompts in a timely manner in order to achieve a specific effect or action within the cut-scene itself.

The discussion around the different functions of the cut-scene suggests that the pleasure of playing a video game is not necessarily related to having continuous agency, but can also be found in the negotiation of control between player and game. Further, Jenkins (2004, pp. 120-122) observes that the gaming experience is never *just* the ludic or the narrative experience, but that these modes intersect to tell stories in a new way:

If some games tell stories, they are unlikely to tell them in the same ways that other media tell stories. Stories are not empty content that can be ported from one media pipeline to another. [...] When you adapt a film into a game, the process typically involves translating events in the film into environments within the game.

The focus on environments conceptualises the video game as an inherently spatial medium, a spatiality that is based primarily on the medium's interactive structures. Indeed, Murray (1997, pp. 162-163) considers spatial navigation to be a feature of digital media in general, which offers a satisfying, pleasurable experience that consists of 'orienting ourselves by landmarks, mapping a space mentally to match our experience, and admiring the juxtapositions and changes in perspective that derive from moving through an intricate environment.' The spatial nature of the video game not only allows for the construction of narrative and fictional worlds through the use of the game's environment and interactive structures, but indeed places the environment and the spatial experiences of player and character at the centre of the story, leading Pearce (2004, p. 153) to describe game designers as 'not so much storytellers as context creators.'

In discussing the relationship between narrative and space, Jenkins (2004) highlights that there are four ways in which environmental storytelling can be used: evoked, enacted, embedded, and emergent narratives. *Evoked narratives* present a world that is already familiar to the player, for instance through other texts in a media franchise, but provide a fresh, new perspective of it. Here, an increased sense of immersion may be created due to the player's inherent familiarity with the fictional world, which draws on a kind of literacy that is informed by the player's previous experience of the story world and the paratextual material surrounding it (Harvey, 2009). Above all, the player is able to interact *with* the game environment, and therefore *enacted narratives* focus on the player-character's relationship with the game space.

Narrative information can be contained in the design of the game space as well through *embedded narratives*, relying on the player's ability to decipher and interpret clues in order to construct the game's backstory and to lend more credibility to the realism and coherence of the fictional world, making it into a *world* with a distinct history rather than a self-contained space within a game. By encouraging and necessitating the player's own involvement in the understanding of the story, these clues function both as sources of information to provide a context for play and as a means to create gaps that the player has to fill in. Wolf (2012, p. 125) refers to this as '*world gestalten*, the way in which a structure or configuration of details implies the existence of an imaginary world and causes the audience to automatically fill in the missing pieces of that world, based on the details that are given.' Finally, Jenkins (2004) discusses that games that do not contain a pre-designed story often contain *emergent narratives*, which are created through gameplay and the player's interaction with the space. These can be related to the concept of 'games of emergence' – as opposed to the narrative-based 'games of progression' –, in which the player is merely provided with a framework or platform through which they can engage with a comprehensive rule system (Juul, 2005).

None of these types of environmental narratives are entirely separate. The player is able to engage with the world-building that is triggered by embedded narratives precisely because they are *enacting* these narratives through the vehicle of the player-character, and the sense of familiarity that is the basis for evoked narratives relies heavily on the player's gap-filling and interpretation given that they need to integrate the game's depiction of the familiar world and narrative within the framework of the world that is being evoked. Jenkins's distinctions do however highlight fundamental aspects of the experience of game narrative by focusing on different types of player engagement.

In the context of this thesis, the sense of spatiality that is offered by video games is one of the core aspects around which the relationship between player and game revolves. In order to gain a deeper understanding of the different kinds of relationships that occur during the gaming experience, I draw on the properties of game space as proposed by Stockburger (2007, pp. 232-233), who distinguishes between five spatial modalities that make up the overall experience. The 'user space' describes the physical space in which the player exists, closely related to the 'kinaesthetic space' that describes the embodied connection between the player and the game space. Within the game, 'rule space' and 'narrative space' deal with the spatial properties that emerge from the game's rules and the narrative respectively, and the relationship between these two modalities determines the 'audiovisual representational space' as mediated by technology. The different modalities of the game space all contribute to its perception as a *physical space* that covers both the digital realm and the real world, and would not be possible without the interactivity that the medium offers. The spatial, physical, and embodied dimensions of the player-game relationship are further discussed in section 1.3.1.

The relationship between narrative and interactivity has always been complex, but so is the gaming experience itself. Newman (2004, p. 76) for instance argues that ‘as they invariably offer different types of gameplay and demand variegated modes of engagement, videogames do not offer a consistent experience of interactivity.’ Wesp (2014, par. 27) further suggests that the division of game and narrative is counterproductive in the first place, as it indicates a fundamental conceptual misunderstanding of the relationship between narrative and medium: ‘Even in texts where narrative is predominant, narrative is only ever delivered through the means of its medium, and never fills the imaginative or representational space created by a text. Videogames are not stories, but neither are novels.’

When considering interactivity and narrative, then, one needs to move beyond such fundamental oppositions and consider the way in which narrative does not only function *within the framework of* interactivity, but how it affects the player’s understanding of interactivity and agency, too. This approach allows us to recognise interactive structures as a core underlying characteristic of the medium while also acknowledging that a gaming experience is not *only* based on the interactive experience. The next section addresses agency as this intersection of interactivity and narrative.

1.2.2 Agency and Choice-Making

While interactivity refers to the underlying technical structures of the medium of the video game, *agency* refers to ‘the satisfying power to take meaningful action and see the results of our decisions and choices’ (Murray, 1997, p. 159). This agency can only be achieved *through* interactivity, but does not automatically result from it; an entirely chance-based game such as *Snakes and Ladders* for instance can be considered interactive as it requires the player to physically interact with the board, but does not offer any agency as the player is not able to make meaningful choices that influence the outcome of the game.

Agency can be understood as the point where a game’s rules and mechanics, i.e. gameplay, combine with the narrative context (Veugen, 2011), allowing the player to occupy a space of power and responsibility within the narrative itself. Murray (1997) further highlights the idea of ‘dramatic agency,’ which takes place when a satisfying relationship between a narratively motivated action and the response to this action is established. The exact degree of ‘freedom’ within agency is debatable however. As Carlquist (2002) argues, the freedom of the player is often illusory, and Veugen (2011, p. 219, emphasis added) stresses that ‘[g]amers want to have the *idea* that their actions are meaningful and influence what happens next, even though the overall outcome of the game stays the same.’ This indicates that creating an illusion of agency through the game’s feedback can to some extent be just as important as designing the structures that allow a high degree of agency or interactivity.

This thesis considers agency in two main ways. When referring to agency, I am primarily concerned with the idea of dramatic agency, which also includes the emotional agency that emerges from a relationship with the player-character; this type of agency is further discussed in section 1.3.2. However, the player is often asked to make choices that carry meaning not in a narrative sense, but in the sense of affecting gameplay. This can be as simple as making the decision to walk into a specific room as opposed to a different one, or as complex as making the choice to level up specific player-character stats, which will influence how the player-character is able to handle certain situations. As this is concerned with the kind of agency that arises from the player's engagement with gameplay mechanics instead of narrative or characters, I will use the term *technical agency* to refer to this type of interaction, focusing on the player's ability to manipulate the avatar, game space, and ludic dimensions of the game. Considering the nuances of agency in this manner is a significant step in understanding the different aspects of the player's behaviour and the way in which player and game are able to affect one another.

At this point it is important to further distinguish between agency and choice-making, both of which are closely related but should not be used interchangeably. Choices are a building block of agency – the player needs to make choices on a narrative or ludic level, through the interactive structures of the game, to be able to affect the game in the first place. However, different types of choices carry fundamentally different functions (Andreen, 2017) and lead to varying types or understandings of agency. The player's choices do not need to alter the result of the game completely for the resulting agency to be perceived as meaningful by the player. As Salen and Zimmerman (2004) observe, choices occur on a micro and macro level; the former consists of small-scale choices that occur in each moment of play, while the latter are large-scale choices that affect the game's overall narrative and result. This thesis considers choice-making in the sense of choice-making *practices*, i.e. the player's behaviour and rationale in making specific choices. The way in which the game presents and processes these choices determines the player's interpretation of their own agency.

1.3 The Human-Computer Relationship

The two-way relationship between the player and the video game and the ways in which this relationship is established and maintained throughout gameplay form a core concern of this thesis. Based on the previous discussions of interactivity, spatiality, and agency, I consider this relationship to consist of two main levels of engagement: ludic and narrative. The overarching gaming experience on both of these levels emerges from the 'collusion' (Giddings, 2009) between player and computer, a symbiotic feedback loop that is not based on a specific hierarchy. Instead, player and computer can be considered equal partners, whose interaction with one another brings about and

defines the gaming experience. In my understanding of the term, collusion describes the overall relationship between player and computer that informs all the other relationship levels and can be seen as the means by which the player-game relationship functions in the first place. This aspect of the gaming experience is primarily based on the interaction and (re)action between the entities.

The ludic relationship between player and video game is informed by the dynamics of interactivity within the context of spatiality. This relationship can be representational (based on the player-character's presence within the game world), embodied (based on the player's physical and quasi-physical relationship with the character and game world), or technical (based on the navigational properties of the non-narrative game space, such as navigating the menu by physically affecting technology in the real world). This level of engagement is primarily mediated through the player's interaction with technology and therefore deals with the real or imagined physicality of gaming.

The narrative relationship relates to the fictional part of the gaming experience and includes the narrative and emotional relationships between player, player-character, and fictional world. These aspects draw on theories of world-building and involvement, especially the notion of gap-filling as discussed by Wolf (2012). While the fictional part of the gaming experience is still mediated by technology, this level primarily deals with the narrative framework of the game and the player's interaction with and interpretation of it, and is addressed through a primarily mental or imaginative activity.

This section provides a brief theoretical framework of the aspects that inform the different levels of engagement in the player-game relationship and contextualises them within the scope of this study. In particular, it discusses embodiment, immersion, emotional agency, and world-building.

1.3.1 The Ludic Experience

For Stockburger (2007) as well as Jenkins (2004), embodiment is a particularly important aspect of the gaming experience. In Jenkins's writing, embodiment is most relevant for enacted and to some degree embedded narratives as described in section 1.2.1. In Stockburger's case it is particularly represented by the kinaesthetic space, although all spatial modalities come together to create a coherent experience, of which the physical aspect is only one part. The importance of embodiment as part of the gaming experience is highlighted by Järvinen (2002, p. 116) as well, who proposes the term 'point of perception' to describe 'the position from which the player perceives, i.e. both sees and hears, what goes on in the game environment.' In using a point of *perception* rather than a point of *view*, Järvinen acknowledges the role of the different modalities in the player's spatialisation process and emphasises the video game's status as an inherently

spatial medium. The player's quasi-physical relationship with the game space is conveyed by the avatar, which Klevjer (2012, p. 28) considers a prosthetic extension of the player's body that allows the player not only to act *within* the space of the game via the 'proxy' of the avatar, but also, in turn, to be affected *by* it:

In the moment of being captured by and channelled through the avatar, the body that is *here*, safely seated on the couch, will be rendered irrelevant in its objective dimension, as an object among other objects, in Merleau-Ponty's terminology — as that which is being touched.

The avatar establishes a direct link between game space and player: the player pushes physical buttons in the real world, which are instantly translated into certain actions that are carried out by the avatar within the game world. This link turns gaming into a primarily embodied experience – game *worlds* are created not only through direct narration (such as the aforementioned cut-scene), but first and foremost through the interaction with the game space as an actual space which the player enters and experiences vicariously.

The physicality of the player-game relationship gives rise to a specific type of engagement that is often described as *immersion*. The term has been widely used to describe the engagement with a variety of media and has, indeed, been conceptualised in different ways in game studies as well, fuelling some of the conceptual misunderstandings in the ludology-narratology debate addressed in section 1.2.1. The two core types of immersion that dominated the debate can be aligned with 'suspension of disbelief,' originally coined by the English poet Samuel Coleridge, and the psychological state of 'flow.' 'Flow' describes a kind of immersion that is both mental and physical. It is encouraged by mastering specific, realistic challenges by successfully following the rules of the system, thereby focusing one's attention entirely on the activity at hand and experiencing a type of temporal distortion (Csikszentmihalyi, 2002). 'Suspension of disbelief' is a term that is widely applied to different kinds of fictional works and describes a mental activity through which the player recognises and accepts the fictional world. In video games in particular, it can be described as 'the voluntary, temporary creation in response to textual stimuli of an imaginative space that transcends the text yet is constantly renewed through its progression' (Brown, 2012, p. 87), focusing on the player's ability to immerse themselves in the space in the game while at the same time remaining aware of the artificial nature of the experience.

Ermi and Mäyrä (2005) propose a model that acknowledges both of these types of immersion as part of the gaming experience. Their approach distinguishes between three types of immersion: sensory, challenge-based, and imaginative, where challenge-based immersion corresponds to flow and imaginative immersion corresponds to suspension of disbelief. Sensory immersion here relates to the audiovisual modality of a game

and is influenced by the technical affordances of the user space (Stockburger, 2007). This type of immersion requires less effort on the player's part and is therefore only partially game-dependent. Ryan (2009), too, distinguishes between 'ludic immersion,' which is related to gameplay, and 'narrative immersion,' which again can be divided into four different types. According to Ryan, the spatial and epistemic types of immersion are easy to achieve due to the interactive nature of the game environment. In her framework, temporal immersion depends on the player's feelings towards the narrative, such as curiosity, surprise, and suspense. Here, '[s]uspense is much more resistant to interactivity, because it requires long-range planning by the system and top-down management of the player's expectations' (p. 55). She argues that because the player is in control of the player-character, unknown effects tend to elicit a surprise rather than a suspense response. Ryan considers the fourth type of narrative immersion – emotional immersion – to be the most difficult one to achieve in the context of interactivity as it draws on the emotional connection that is established between player and player-character.

Calleja (2011) criticises the use of 'immersion' in video games, arguing that the term itself is over-used and can lead to confusion due to its application in different (non-interactive) media forms. As such, it does not quite account for the full interactive nature of the gaming experience: while involvement is a prerequisite for the player's presence or immersion within a game, and the player's attention is a prerequisite for involvement, a comprehensive framework of player experience needs to take into account the two-way relationship between player and game with a particular focus on the game space. Instead, Calleja proposes the term 'incorporation' to describe the player's presence within the digital environment. Incorporation functions in two ways simultaneously: on the one hand, the player treats the game space as direct and navigable, and on the other hand the player acknowledges their specific presence (as conveyed by the avatar for instance) within the virtual world. To further describe the concept of incorporation, Calleja proposes a player involvement model based on the six dimensions of kinaesthetic, spatial, shared, narrative, affective, and ludic involvement (pp. 43–44). This model is particularly useful in unpacking the relationship between player, game, and narrative: while it echoes the models of immersion proposed by Ermi and Mäyrä (2005) and Ryan (2009), the spatial and shared dimensions describe the interactive relationship in greater depth. The spatial involvement describes the player's interaction with the game space, whereas the shared involvement specifically describes 'the engagement derived from players' awareness of and interaction with other agents in a game environment' (Calleja, 2011, p. 43). This includes interacting with other players locally or online.

Calleja further develops the involvement model by distinguishing between macro and micro involvement. Micro involvement addresses the player's involvement during the

moment of gameplay, i.e. the immediate and direct interaction between the two entities. Macro involvement on the other hand takes place in the broader context of the gaming experience that is not limited to an individual session, but includes ‘issues of motivations and sustained engagement with digital games through the long-term [...] aspects of the six dimensions of involvement’ (p. 39). Therefore, it acknowledges the ways in which players are able to, and want to, return to playing a game. In the context of this thesis, macro involvement is particularly relevant when approaching the player’s construction of an interpretive framework.

Viewing the game as a physical experience both in the tactile and the imagined sense allows us to acknowledge the immediacy of the interactive experience and leads to an in-depth understanding of the learned and often intuitive nature of gameplay that dominates the ludic relationship between player and game. While the different views on the immersive experience feed into the way in which this very direct relationship is formed, the idea of ‘incorporation’ and the player involvement model proposed by Calleja (2011) provide the most comprehensive approach to this dimension of the gaming experience.

1.3.2 The Narrative Experience

The previous section broadly introduced the intuitive, embodied, and spatial engagement that occurs during gameplay and helps situate the player within the game world. This section focuses more specifically on the narrative aspects that inform the player’s emotional engagement with the video game as well as the player’s interpretive framework by discussing the concepts of player-character and world-building.

Video game narratives provide a context for the player’s actions, a reason why the player should be interested in pressing buttons in the real world that are translated into specific actions, movements, and meaning in the virtual space. As such, the narrative can be used to provide the player with a framework through which they can explore and understand the rules of the game, meaning that its function is to support, structure, and contextualise the act of playing itself by assigning narrative meaning to ludic goals (Pearce, 2004; Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008; Calleja, 2011). Beyond this, Veugen (2011, p. 220) observes that completion rates for narrative games tend to be higher than for games without a strong narrative, ‘suggest[ing] that narrative closure is a strong incentive that motivates gamers to play on.’

In the context of the ludology-narratology debate, video games have been criticised for a supposed inability to tell compelling stories, with their narratives often considered to be ‘essentially formulaic’ (Atkins, 2003, p. 55). Structurally they tend to fall back on the Hero’s Journey as coined by Campbell (1949), albeit with ‘a substantial skew

in the proportional representation of each act as compared to other conventional narrative forms' (Ip, 2011b, p. 235) to account for the medium-specific properties. The judgement of video game narratives as unrefined is debatable, particularly given the increasing complexity that can be observed in their innovative storytelling techniques and sophisticated environments (Zarzycki, 2016). The experience of a narrative video game comes not only from the quality of the story, but from the overall *relationship* between game and story. Ryan (2009), for instance, distinguishes between a 'narrative game,' where the story is there to support gameplay – suggesting it has a lower status in the overall hierarchy – and a 'playable story,' where the narrative emerges out of gameplay. A meaningful story, then, is generated not by the game itself, nor by the player's actions, but is found in the interstice *between* player and computer, between agency and gameplay (Carlquist, 2002). This thesis, then, focuses particularly on this space between player and video game and the ability of the two entities to create a meaningful gaming experience *together*.

The player-character comprises both ludic and narrative functions in the form of the avatar and the protagonist (Veugen, 2011). This means that the avatar has a functional role – acting as the player's physical representation in the game space as discussed in section 1.3.1 –, while the protagonist has a clear role within the narrative itself. This suggests that players do not necessarily need these two dimensions of the gaming experience, which Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al. (2008) describe as story and action levels, to correlate, as the player's ludic actions (situated on the action level) are only indirectly part of the narrative (on the story level). Extending this, the player-character can be considered the vehicle through which the player acts on both of these levels simultaneously in the game world, while at the same time not fully embodying either of them. These levels extend to the non-player characters (NPCs) that populate the game world as well, which according to Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al. (2008, p. 178) can be distinguished based on their specific function: characters can be part of the setting without any further gameplay function ('stage characters'), they can have a gameplay function without being part of the narrative ('functional characters'), or they can have an important function within the narrative as well as the gameplay ('cast characters'). Non-player characters are part of the 'shared engagement' which the player experiences during gameplay (Calleja, 2011) and are therefore important to take into account when analysing the player's emotional engagement as well as their choice-making behaviours within the interactive environment.

The emotional connection between player and (player-)character can be discussed in the context of diegetic emotions as represented by the characters and the emotions that are triggered in the player themselves. This relates to the previously discussed ideas of emotional immersion or engagement (Ryan, 2009; Calleja, 2011). Apart from the information conveyed by the narrative, which may cause a sense of empathy or

identification in the literary sense, the player's perceived agency contributes to the relationship between player and character, leading to a type of emotional agency (Kway and Mitchell, 2018). Kway and Mitchell observe that time plays an important factor in creating a deeper connection with the player-character, which in turn makes it possible to feel emotional agency in the first place: 'Players believe they have exercised agency because they have changed the way the characters behave as a result of choices they have made' (p. 237). Here, the choices that are most significant in shaping this relationship are primarily related to small-scale choices on the micro level (Salen and Zimmerman, 2004) as discussed in section 1.2.2.

Not only the player-character is established as time progresses, but so is the story world itself. The world of the game needs to provide sufficient depth in order to contextualise the character's actions and the narrative, increasing the player's emotional engagement with the game by offering them an environment that they can exist in through the player-character. Wolf (2012) talks about world-building in relation to 'world gestalten,' the narrative gaps that encourage engagement with a fictional world as discussed in section 1.2.1. This is best understood by considering Primary and Secondary Worlds, which Wolf adapts from Tolkien. Contrasted with the real Primary World that we live in, Secondary Worlds operate according to their own logic, which needs to be established by providing certain information, such as geography, cultures, or physics. Some information does not need to be given explicitly, as '[w]here the world's own logic does not dictate specific answers, gaps are usually filled with primary world defaults' (p. 130). Wolf argues that as there is a finite amount of information that can be given about a story world, fictional worlds are always necessarily incomplete, but they appear completed when the player fills in the gaps on a narrative or world level through speculation. Generally,

The more the illusion of a complete and consistent world can be maintained, the more audiences will be able to enter (and want to enter) the world vicariously, experience it, and complete the world-building process through extrapolation and gap-filling. (Wolf, 2012, pp. 138-139)

The player needs to invest some effort in order to construct their understanding of the story world. Filling in these gaps allows the player to establish their personal narrative and world frameworks that will share many characteristics with the official information provided by the game, but will also be impacted by the player's interpretation of the narrative events and their relationship with player- and non-player characters.

1.3.3 Collusion and Player Experience

During gameplay, player and computer can be understood to enter a relationship in which both participants are dependent on the actions and reactions of the other entity.

After all, ‘a game becomes a game when it is played; until then it is only a set of rules and game props awaiting human engagement’ (Calleja, 2011, p. 8). The player’s activity is necessary in order for the game to be played, but the gaming *experience* is based on the successful merging of the two.

Smethurst and Craps (2015, pp. 272–273) put forward the term ‘interreactivity’ as an alternative to interactivity to acknowledge the two-way engagement that takes place during gameplay, where ‘[t]he game reacts to the player’s input both on a moment-to-moment basis [...] and in the long term. [...] The player’s strategy can then be modified in response, with the game offering a different set of outcomes based on their renewed efforts.’ Interreactivity is a useful term in the context of the player-game relationship that informs this thesis, and as they go on to explain, it can appear to varying degrees depending on the level of control that the player has at a given moment. The notion of interreactivity extends the discussion of interactivity in section 1.2.1, and is crucial in achieving and communicating the different types of agency discussed in section 1.2.2.

While the concept of interreactivity does not quite address the ludic and communicative qualities that are at work during gameplay on both sides of the player-game relationship, it allows us to better understand how it is negotiated through gameplay and how this differs from other types of media. In framing the player-game relationship as ‘collusion,’ which removes the player as the primary focal point of study, Giddings (2009, p. 156) highlights the playful and cooperative features of gameplay:

The word has a ludic etymology (co-lusion), so to collude is not only “to work with another” or “act in concert with”, but also “to act in play”, to come together in, and as, play. The word does not in itself assume anything about the nature of the colluding entities, but indicates the video game’s material distribution of agencies and the positioning of agents, bodies, or part(icipant)s. The event is constituted by the coming together in play, the collusion of material and imaginary elements...

In the context of this thesis, the concept of collusion is used to understand the ways in which player and game work together and cooperate to achieve a coherent and meaningful gaming experience. As I consider the communicative nature of the player-game relationship, the gaming experience itself is based on the two modes of competition and cooperation, which ‘collaborate in synergy to the realization of the player’s videoludic experience’ (Ferri, 2007, p. 469). To gain an in-depth understanding of the workings of the player-game relationship, I investigate the way in which player and game are in communication throughout the interreactive process, and how this communication shapes not only the player’s interpretation of the experience, but also their behaviour at large, with a focus on the player’s ability to make choices.

The interreactive nature of the video game transforms the player's experience of the narrative by giving them active control over the agent(s) within the game. The degree of narrative control on the player's part is necessarily constricted, as 'the more active and the less constrained the user's role [...] the more problematic its integration into a well-formed narrative arc' (Ryan, 2009, p. 44). This in turn can lead to the impression of 'the player [...] *solving* a story instead of actively *creating* it' (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008, p. 182). However, regardless of the actual narrative control, both player and game take on active roles and engage in co-creation, or 'co-processing' (Aarseth, 1997), of the gaming experience. In this context, it is helpful to distinguish between the role of the narrative from a game design perspective and the player's actual experience of the story.

Through continued engagement with a video game, each player creates a unique game experience in relation to the game's ludic and narrative properties. This is not limited to the player's interpretive abilities alone, as the cognitive activity in video games can be understood as configuration rather than interpretation (Klevjer, 2002; Moulthrop, 2004). It does however still include interpretive aspects even if they do not represent the main mode of understanding for the player, for instance when the player assigns narrative meaning to goals as guided by the game's feedback (Cardona-Rivera et al., 2020). Calleja (2011) calls the player's subjective experience of the narrative an 'alterbiography,' referring to the story that is generated by each player individually through their interaction with the game. As Calleja discusses, the variations in possible alterbiographies is partially dependent on the way in which the game and its narrative are structured, for instance in the freedom that open-world games offer the player as opposed to more linear narrative design, and the alterbiography is not consistent even for the individual player, as it may change depending on the context of each gaming session.

The notion of alterbiography provides a basis for understanding and conceptualising the subjective framework that the player builds up as a consequence of the communicative aspects of the player-game relationship and highlights the necessity to take a closer look at the way in which players conceive of their own role within the space of the game, and how this understanding is manifested through their instinctive and deliberate behaviour. In the context of this thesis, the notion of alterbiography provides the basis for conceptualising the player's cognitive and emotional engagement with the game in the form of the altercharacter.

1.4 Thesis Structure

After the methodological framework for this research is laid out in chapter 2, this thesis is divided into two main parts. Part I, 'Identity, Experience, and Narrative,' is summarised in chapter 6 and demonstrates the framework of the subjective player experience by investigating how the close player-character relationship is formed through the simultaneous and at times conflicting processes of *merging* and *separating* player and player-character. Here, the ludic and narrative modalities of the player-character and their interplay with the player and their own notion of identity are highlighted. Chapter 3 focuses on the way in which the player is transported into the character's body through a shared sensory framework. As shown throughout the analysis, this merging of player and player-character tends to have ludic, rather than narrative, implications. In contrast, chapter 4 highlights the separation of player and player-character by focusing on the narrative devices and information management that lend the character a psychological, rather than purely narrative, dimension. Chapter 5 concludes this part of the thesis by showing how the player navigates the ever-changing terrain of player and character identity by focusing on the relationship between ludic and narrative foci, as well as the player's deliberate construction of the altercharacter.

This exploration of the player-game relationship that is strongly based in the narrative dimensions of the game is followed by Part II, 'Choice-Making Practices,' which is summarised in chapter 10 and conceptualises choice-making as a practice embedded within the behavioural framework that the player establishes both on the level of the individual game and in relation to the literacy that is built up through their engagement with other games. Taking a closer look at the way in which the player-game relationship functions within the context of choice-making, chapter 7 analyses how the game system communicates and interprets the player's agency. Here, a strong focus is placed on the way in which the game has the potential to shape player behaviour. With the game communication as a foundation, chapter 8 conceptualises the practice of choice-making by considering the player's choice-making rationales and how these function on the micro and macro levels of choice. Chapter 9 concludes the conceptualisation of the player's choice-making practice by analysing the player's emotional involvement with their own choice-making behaviours, as well as the different types of emotional involvement that emerge from the player's various types of agency.

Finally, chapter 11 concludes this thesis by providing a summary of its key arguments, findings, and contributions, both theoretical and methodological, and discusses potential avenues for future research.

Chapter 2

Methodology

Video game research is often divided into two main approaches, where ‘the two camps, one focused on understanding games through playing them, and one focused on observing actual players, represent two quite separate paradigms in terms of their player perspective, and [...] are not always living happily side by side’ (Aarseth, 2007, p. 131). Given the complexity of the video game as an *interreactive* medium (Smethurst and Craps, 2015) in which the player and the computer work together towards a coherent experience, video game analysis should ideally incorporate both of these perspectives. In this, it should acknowledge the subjectivity of the experience as well as the overall game design, as ‘[t]here is no reason for game studies not to embrace the playing subjectivity, to which it has an undisturbed access already via accepting playing as a valid method of research’ (Leino, 2010, p. 7). Rather than merely acknowledging and embracing subjectivity as part of the gaming experience, this thesis aims to establish how this subjectivity can be used as an explicit research *tool* as well.

This chapter presents the methodological considerations that underpin this thesis, drawing on the idea of microethology as proposed by Giddings (2009). While the method itself is similar to ethnography, the term ‘ethology’ is more suitable for the study of the *relationship* between player and computer and the behavioural patterns associated with this relationship, rather than focusing solely on the human in the equation. Although the design of the study focuses on ethology as theoretical foundation as it conceptualises both player and computer as equal participants in the gaming process or experience, the methodological discussions will continue to use the term ‘ethnography’ as I focus on complementing existing ethnographic methods with a stronger focus on the game-player relationship to account for the ethological components.

This thesis establishes an ethnographic/ethological approach to video game analysis that acknowledges the complexities of the player-game relationship by combining participant observation, semi-structured interviews, autoethnography, and textual analysis. In order to sufficiently discuss the methodological stance guiding this research, I

first present the different methods and the rationale for their use with a focus on the ethnographic perspective. This is followed by a more detailed description of the design of the study.

2.1 Methodological Framework

This thesis approaches video game research through the intersecting angles of the player's behaviour in the moment of play and their interpretation and narrativisation of specific gaming experiences. In order to be able to capture as fully as possible the dynamics that define the gaming experience both in and beyond the moment of play, the player's perspective is approached through ethnographic research as well as formal autoethnographic research. The different methods are synthesised through textual analysis informed by the position of the player-researcher. By combining these perspectives and methods, this thesis aims to provide comprehensive insights into the relationship between player and game as well as the role of the player's narrative and personal framework within their choice-making practices.

2.1.1 In the Moment of Play: Participant Observation and Autoethnography

Video game ethnography is often concerned with participant observation of virtual worlds (Boellstorff et al., 2012), where the researchers participate in order to observe specific aspects of these worlds, such as the analysis of worldness by Klasturp (2009). Other researchers, such as Rimington (2017), use participant observation to study specific aspects of player behaviour – in this case toxicity – in online games. Aside from virtual world analysis, ethnographic methods can also be used to study gaming on an everyday basis, either in condensed moments of play or long-term (Giddings, 2009; Thornham, 2016), for an individual player or a group of players. In considering different types of video game ethnography, Miller (2008) points out that apart from gaining information from fan communities and game designers, the researcher can also treat the game space as a real place in which fieldwork can take place. In short, an ethnographic approach can have many different applications in the study of video games; however, Boellstorff et al. (2012, p. 6) argue that ethnographic methods in general tend to be under-valued and often considered 'anecdotal or unscientific' in game studies.

This thesis takes the method of microethnography/microethology (Giddings, 2009) as a starting point and uses the conceptual framework of collusion to investigate the behaviours of player and computer. While Giddings proposes the term microethnography/microethology as 'a nonscientific, improvised, opportunistic approach to recording, describing, and analyzing brief moments of everyday technocultural activity' (p. 149), I extend this focus to a discussion of gaming as integrated within the participants'

typical gaming experience. By considering the player's self-observed behaviour in their everyday gaming practices, I acknowledge that '[g]ames are not played or experienced in a vacuum, but are contingent upon other relations, and other gaming experiences, which frame and produce the practice and meaning of gaming' (Thornham, 2016, p. 8). This means that in order to appropriately understand the ways in which player and game interact, one needs to look beyond the singular gaming experience, instead considering the cumulation of experiences and the player's overall engagement with gaming culture.

During the ethnographic part of this study, the player's gameplay was observed and recorded, after which the player's perspective was discussed in semi-structured interviews. My role as a researcher during the gameplay sessions was primarily observational, but held a small participatory function as well, which constitutes the framing of my position as participant observer as the participants were encouraged to discuss their gameplay throughout the session. This approach also acknowledges that gaming is not necessarily a solitary practice and involves strong social aspects as well. Playing a single-player game while another person watches is a common practice in the gaming community, where 'gamers are not only the people holding the consoles, but the people in the room: those encompassed in, framed by the game' (Thornham, 2016, p. 38). Nonetheless, it needs to be acknowledged that the gaming situation simulated in this study cannot be considered an everyday activity of play, such as those that Giddings (2009) aims to observe, given that participants were invited within the context of a research study and the sessions took place at a dedicated space for video game research at Winchester School of Art.

The combination of gameplay recordings and participant observation is proposed by Giddings and Kennedy (2008, p. 14) to address the issue that 'players are usually too engrossed to reflect on their experience and researchers studying other players find it hard to get any analytical purchase on their activities (as gameplay is so often characterized by little movement or comment on the part of the players).' As participants were encouraged to discuss their behaviour, thoughts, and feelings during their session, the insights gathered from the gameplay sessions are based on the factual gameplay that took place on screen, my observations of the player's behaviours, and the player's immediate responses to the game as they play to gain a more holistic picture of the experience.

Drawing on the notion of 'playing research' put forward by Aarseth (2003), Karppi and Sotamaa (2012) discuss the importance of the researcher's own practice of playing a game and highlight the lack of specificity about or systematic engagement with this research practice. Here, they challenge the idea that video game researchers should attempt to emulate the 'implied player' that follows the rules and expectations of the game in order to achieve a productive analysis (Aarseth, 2007). Instead, they treat the

experience of conducting playing research in relation to the player's individual experiences and analyse their different modes of engagement with the game, as well as their experimental and emergent attitude to gameplay. However, it should be noted that in addition to the 'implied player' perspective, Aarseth (2007, p. 132) considers '[t]ransgressive play [...] a symbolic gesture of rebellion against the tyranny of the game, a (perhaps illusory) way for the played subject to regain their sense of identity and uniqueness through the mechanisms of the game itself,' thereby acknowledging the importance of an experimental engagement through gameplay as well. The researcher's own experience and engagement with a game, then, is generally understood to be an important part of video game analysis due to the invisible mental processes that make up a large part of playing:

When others play, what takes place on the screen is only partly representative of what the player experiences. The other, perhaps more important part is the mental interpretation and exploration of the rules, which of course is invisible to the non-informed non-player. As non-players we don't know how to distinguish between functional and decorative sign elements in the game. (Aarseth, 2007, p. 3)

This notion underpins my rationale for conducting autoethnographic research as opposed to a more conventional textual analysis or close reading of the video games in question. On the one hand, conducting an in-depth autoethnography allows for comprehensive insights into the *experience* of the game, highlighting the practice of playing and the emotional component that a formal analysis of the different elements that make up the game would fail to account for. On the other hand, approaching playing research in a similar manner across the participants of the ethnographic study and myself as researcher provides a stronger link between the two data sets, which enables not only a comparative analysis but, more crucially, expands the initial results from the ethnographic study with my own experience of the same games on a larger scale than was possible with the participants. To maintain a coherent approach across the different perspectives, the autoethnographic part of the study involved the recording of my own gameplay as well. Here, I also made use of think-aloud procedures where appropriate, commenting on my experience of the gameplay as well as the narrative.

The explicit positionality of the player-researcher and their subjectivity also allows for an acknowledgement of the player's personal background and identity in ways that are not always possible to capture through ethnographic research. While the relationship between, for instance, gender identity, gaming, and gaming culture is approached in other studies, such as those by Hayes (2007), Thornham (2016), Schelfhout et al. (2021), or Kivijärvi and Katila (2022), discussions of gender and race are not a primary focal point of this thesis as it presents a small-scale study that primarily considers the engagement with the game as a text rather than investigating the overall gaming culture

surrounding it. Nonetheless, my experiences as a white, female academic and gamer inevitably influence my own practice of playing, as well as the nature of the connection that is formed with the player-character and the narrative in general. This relationship between identity and choice-making behaviours is discussed more specifically in chapter 5, but also plays a role in the relationship between player and narrative character as shown for instance in chapter 4.

2.1.2 After Play: Semi-Structured Interviews and Research Diary

While recordings can give greater insights into the actual gameplay, it is also necessary to consider the player's own view of their gaming experience. However, the player's account is not necessarily factually reliable as their understanding of the on-screen events, and even their own actions, may differ widely from what actually happened during gameplay, a discrepancy that Thornham (2016) notes for the participants in her ethnographic study as well. In spite of, or possibly *because* of such incongruities, the participant's own perspective is invaluable, as Boellstorff et al. (2012, p. 92) for instance recognise that '[w]hile there is an important difference between people's speech and action, this does not mean that what people say they do is insignificant. The meanings people give to their actions and the world around them form an essential component of understanding.' Thornham (2016, p. 22) also points out that the act of narrating a game experience can change the perception of the experience itself as it is 'fluid, mutable and open to change. [...] The event is also positioned in relation to further episodes so that there are always multiple temporalities going on.'

In the context of this study, this means that as the session progresses, the player's ludic and narrative frameworks adapt and events may be discussed or understood in a different light. As dramatic agency occurs when meaningful choices are made within the context of narrative (Murray, 1997), the player's changing understanding of the narrative, and of their own role therein, is crucial for the development of their choice-making practices as well as their relationship with the video game itself. The player's re-telling of their session captures 'the unique, session-specific played or traversed sequences of events' (Eladhari, 2018, p. 76) that are memorable, and can therefore be considered to contribute to the player's understanding of the narrative. Through the practice of re-telling, the player is asked to narrativise their previous experience and is able to further make sense of their experiences, assigning new meaning to them.

The changes in understanding and meaning that may take place through the process of narrativisation also highlight the necessity for capturing the player's perspective both *during* and *after* gameplay. Other scholars, such as Kway and Mitchell (2018) and Higgins and Howell (2020), approach empirical research by playing the recorded gameplay back to the participants and asking them to reflect on their choices and experiences at certain moments. While their studies provide interesting insights into player

behaviour, the players are likely to discuss their choices differently having already experienced their potential outcomes.

In the ethnographic study, the participant's meaning-making is addressed through semi-structured interviews, which took place immediately after the gameplay session (for interview structure and sample questions, see Appendix A). These interviews focused on the player's understanding of narrative, characters, agency, game mechanics, and game feedback, and acknowledged the player's interpretation of the events throughout the session. This may stand in contrast to the player's immediate reactions and musings *during* gameplay as the player was able to incorporate ludic and narrative developments in their discussion and to contextualise their choices within new insights. The technique of re-telling (Eladhari, 2018) has only been used explicitly with one participant, but all participants highlighted to some degree their own interpretation of in-game events and their actions.

In the autoethnographic study, I recorded my thoughts and reflections in a research diary at the end of each play session (see Appendix B). This document can be used to identify moments that made a strong impression on myself as a player. More significantly, it provides insights into my own interpretation of the narrative and characters, my changing relationships and priorities, and the various kinds of emotional involvement that occurred during gameplay or as a result of a session.

2.2 Study Design

2.2.1 Case Studies

The four video games selected for this study were chosen on the basis of genre, gameplay, and narrative conventions. Most of the games consist of a strong narrative- and choice-driven focus. The *Life is Strange* series is generally more linear and straightforward in its gameplay, but branches out into different endings, whereas *Detroit: Become Human* branches out on a much larger scale and can be completed in many different iterations with a large variety of different endings. *Horizon Zero Dawn* was chosen as an example of an open-world game and was used in opposition to the linear focus of the other case studies. Two participants played *Life is Strange 2* in order to gain insights into the difference in choice-making practices within the same game. The selection of the specific video game was made prior to each session with the participant's agreement.

FIGURE 2.1: *Life is Strange*. Max.

2.2.1.1 *Life is Strange*

Overview *Life is Strange* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2015) is an episodic adventure game whose gameplay consists of the player-character Max's ability to reverse short segments of time, thereby being able to change certain actions if the immediate outcome is unfavourable. The first episode introduces the gameplay dynamics and the overall setting. Max discovers her power to rewind time when using it during an altercation between the two students Nathan and Chloe, saving the latter from being shot. After this, Max continues to explore her power, which can be applied both in everyday settings (e.g. to change the outcome of a dialogue), or to alter major decisions. Throughout the remaining episodes, Max uncovers the mystery behind a missing student and encounters moral conundrums in relation to her newfound powers, which turn out to have an adverse effect on the world around her.

The section chosen for the ethnographic study is the beginning of the game, in which Max discovers how to use her powers and starts to find out more about the events happening on campus. For the autoethnography, all five episodes were played.

Player-Character Max (see fig. 2.1) is a teenager who has recently moved back to her home town to attend Blackwell Academy, a high school focused on art and science. She is shy and is presented as an overall relatable character who is overwhelmed with the implied responsibilities that come with her powers to rewind time. Throughout the game she reconnects with her former best friend Chloe and attempts to help her find out what happened to the missing student Rachel Amber, a close friend of Chloe's. The player continually gains insight into Max's private and social life and her interpretation of the in-game events through her diary and text messages that are added as the game progresses.

Rationale *Life is Strange* was chosen due to the emotional impact of the narrative and the innovative gameplay mechanism of rewinding time, which offers the potential for

an intriguing relationship between player and game on an emotional, moral, and temporal level. Apart from the emotional and moral aspects, the game was also chosen for the way in which it communicates choices and consequences to the player. Due to the rewind mechanism, the player is continually reminded of the fact that choices can be changed, and Max often talks about regretting certain choices and worries about the consequences. While players often have the choice to undo certain actions in other games as well by, for instance, re-loading a previous savegame, *Life is Strange* acknowledges this desire and organically narrativises it. The rewind mechanism highlights the relationship between player, game, and choices, and was therefore considered suitable for inclusion in this study.

2.2.1.2 *Life is Strange 2*

Overview *Life is Strange 2* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2018) is the third season in the episodic adventure game series, and although the game asks the player to indicate whether or not they had played *Life is Strange* and which ending they had chosen, the beginning of the game does not have any obvious overlap with the first season. The game revolves around the player-character Sean and his little brother Daniel. The beginning of the game depicts their family life with their father until a fight between the boys and their neighbour escalates. The situation results in both the neighbour's and their father's death, with the latter being shot by a police officer following an unidentified explosion. As the brothers are wanted by the police after this incident, they run away and have to learn how to fend for themselves, while also discovering that Daniel has supernatural powers which caused the explosion in the first place.

The section chosen for the ethnographic study is the beginning of the game and ends shortly after the father's death. The autoethnography includes all five episodes of the game.

Player-Character Sean is a highschool student living with his father and his brother Daniel (see fig. 2.2). They appear as a tight-knit family and throughout the first episode it becomes clear that they take care of each other well, despite the usual bickering amongst siblings. Sean is protective of his little brother and takes care of him after they run away following the fatal incident with the neighbour. He is an overall reliable character, torn out of his everyday life and trying to make the best of the situation while looking after Daniel.

Rationale *Life is Strange 2* was chosen to investigate a different episodic adventure game, one that does not contain the specific temporal mechanics of *Life is Strange*. Again, the game communicates to the player directly that certain choices will have



FIGURE 2.2: *Life is Strange 2*. Sean and Daniel.

consequences in the course of the game, although this message only appears after the long prologue. The dynamic between Sean and Daniel makes the game a particularly interesting object of study, as the player-character is able to hide certain things from his brother and his overall actions are reflected in Daniel's behaviour. The game was incorporated in this study due to the dynamic between the characters and the strong focus on story and character development.

2.2.1.3 *Horizon Zero Dawn*

Overview *Horizon Zero Dawn* (Guerrilla Games, 2017) is an open-world action adventure game set in a post-apocalyptic world that has been taken over by machines. In this world, humans mostly live in tribal structures and consider technology dangerous. The game revolves around the player-character Aloy, who is tasked with finding out more information about a new threat the tribe – and the world at large – is facing due to corruption and aggression of the machines.

The section chosen for the ethnographic study takes place a few hours into the game following a major attack on the tribe. This section was chosen because the game becomes considerably more open at this point and offers the player more choices regarding where to go and what to do. Due to the scale of the game, a playthrough of the entire game was not feasible for the autoethnographic study. Instead, the autoethnography follows the first 19 hours of the game.

Player-Character Aloy (see fig. 2.3) was cast out from her tribe as a newborn due to her unknown origin, which becomes a central part of the plot as the game progresses. Raised by the outcast Rost, she starts training to participate in a trial called the Proving to re-join the tribe and find out more information about her background, particularly the identity of her mother. Shortly after she wins the Proving, the tribe is attacked and Rost sacrifices himself to save Aloy. Aloy is given the title of Seeker, which grants her the authority to leave the tribe and find out more about the attackers and the mystery



FIGURE 2.3: *Horizon Zero Dawn*. Aloy.

surrounding her unknown mother. The game gradually uncovers the events that forced mankind to return to tribal structures and to reject advanced technology, which tie in with the threat that the world is facing anew. Aloy is headstrong and competent, but possesses little knowledge of the world outside of the area that she grew up in. The player learns about the world as Aloy's own understanding of it increases.

Rationale *Horizon Zero Dawn* was chosen as an example of an open-world game, which provides the player with a high degree of freedom. As such, the player is offered a variety of different choices that are not present in the other case studies – for instance navigational choices, character development through levelling up specific skills, or which quests to follow. The game is the first in the *Horizon* series and therefore does not require any prior knowledge, while at the same time presenting an interesting multifaceted world. It relies heavily on the exploration of the game world and offers the player various side-quests in addition to the main storyline. The gameplay also revolves around Aloy's focus, a wearable device that augments reality and provides important information about the surroundings as well as the enemies. The focus plays an important part in the story as well and offers the game an interesting way of relaying information through an interface that is a natural part of the player-character's world. The game was chosen for this study primarily due to its use of interface in combination with open structures and a strong character.

2.2.1.4 *Detroit: Become Human*

Overview *Detroit: Become Human* (Quantic Dream, 2018) is an adventure game set in 2038 Detroit and introduces life-like androids as widely available workforce, leading to a mixed public reception. While society relies on androids for numerous types of labour in many sectors, they have also replaced many human workers, in turn increasing unemployment. Androids do not have any legal rights as they are considered objects instead of persons and are segregated from humans, leading to for instance separate entrances or android-only areas on public transport.



FIGURE 2.4: *Detroit: Become Human*. Connor, Kara, and Markus.

The section used for the ethnographic study consists of chapters 6 through 9, in which Connor discovers the whereabouts of a missing deviant and interrogates him, and Kara and Markus break their programming when faced with traumatic situations. The autoethnographic study includes a full playthrough of the game.

Player-Characters Throughout the game, the player experiences the story through the eyes of three different android player-characters: Kara, Markus, and Connor (see fig. 2.4). Kara is a housekeeper for her abusive owner Todd. Her story begins when she is picked up from the store after she has been repaired and her memory was reset. The player soon discovers Todd's violent and aggressive behaviour towards Kara and his daughter Alice, and finds evidence that Todd has broken Kara in the past, leading to her repair and memory reset before being returned to his household. When Todd's behaviour escalates towards his daughter, Kara breaks her programming to flee the country with Alice. Her storyline is focused on the mother-daughter relationship that the two characters slowly develop.

Markus is a companion and domestic help for Carl, a painter who has lost the use of his legs. The relationship between Carl and Markus is close and Carl is eager to help him explore his creative side, treating him like a son rather than a possession. One day, Carl's estranged drug-addicted son Leo breaks in to steal from Carl and ends up attacking Markus, jealous of their relationship. The attack causes Markus to break his programming, resulting in either Leo's injury or Carl's death, and is shot by the police upon their arrival. He awakens at a junkyard and fixes himself before looking for Jericho, a hiding place that has been established by other deviant androids. Markus soon becomes the leader of the deviants and embarks on a quest to bring freedom to the android population by appealing to humans to see them as persons instead of objects.

Connor is an android police investigator. He is a prototype, as law enforcement has not integrated androids into their workforce yet. He is partnered with Hank Anderson to investigate crimes committed by deviants, including Kara and Markus. Hank continually shows himself to be unwilling to work with Connor and overall has a very hostile attitude towards androids, but throughout Connor's storyline there is a possibility for the two to become friends. Over the course of the game, Connor's investigation of crime scenes and his interaction with deviants and humans allow him to uncover the

whereabouts of Jericho and learn more about his own nature and programming. Connor is a deciding factor in the overall outcome of the narrative as it becomes possible for him to side with the deviants and break his programming himself in the later stages of the game.

Rationale *Detroit: Become Human* has a high level of complexity in terms of narrative and gameplay. Moving between the intersecting storylines of the different player-characters, the game is divided into 32 chapters, each of which contains decisions that impact the game's overall outcome and the character's individual outcomes. It is possible for the player-characters to die permanently, or fail in various other ways – one of Kara's possible outcomes is being reset and enslaved, for instance. A flowchart is displayed at the end of each chapter, bringing into focus the way in which different choices may lead to a different outcome. Here, choices that have not yet been explored remain blank, adding to the replay value. It is further possible to replay individual chapters, with the option to either save the new outcome or to stick with the original one. This dynamic is helpful to investigate the ways in which the player interacts with the video game. In addition to moral reflections around the aspects that make up a person, the game further conceptualises the human-computer relationship on a meta level. Occasionally, when the game is loaded in a future session, the female android named Chloe that takes over the functions of the game's menu talks to the player, for instance asking questions about the player's opinion on androids or commenting on in-game events. On first completion of the game, Chloe asks if the player will set her free, and if met with agreement, she will not return for subsequent replays.

The decisions the player has to make in *Detroit: Become Human* are not only narrative or character decisions; they have a strong moral component as well as they force the player to re-evaluate their own notions about humanity and sentient life, which may lead to a strong emotional engagement. In addition, the existence of three player-characters whose narratives occasionally intersect is interesting when investigating choice-making practices, as success in Connor's storyline could potentially lead to the capture or death of the others. The player therefore has to develop some awareness of their own choice-making rationales and practices. The complex choice structures of the game, as well as its emotional, narrative, and moral depth, are the primary reasons for including the game in the study.

2.2.2 Ethnographic Study

The ethnographic study was conducted in 2019 (ERGO number 45722) and used participant observation and semi-structured interviews with the aim of investigating choice-making practices in narrative video games. A secondary aim of the study was to develop a thorough methodological framework for ethnographic video game analysis.

TABLE 2.1: Games and Participants

Game	Participant	Time Played
<i>Life is Strange</i> (PC)	Participant 2	1:30 hours
<i>Life is Strange 2</i> (PC)	Participant 1; Participant 3	45 minutes; 1 hour
<i>Horizon Zero Dawn</i> (PS4)	Participant 4	1:15 hours
<i>Detroit: Become Human</i> (PS4)	Participant 5	1 hour

The study was conducted with a total of five participants (see table 2.1 for an overview of the participants and their respective games).

The study itself consisted of two parts: the gameplay session and the interview session. The gameplay sessions typically lasted 45–60 minutes, although Participant 3 requested additional time to engage with the game more thoroughly. The semi-structured interview took place directly after the gameplay session and dealt with the choice-making experiences and rationales during this particular gaming experience and the participant's typical gaming behaviour outside of the study. The gameplay itself was video-recorded, and mine and the participant's voices were recorded during both parts. The choice to record the gameplay itself, in addition to taking notes and discussing gameplay in the semi-structured interview, was made to address the elusiveness of gameplay as discussed in section 2.1.1.

The study took place in the Office for Postdigital Research at Winchester School of Art, using Open Broadcaster Software (OBS) to record gameplay. While Steam games were able to be captured by the software directly, PS4 Remote Play was used to record PlayStation4 gameplay with the same software. In order to ensure sufficient coverage, the participant's voice was recorded using headset and laptop, and my voice was recorded using a dictaphone. Additionally, a mobile phone was used as a backup recording device in case of technical issues. After each session, the two audio files were merged with the gameplay recording in order to be able to retain a comprehensive record of the session to use in the analysis.

The five participants – four female, one male – were recruited from my own social and academic circles ranging from loose acquaintances to close friends; only one participant was largely unfamiliar with me at the time of the study. All participants possessed an academic background, but none of them were involved in game studies specifically. Most of the participants considered themselves to be frequent gamers, apart from Participant 2 who had very little gaming experience.

2.2.3 Autoethnographic Study

The autoethnography of the four games took place between August and October 2020, allowing for a substantial amount of playtime for each of the games. *Life is Strange*,

TABLE 2.2: Autoethnography – Overview

Game	Research Period	Time Played	Research Entries
<i>Life is Strange</i>	17-21 Aug. 2020	18:28 hours	6
<i>Life is Strange 2</i>	14-23 Sept. 2020	19:19 hours	6
<i>Horizon Zero Dawn</i>	25 Aug. - 7 Sept. 2020	18:48 hours	8
<i>Detroit: Become Human</i>	8-16 Oct. 2020	12:28 hours	6

Life is Strange 2, and *Detroit: Become Human* were played in their entirety. This was not possible in the case of *Horizon Zero Dawn* due to the scale of the game, but the playtime for it in this study was comparable to that of the other games (see table 2.2). Each of the gameplay sessions, which were recorded in the same way as the sessions in the ethnographic study, was followed by an entry in the research diary (see Appendix B). The research diary contains a plethora of in-depth impressions, including reflections on specific and impactful events that happened during the session, my personal interpretation of them, the changing relationships between myself, the characters, and the video game in general, my emotional responses triggered by the game, my future plans and goals for the game, and technical issues and their impact on my gaming experience. Here, I also reflect on the knowledge that I had of the games prior to conducting the autoethnography.

2.2.4 Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic

As with many research projects in the past years, the COVID-19 pandemic had a significant impact on the course of this study. After conducting the initial ethnographic study in 2019, a follow-up study was planned to take place in 2020. This study was designed to analyse more deeply how the player's relationship with the video game developed and changed through prolonged engagement with a video game, as well as the impact of player interpretation and memory on their choice-making behaviours. To this end, the follow-up study was supposed to be divided into four session taking place across a period of 2-3 months. In these sessions, the participants were expected to play *Detroit: Become Human* or *The Witcher 3*, with each approximately 90-minute session finishing with a semi-structured interview. Each session would be preceded by the player's retelling of their previous gameplay, utilising the technique discussed by Eladhari (2018) that was already applied successfully in the initial study.

Given the restrictions of the pandemic, it was no longer possible to conduct this follow-up study. In order to produce a second data set to correspond to the findings from the initial study, the decision was made to replace the second in-person study with the autoethnographic study instead. This directed the focal point of this thesis away from player memory and interpretation, focusing instead on the different communicative and emotional layers of the gaming experience as explored in the remainder of this

thesis. The change in direction also allowed me to strengthen the methodological aspects of this thesis by focusing on establishing the in-depth games research method that forms one of my core contributions.

2.3 Analysis

Section 2.1 shows that in order to understand the different facets of the gaming experience, we need to consider on the one hand the observed behaviours and interactions that take place during gameplay, and on the other hand the player's interpretation and understanding of the experience itself. The former is comprised of notes taken during observation and the analysis of recorded gameplay, including potential comments that the player makes while playing. The latter is captured in the semi-structured interviews in the ethnographic study and the research diary in the autoethnographic study. This provides a wealth of data with a focus on the experiences that take place both in the moment of play and in the context of the overall study.

According to Fernández-Vara (2014), due to methodological and theoretical incoherences, video game analysis often tends to be less nuanced than analysis of, for instance, film or literature. For this reason, she proposes a model of textual game analysis that focuses on the contexts of play and production, a general overview of the game, and the analysis of formal (primarily ludic) elements. At the same time, she emphasises that video game analysis needs to address not just the formal elements of the text, but also 'how players engage with the text at different levels: how players understand the rules, and follow or break them, how players create goals for themselves, how they communicate with each other, to name but a few' (p. 7). Noting that game analysis is mostly concerned with *either* the game as a text, leading to an analysis of the game's content and its cultural representations, *or* with the player's experience in the form of experiments or interviews, Consalvo and Dutton (2006) propose a more specific methodology to guide textual analysis. Their model includes the study of object inventory (including aspects such as interaction possibilities and use), interface study (the information communicated to the player via the game's interface and various menus), interaction maps of dialogue and other game choices, and gameplay logs, which involve details of the ways in which the the player interacts with the game and its rules and what gameplay actually looks like. The methodological template aims to provide 'a way to make the research thorough, without losing those aspects of games – play and emergence – that make them the dynamic artefacts of culture that they are' (par. 43).

The methodology put forward by Consalvo and Dutton (2006) provides a helpful guide for video game analysis; however, it does not fully acknowledge the individual engagement of the player, or player-researcher, and seems to be mostly concerned with the

perspective of the implied player and the textual status of the video game. Nonetheless, the different levels of textual analysis highlighted here are useful for structuring the analysis of the gameplay recordings. Following the ethnographic traditions that my methodology draws on, specific moments of gameplay are captured as ‘thick descriptions’ (Geertz, 1973), which include not only the player’s gameplay actions, but also the audiovisual information provided by the game, such as the interface, which for the purpose of this thesis is approached as a point of contact and communication between game and player. The thick descriptions form the basis for analysis, which integrates the player’s reflections and, where appropriate, a comparison with other players. Where appropriate throughout this thesis, the thick descriptions precede the analysis in the form of vignettes to paint a more in-depth picture of the game and overall experience.

In order to allow for a coherent analysis across the different datasets, the gameplay and interview sessions were transcribed for the ethnographic study, after which they were annotated and coded thematically using NVIVO. To make the analysis more transparent, gameplay and interview sessions were coded in different documents. For the autoethnographic study, the research diary was coded. Based on the coding and an analysis of the research diary, relevant moments were selected for further in-depth study.

The codes were determined by an initial top-level review of the ethnographic data, which brought to light the factors that were most vivid and recurring across participants. The codes underwent another review after the autoethnographic study, which flagged up the final four codes of ‘perceived failure,’ ‘personal objectives,’ ‘physical and sensory,’ and ‘technical difficulties.’ The ethnographic data was then re-visited in light of these new factors. In the end, this led to 13 thematic codes which were used to investigate gameplay and choice-making behaviours more closely, each comprising a number of different perspectives:

Agency This code deals with meaningful effects of choices or the lack thereof, short- and long-term effects, technical or perceived agency, and feelings of responsibility.

Choice conflict This code investigates the discrepancies of different aspects of agency, including the conflict between the player’s intentions and the result of an action, difficult decisions, and different layers of choices, such as ludic, narrative, or personal. It also investigates the clash between player and game objectives.

Choice-making rationale This code specifically highlights the player’s reasoning for making specific choices. The reasoning does not need to be explicitly stated and can therefore be a conscious or unconscious rationale or guideline for choice-making.

Game communication This code refers to the way in which the game is able to communicate with the player and vice versa, and includes the interface, the game's responses to player input, and communication issues between game and player.

Orientation This code investigates the player's orientation, both spatially and in the context of the 'choice space,' i.e. the player's navigation through different choice options, including the player's extrapolation and speculation of events and consequences and the player's familiarity with the game and its world, or a lack thereof.

Emotional response This code highlights both positive and negative emotions, which can be directed towards a specific situation, a character, or the game itself.

Gameplay This code investigates the ludic aspects of the gaming experience, including the game's controls and potential difficulties with gameplay, as well as the impact of gameplay issues on the overall experience.

Player-character relationship This code refers to the explicit relationship between player and player-character as well as player and non-player-character, focusing on both the ludic and the narrative aspects of these relationships.

Narrative engagement This code refers to the player's ability or interest to engage with the game's background, the world, and the characters, focusing both on the player's direct engagement via exploration as well as the player's general interest in the narrative.

Perceived failure Related to both agency and the player's emotional responses, this code highlights instances where the player experiences a sense of failure as a direct result of their own actions within the game.

Personal objectives This code investigates the player's personal goals that drive their engagement with the game. These objectives can be of narrative or ludic nature, and are not pre-determined by the game itself.

Physical and sensory This code highlights the sensory impact of the game on the player, e.g. reactions caused by controller vibrations or sound.

Technical difficulties This code investigates the occurrence of technical issues that go beyond simple difficulties with control, such as connection issues, and the impact of these issues on the experience as a whole.

These codes were used when the player voiced opinions on an issue during the game-play or interview / research diary, and when the issues could be observed during game-play itself regardless of the player's explicit acknowledgement of the related issues. Using the same codes for both studies provided a thematic coherence that allowed me to categorise and draw connections between the two sets of data, giving me the opportunity to complement the analysis of the ethnographic data with the autoethnographical data and vice versa.

The remainder of this thesis is divided into two main parts. Part I, 'Identity, Experience, and Narrative,' explores the development of the relationship between player and game via the player-character, focusing first on the embodied aspects of the experience before investigating the narrative character and, finally, the negotiations of player and player-character identities. Part II, 'Choice-Making Practices,' explores the player-game relationship on the basis of agency, communication, and emotional engagement, taking a more in-depth look at the different aspects of player behaviour that allow the conceptualisation of choice-making as a practice. Throughout these chapters, the ethnographic and autoethnographic data is explored in tandem, which allows for a more holistic understanding of the gaming experience.

Part I

Identity, Experience, and Narrative

Chapter 3

Embodied Relationships

3.1 Introduction

This thesis is concerned with the player-game relationship in light of player choice, emotion, and subjective experiences. In order to establish a comprehensive framework of the player-character relationship that lies at the core of the gaming experience, this part of the thesis sets out the initial construction of the bond between player and player-character. The notion of the player-character itself however is not straightforward or clearly defined; in fact, video game characters are multimodal entities fulfilling a variety of different functions that work in conjunction with and overlap one another, but which can often be found to be in contradiction with one another as well. The player-character is considered to be the ‘contact point between the player and game’ (Lankoski, 2011, p. 306), and is informed by both ludic and narrative characteristics. In order to investigate the way in which the player-character functions, a distinction both in functionality and player-character relationship needs to be made between the avatar as the on-screen token, the narrative character as the protagonist of the story (Veugen, 2011; Klevjer, 2012), and the player-character combining both ludic and narratives modes with player interaction.

During gameplay, the player controls the avatar as they would use a tool, but the ludic relationship goes beyond this basic functionality. The player affects the space of the game *through* the character, but the avatar is also the entity that gives the player access to the game world in the first place. Calleja (2011, p. 61) considers the avatar a conduit of the player’s *presence*, stating that ‘[c]ontrolling a single avatar creates a more direct link between the player and the in-game events.’ The avatar translates the rules and properties of game space and events to the player, and is the point of reference through which the player constructs their impression of the different aspects of the game space.

The combination of interactivity, i.e. the player’s ability to affect the game space and be affected by it in a direct way through navigation and other means of interaction,

and the player's vicarious inhabiting of the game space through the body of the avatar leads to the player's understanding of the game space as a real perceptible space as previously discussed in section 1.3.1. As shown in this chapter, the avatar's capacity of embodiment and spatialisation is a crucial aspect of the construction of the instinctive relationship between player and player-character. This relationship is mediated by technology: the player's movement in the real world is transmitted to the ludic space of the game through controller or mouse and keyboard, which in turn is translated into both ludic and narrative meaning by the avatar. The avatar therefore becomes a direct extension of the player's various identities that dominate play, which will be further discussed in chapter 5. This gives the player a *prosthetic* kind of agency (Klevjer, 2012) in which the avatar is not only an extension of the player's self in the cognitive and emotional sense, but also of their physical body, thereby turning them into 'inhabitable protagonists' (Isbister, 2016, p. 11).

Focusing primarily on the player-character relationship as embodied by the avatar, this chapter lays the foundation for the construction of video game narrative in conjunction with interactivity, focusing on the way in which spatialisation and embodiment enable the player to affect the space of the game in a way that makes them emotionally involved and highlights their responsibility over their and the player-character's actions. In particular, it analyses and discusses the *sensory* framework that is shared between player and player-character, encouraging a direct and immediate relationship between player and game.

3.2 Shared Sensory Experiences

I am watching my participant start Life is Strange. They are attentively focused on the screen, reading the message that explains that choices have narrative consequences in this game. The screen goes black, and with a sudden clap of thunder the game opens on a stormy scene: the lightning illuminates the leaves of a tree, and the screen goes black again, only to show another streak of lightning bathe the dark forest in a bright light. Taken aback by the sudden noise and the controller's rumble in time with the thunder, Participant 2 gasps, 'Oh, it shook! That's cool!' and yelps at the next thunderclap, laughing at their own reaction. 'Thunder,' they mumble, mesmerised as the screen flickers between black and flashes of lightning a few more times before zooming in on the figure of a girl lying face-down on the ground, in the rain. The girl wakes up and raises her head to stare straight at the camera. As she is looking around, she slowly gets up, looking dazed. 'Where am I? What's happening?' It is clear that the voice-over represents her thoughts – her mouth is not moving. 'I'm trapped in a storm?' she continues. 'How did I get here? ...and where is "here"?' The scene now shows a bird's-eye view of the girl and her surroundings, although not many details of the forest can be made out in

the dark and stormy night. Standing up and noticing a lighthouse, she explains that she will be safe if she makes it there. The camera pans behind the girl, smoothly settling on a perspective just behind her, right off the centre of the screen. A sign reads 'Lighthouse' in stark, white letters, an arrow pointing to the left, up the path she is standing on.

Nothing happens for a few moments while my participant is still staring at the scene. 'You have control now,' I say. They nod – 'Oh, right' – then start using the control sticks while explaining that they had just been waiting for the story. I briefly explain the basic controls to help them navigate their surroundings. 'Thank you, I was just caught up in the scenery,' they say as they try out the controls, trying to control the camera and the player-character's movements at the same time. 'Go forward, you can do it,' they tell the screen encouragingly, and after a few attempts they manage to get a better grasp of their relationship between the two control sticks, situating the camera behind the character again and moving forward. 'Let's go up to the lighthouse. Let's do it,' they say, this time with more determination. As they move the player-character up the steps to the lighthouse, they comment on the scenery, which they find appealing. The girl is almost at the top of the hill now, and the voice-over says, 'Come on Max, you can make it...' The player echoes the encouragement, letting out a satisfied 'Yes!' when they reach the lighthouse. Walking towards a bench overlooking the cliff, they comment on the familiarity of the scenery, making an 'Ow!' noise when the controls are getting more difficult to manage.

Suddenly the game takes control again. We can now see the girl – Max – walking towards the edge of the cliff, the storm blowing across the sea, pieces of debris flying through the air. 'Woah,' the participant says, then, seeing how close Max is getting to the edge of the cliff, exclaims 'Stop – moving!' They sound relieved when the camera closes in on Max again, who has now stopped and is looking up in awe at the approaching tornado – a sentiment that the participant echoes. Suddenly the focus is drawn to a rowboat that is launched out of the tornado, crashing against the lighthouse with both participant and Max exclaiming their surprise. The controller is rumbling violently. Max looks up, the camera situated behind her and directed upwards. We see the boat fall towards us. Both Max and the participant let out a short scream, then the scene fades to black.

Using only a few straightforward techniques, the beginning of *Life is Strange* starts building a very direct relationship between player and video game. Here, both player and player-character find themselves in an unusual situation – a situation of which Max has just as little understanding as the player. Since this is the very beginning of the game, there is no context provided yet except for the developer's beginning message emphasising the importance of the player's choices: 'Life is Strange is a story based

game that features player choice, the consequences of all your in game actions and decisions will impact the past, present and future. Choose wisely...' This is immediately followed by the opening of the nightmare scene, which evokes a visceral, physical response from the player with a loud thunderclap, the shock of which is transferred to the player's body with the rumble of the controller. The game draws the player into the world of the game with the initial focus on the environment itself: flashes of lightning reveal the scene in the forest, offering the player a first foothold in the game world.

In the first instance, then, the connection between Max and the player is of a physical nature. The player knows nothing of Max's character so far, but their physical hurdles are mirrored to an extent. As highlighted in chapter 1, playing a video game is an inherently spatial experience in which the player cognitively maps themselves onto the world of the game itself, allowing them to be physically present in a specific location in space and time through the vehicle of the avatar (Juul, 2004; Dubbelman, 2013). Most games will have visual aids available to help with the player's orientation within the space of the game, such as maps and location markers, but this is not the case for every game. Indeed, Calleja (2011) highlights that the risk of getting lost leads to a stronger spatial involvement on the player's part in a similar way in which the possibility of failure is an essential aspect of agency.

The player's cognitive transportation of themselves into the avatar's body, combined with the game's spatialisation techniques such as sound and the use of off-screen space, allows the player to adapt a Point of Perception instead of a more limited Point of View with a focus on their own position within the space, influenced by the different modalities of the game space (Järvinen, 2002; Stockburger, 2007). The player's acceptance of the game space as a three-dimensional space that can affect the player and be affected by them does not mean that the player is likely to misunderstand the virtual nature of the game space – they remain aware of the game's status as an artefact –, but that the player acknowledges the space as a viable space in which they can imagine themselves to be present. Space is not merely viewed, but *experienced* and mapped out, and is therefore a prerequisite for the embodied dimension of gameplay. The player is then able to affect the space of the game through the specific relationship between the player's physical actions and gestures and events within the space of the game via symbolic, mimetic, or symbiotic inputs (Ryan, 2009; Calleja, 2011). Acknowledging and even highlighting the spatiality of the gaming experience, then, is a useful tool to draw the player into the game, make them an active participant, and demonstrate the embodied connection with the avatar.

In the above scene, it is only after the initial setting is established *spatially* that the player meets the player-character. The player is given access to Max's thoughts in her voice-over, and her gaze at the camera is akin to a breaking of the fourth wall, invoking the feeling that Max is looking at the player directly (see fig. 3.1). While communicating with the player in this direct manner and evoking an 'illusion of intimate distance'



FIGURE 3.1: *Life is Strange*, Episode 1, Chapter 1: 'Nightmare'. Max looks directly at the player.

(Isbister, 2016, p. 7), the game also makes clear that Max is not actually talking *to* the player, but to herself – this is where her name is first revealed, too: 'Come on Max, you can make it...' This highlights that Max is, above all, a person of her own, but one that the player is invited to take part in.

It is difficult to see much in this first dark scene, and the player's only directive is to navigate towards the lighthouse. In the case of Participant 2, another layer of difficulty is added in that they are not familiar with video game controls. Not identifying as a gamer, and not having played a lot of video games in general, they require an explanation of how to use the basic controls – moving with the left stick, directing the camera with the right stick. For experienced gamers, this experience is decidedly different, as I reflect in the autoethnography of *Horizon Zero Dawn*: 'It's like putting on a well-worn glove. The familiarity of gaming is somewhat soothing' (Research Diary, Appendix B.3). For Participant 2, the lack of familiarity with video game conventions and the resulting lack of ludic literacy mean that they initially miss out on the game's signalling. When the cut-scene transitions to gameplay, which the game conveys by placing the camera behind the player-character, they do not immediately understand that the cinematic sequence is over and that they are in control now, partly because they are enraptured by the sound and scenery. There is not much difference in graphics between cut-scene and gameplay, which may contribute to this misunderstanding as well.

Participant 2 reacts to the scene on different levels. On the one hand, they comment on the scenery from an aesthetic point of view and connect it to their own experiences by attempting to situate the surroundings geographically, saying that it feels like the American Midwest. The aesthetic perspective is evident throughout the participant's session, and they tend to be fascinated with the game's use of symbols: 'I really wanna know what happens with that butterfly and the birds. It was cool to see the butterflies and birds pop up a lot in the story up to this point' (Participant 2, Interview).

On the other hand, the participant's reactions show that they do acknowledge their own transportation into the game by reacting to threatening situations. In the first

instance, this is based on auditory and tactile sensations – the shock-like reaction to the sound of thunder and the rumble of the controller –, but the player's engagement with their surroundings as negotiated through the player-character highlights this more strongly. They talk *to* Max with words of encouragement, which in reality are directed to themselves, too, as they are learning the controls of the game, and they panic when, after having control for a few moments, the game moves back into a cut-scene, yelling for Max to stop walking towards the cliff. The cut-scene that follows emphasises the feeling of danger and volatility that the scene has conveyed so far, and the reactions of player and player-character are mirrored when the rowboat starts falling towards Max. Based on the participant's reactions, the physicality of the experience appears to be highly effective in creating a primal bond between player and character: they both exist in the same virtual space, and the danger to Max is reflected onto the player. According to Calleja (2011, p. 169), the spatial and embodied dimension of the player-avatar relationship is a crucial step in the player's initial immersion or incorporation into the game:

On the first level, the virtual environment is incorporated into the player's mind as part of her immediate surroundings, within which she can navigate and interact. Second, the player is incorporated (in the sense of embodiment) in a single, systemically upheld location in the virtual environment at any single point in time.

The type of shared sensory experience described in the case of *Life is Strange* takes place in some of the other case studies as well, most notably in *Detroit: Become Human*. Playing three different characters in this game makes for a volatile relationship between player and player-character: the process of identification is not straightforward due to the constant switching of perspectives and conflicting narrative goals, and is further explored when discussing player and character identities in chapter 5.1. Connor and Markus are introduced in a first and foremost narrative way: they are characters in this story, a vehicle for the player, and they are seen from a third-person perspective. In contrast to this, Kara's first scene is shown entirely from a first-person perspective: the player's first interaction with Kara consists of literally seeing the world through her eyes. After showing the details of her system reboot, the game imitates a few blinks of her eyes while Kara is looking at a girl in the store (see fig. 3.2). In this scene, the player's entire interactivity is reduced to only being able to move her head, looking at the different people in the store until Todd approaches to take her home.

Kara's first appearance in *Detroit* conveys a different kind of relationship between player and player-character, one emerging from a *loss* of interactivity, which I reflect on in the course of my autoethnography: 'I was struck by the powerlessness in Kara's first scene – being in the shop and only being able to look around, but not actually being able to interact with anything. Maybe that's why I normally feel so close with her' (Research

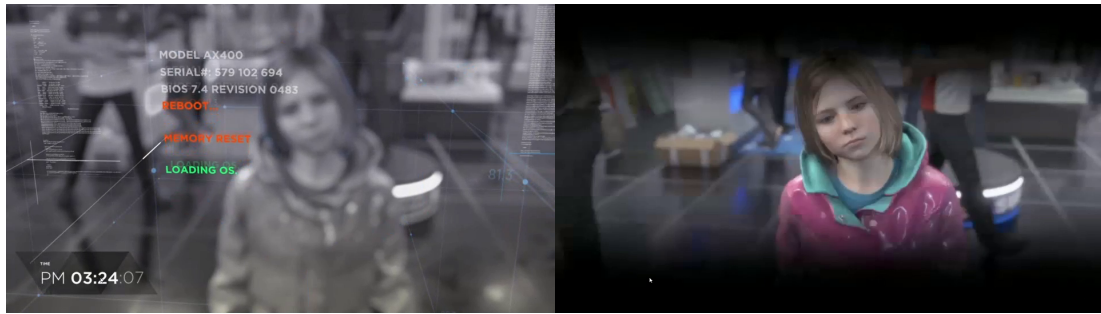


FIGURE 3.2: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 2: 'Opening'. The player sees the scene through Kara's eyes.

Diary, Appendix B.5). This helplessness appears in other scenes as well, for instance when Kara is captured and reset by Zlatko. The other characters are less focused on the lack of agency, except for in the way that all of them share an initial inability to disregard the instructions conveyed by their programming. Even Connor, who does not automatically turn deviant as the others do, tends to have a lot of agency and freedom within the confines of his programming, and depending on the player's choices is able to become a deviant towards the end of the game. In Kara's story, the lack of agency serves as means of characterisation, as it is revealed quickly that Kara has been previously mistreated by Todd. Breaking her programming and becoming a deviant emancipates Kara, giving her the means to take action and to attempt the start of a new life with Alice.

3.3 The Role of the Interface in Player-Character Connections

The interface in a video game carries particular ludic and narrative meaning by translating game rules and game states into a format through which the computer communicates directly with the player and vice versa, thereby bridging the gap between the two entities. Through this, the interface is the main conveyor of interactivity, and indeed highlights the reactive aspects of the game in what Smethurst and Craps (2015) call *interreactivity*. The interface can also have distinct narrative properties (Bizzocchi, 2007), i.e. the narrative itself is represented through the interface. Consalvo and Dutton (2006, par. 19) consider interface to include

any on-screen information that provides the player with information concerning the life, health, location or status of the character(s), as well as battle or action menus, nested menus that control options such as advancement grids or weapon selections, or additional screens that give the player more control over manipulating elements of gameplay.

Generally, *Detroit's* interface serves to connect player and player-character in a quasi-physical way: objectives and other environmental information are presented as part of the way in which the androids process the world, thereby making the interface diegetic and reducing the necessity of breaking the player's immersion to a degree. A few scenes however serve to create a more direct sensory connection between player and character. Most striking in this context is the chapter 'From the Dead,' which takes place after Markus was shot by the police. Here, Markus's system reboots and he finds himself in a junkyard. The game switches between showing the world from Markus's perspective when he is analysing himself or parts around the junkyard for compatibility, and a third-person perspective while navigating through the junkyard. The former is mostly tinted red, as his optical unit has been damaged, while in the third-person perspective the visuals are mostly normal but occasionally become blurry, emphasising the volatility of the situation.

Markus's navigational difficulties are translated to the player in the slow quick-time events at the beginning of the scene, alternately having to hold down L1 and R1 to allow him to pull himself forward until he is able to replace his legs; in the autoethnography I comment on the slow progress of this. At the same time, I also admit that I was not paying attention to the specifics of what I was doing – dragging myself along, analysing the spare leg parts –, instead simply following the prompts on the screen. Once the legs have been replaced, Markus is able to move around a bit more freely, but is still struggling. Markus's damaged audio processor is especially relevant in this scene, as the broken audio is much more ubiquitous than the impaired vision. The sound in the chapter is muffled, hollow, and occasionally marked by an uncomfortable high-pitched sound; '[i]t was surreal not being able to perceive the world around you properly' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). The sensory connection between player and player-character both enhances and is enhanced by the body horror elements of the scene, for instance androids walking without a head or talking without a body. Of particular note here is a moment in which hands coming out of a wall of bodies are trying to grab Markus, which made me 'feel physically shivering – flinching...' (Autoethnography, *Detroit*, Session 3) Due to the audiovisual elements of the scene and the necessity of having to navigate through the horrors of it, the perceived threat is translated physically, having an effect on the player's actual body.

Markus's physical difficulties are addressed one by one, with each solution changing the way in which the scene is perceived from a sensory and narrative perspective. The first time Markus finds a compatible and functional thirium pump regulator, the android that it belongs to wakes up and starts begging him not to take it. Rather than simply taking the part (or not), the player is confronted with the choice to kill or spare the android. In addition to the tense situation of being in a junkyard full of decommissioned and broken androids, this is one of the many moments in which the game challenges the player to take a moral standpoint: to what extent can androids in this

game be considered *persons*? This is the main theme of the game and many choices deal with this conundrum, both morally and practically, most notably in Connor's storyline – whether to shoot one of the androids at the Eden Club, for instance, or whether to shoot Chloe at Kamski's request in order to obtain crucial information for his investigation. It is also carried over to a meta level, as Chloe – the android in the game's main menu – occasionally asks the player to answer questions about their attitude to androids. Thematising this philosophical question within the player's own choices makes it more personal and drives the point home. In Markus's scene, the game contextualises the choice as 'kill' or 'spare,' thereby already assigning a moral judgement to whatever choice the player is going to make (see fig. 3.3). Compared to other scenes in which this is thematised, the difference here is that Markus's own survival is perceived to be tied to it as well, although the player will find a pump even if the android is spared.

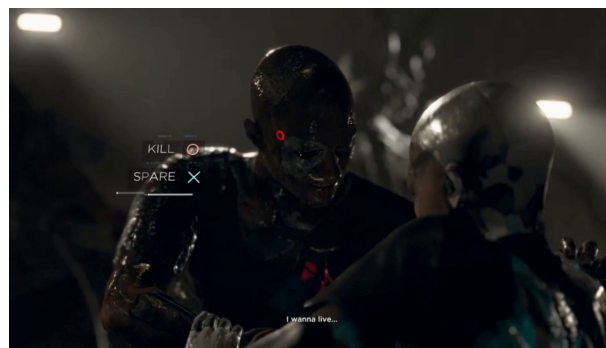


FIGURE 3.3: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 11: 'From the Dead'. The player has to choose whether to kill or spare the android.

A compatible optical unit can be taken from the dismembered head of an android, which starts talking to Markus as he removes it – based on my own reactions during the autoethnography, an intense and horrifying moment. Once the optical unit is in place, Markus's vision returns to normal, and the fact that he replaced his original unit is highlighted when his eyes are revealed to be in different colours: the original one is green, the new one is blue. A new audio processor fixes the muffled sounds; a return to normal sound levels here can be startling to the player, having gotten used to the sound in this scene so far. Finally, a compatible and functioning thirium pump regulator enables Markus to move more confidently again, and he is able to climb the slope of defective android bodies and leave the junkyard.

The climb out of the junkyard requires the player to push up to three buttons or sticks at the same time, reflecting Markus's own difficulties, and I comment on the challenge of this: 'It's alright if you have two things to do at once, but once it gets to three it can get a bit weird. I suppose you suddenly have to think about how to hold your hands' (Autoethnography, *Detroit*, Session 3). These difficulties can also be player-dependent, as they may change depending on the size of the player's hands and the controller that is being used. In my playthrough, there is a noticeable pause in the flow of gameplay

as soon as a third quick-time event appears on screen. By the end of the chapter, I acknowledge a definite connection between myself and the player-character that was missing in previous scenes: 'It's not really identification because I know there is a gap between me and him, but it's... something else.' Indeed, the act of including the player in the narrative events through the use of quick-time events in this manner leads to a kind of 'representational agency' (Cheng, 2007) that takes place in the fictional world instead of the player's, strengthening the connection between player and *narrative* character as well as the connection between player and avatar.

Although identification varies in the game due to having multiple player-characters, Markus's scene highlights the implications of embodiment-focused game design for the construction of the relationship between player and player-character. This embodied relationship may only manifest itself short-term and does not necessarily impact the player's main mode of engagement. Despite feeling such a strong connection via a shared sensory experience, my research diary highlights that as the game progresses I still felt more connected to the other characters: 'I find that overall I don't care that much about Markus or his storyline because it seems too grand; I know it's crucial for the narrative, but I feel more connected to the more personal storylines of Connor and Kara' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5).

When considering the embodied dimension of gameplay and its implications, it is important to further consider the *stakes* of a given scene, and here the idea of failure needs to be highlighted in the context of an imagined or real threat to the player-character, and by extension to the player themselves.¹ The feeling of being threatened is already touched upon in the above analyses, in the participant's very audible reaction to the falling rowboat in *Life is Strange* and my own reaction to the horror scenario in *Detroit*, particularly the hands coming out of the wall. None of these pose an actual threat in terms of ludic consequences: the rowboat falls towards Max in a nightmare, and the hands may be trying to grab Markus and the player has to follow the game's prompts to get away from them, but they do not pose any real danger to him. In contrast to this, an actual perceived threat on a player-character's life takes place during Connor's investigation of the TV station. While investigating which of the station androids was helping Markus, the deviant assaults Connor, tearing out his thirium pump to facilitate his escape. Connor's systems inform him that his shut-down is imminent and his senses are mirrored to the player, similar to Markus's condition in the junkyard, but primarily focusing on a distortion of Connor's surroundings, which are shown from a first-person perspective (see fig. 3.4).

The severity of Connor's condition is highlighted in three main ways. Firstly, the text and numbers that form part of the way in which androids make sense of the world change between displaying correctly and incorrectly – 'missiog' instead of 'missing',

¹Further implications of failure for the player's understanding and structuring of gameplay are discussed in more detail in chapters 5 and 9.



FIGURE 3.4: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 24: 'Public Enemy'. The depiction of the world changes due to Connor's critical condition.

'B1' instead of '01'. This is particularly concerning given that this data is normally very reliable. Secondly, Connor's surroundings are blurry, alternating between being shown in colour and being greyed out even when the first-person perspective is replaced by the usual third-person perspective, and sound is distorted. Thirdly, while Connor's condition is not displayed as badly as Markus's visually, it is conveyed to be more severe because of the time pressure of the scene. Once the player is in control of Connor, they have 1 minute and 45 seconds to recover the thirium pump in order to avoid Connor's shutdown. The recording of the autoethnography shows that I was extremely stressed in this scene, looking around frantically to find out what I need to do and commenting that the controls are responding only with some difficulty:

I don't know, what else can I do... This is very stressful! What else... Oh yeah, my knife. It's really difficult because it's [...] not mega responsive, so you actually have to try really hard, which I guess kind of makes sense because [...] *he* has to try really hard... (Autoethnography, *Detroit*, Part 5)

My stress in this situation is caused by two main factors: the scene's time pressure and the implications that the scene has for Connor's well-being. At the same time, it has to be noted that despite the way in which the game communicates these life-and-death stakes, the consequences are not necessarily as severe as they seem. Both Connor and Markus are unable to permanently die until later in the game. Only Kara is able to actually die from chapter 7, Kara's third chapter in the game, while Markus is first able to die in chapter 28. Connor can die at numerous points in the game including the first chapter, but in those cases, a new Connor model is deployed with his memories mostly intact. Each of Connor's deaths however has an impact on his software instability and his relationship with his human partner Hank, therefore creating real narrative consequences. Connor is only able to permanently die in the final chapter, once he has become a deviant. Although at the point of conducting the autoethnography I was aware that Connor will not die permanently, I still acknowledged the danger of the situation and the real narrative and ludic consequences that would result from this failure.

The scenes discussed in this chapter provide insights into the ways in which the player-character relationship is established independent of narrative context. The physical, embodied connection cements the player's presence within the game's environment and allows them to transport themselves *into* the the avatar, viewing the world through their eyes and perceiving threats in a way that manifests as a physical reaction. This connection bridges the initial gap between the player and game, making them coluding entities instead of competing ones. Building on this connection, the following chapter focuses on the player-character relationship as based on the narrative context, and the ways in which the character's personality is established and conveyed to the player to allow for a more empathetic relationship.

Chapter 4

The Personhood of the Character

4.1 Introduction

When talking about narrative in video games, it is not particularly productive to solely focus on the presentation and formal properties of a comprehensive narrative arc in the narratological sense, as the gaming experience is made up of various modes of engagement (Calleja, 2011) as explored in chapter 1.3.1. Instead, the story can be represented and analysed through a number of areas such as the story world itself, characters, emotions, narrative interface, and micro-narratives (Bizzocchi, 2007). These aspects can be crucial for the framing of game and narrative as well as the construction and maintenance of an immersive experience, accounting for both the player's ludic and imaginative needs.

As previously discussed in chapter 1.3.2, the role of the player-character is not only to act as the player's prosthetic extension (Klevjer, 2012) in the form of the avatar, but also to be a vehicle through which the narrative is experienced and contextualised in a meaningful way, highlighting the player-character's status as a *narrative* character. In order for the character to fulfill this function, the player needs to be able to acknowledge them as a separate entity with a distinct interior life, even if that interior life might be based on the player's own interpretation or projection. As opposed to the avatar, who, as discussed in the previous chapter, is highly dependent on the player's interactive capacities and has a crucial role in conveying and managing them, the narrative character – the protagonist and other characters populating the narrative – remains fairly fixed, and their backstories and personalities tend to be primarily conveyed through dialogue or cut-scenes.

As the narrative modes require strong authorial control, the player has limited influence over their development. However, the character's personality may change and be further developed by the narrative choices that the player makes (Mawhorter et al.,

2018), and some video games incorporate technical agency into the character design as well. In *Fable II* (Lionhead Studios, 2008), for instance, the player-character's appearance changes based on the specific choices that have been made by the player, assigning a clear value judgement to the player's actions and 'mapping [...] action-to-meaning' (K. Tanenbaum and T. J. Tanenbaum, 2010, p. 15) as a means to communicate with the player in a transparent and narratively meaningful manner. This, in turn, highlights feelings of agency for the player, i.e. the understanding that their actions carry dramatic meaning that influences the further experience of the game.

Another way of assigning meaning to player action is through non-player characters, who can flesh out the characterisation of the player-character through their interaction with them and their actions, again needing to distinguish between their functions within the narrative and their function within the game world (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008). This function can be ludic – the player is able to interact with them for a specific purpose – or a matter of world-building. In many cases the responses of non-player characters may not change significantly, but they give the player feedback through action or dialogue that carries narrative weight.

Following from the discussion of interface and embodiment in chapter 3.3, I would extend the definition of interface by Consalvo and Dutton (2006) to purely informative, as opposed to functional, screens and menus as well. In these, the game presents information about the game world, narrative, and characters that may aid and indeed impact the player's choice-making processes as well. While the player's own interpretation of the game events is a valid part of the gaming experience, these screens are important not just for the presentation of the narrative itself, but also for the representation of the game's own re-telling of events, which is done automatically throughout the course of the game (Eladhari, 2018). Essentially, the video game is represented as the ultimate authority due to the objective knowledge that is represented here, but they can also be considered separate texts with distinct narrative functions that bridge the gap between the story world and the player's world.

Extending the previous chapter's discussion of the player-character relationship that is constructed on the basis of the embodied dimensions of the gaming experience, this chapter focuses on the narrative development of player-characters that assigns psychological personhood through their distinct voice and a specific context that is shared with the player, as well as the player's role in engaging with the information that is provided by the game in this manner.

4.2 Understanding Characters as Persons

In calling for a player-centric understanding of video games, Pearce (2004, p. 146) argues that video game characters should be incomplete to 'leave more room for the

player,’ claiming that ‘[g]ames tend to favor abstracted personas over “developed” characters with clear personalities and motivations.’ While a degree of incompleteness is certainly desirable and necessary for the player to make the gaming experience more meaningful, Pearce’s focus on abstract characters fails to acknowledge the emotional component of player-character interaction and the gaming experience as a whole. Characters with a rich personal life are commonplace in contemporary video games, and just as the narrative can be used to translate the rules to the player, the player-character is able to translate the player’s agency into a meaningful experience. The narrative character is clearly defined, but will ideally undergo significant character development based on the events that take place in the game as a result of player action. In the case of ‘shell characters,’ where the character is purposefully less defined and more open to interpretation, the player is forced to reposition themselves in relation to both character and game in a separation of character, player, and narrator (Lee and Mitchell, 2018). The exact configuration of the player-character, including how abstract and involving they are, is dependent on the type of game that is being played as well. Often, games with a strong narrative focus tend to have more complex characters, but given the various narrative capacities represented in video games, this is not a necessity.

The interpretive action on the player’s part is not confined to a lack of characterisation, or abstract characters in general. Indeed, I would argue that the player’s own interpretation of the character plays an important role in creating meaningful play even if the character is well-defined, rounded, and displays a complex personal life, as the player inevitably fills in gaps based on the information that they are given as well as their own gameplay in the construction of their alterbiography. This is not necessarily focused on only one player-character, either: Calleja (2011) distinguishes between three main foci of alterbiographies, namely those of miniatures, entity, and self, where the first two relate to the number of characters that the player is in control of at any given moment, either multiple ones in the case of miniatures or a singular character in the case of entity. The alterbiography of self denotes a situation in which ‘players interpret the events happening in the game as happening to *them* specifically, rather than to an external character’ (p. 126), creating a more direct link between player and character as well as the capacity to fill in gaps in characterisation to arrive at a more fully formed understanding of the character itself. The game’s direct characterisation of the narrative character, then, provides a basis for the player’s own interpretive actions.

Of the explored case studies, the *Life is Strange* series lends the characters the most distinct interpretive voice. At the beginning of *Life is Strange*, the player has access to a variety of entries of Max’s diary detailing her acceptance into Blackwell Academy, her move back to Arcadia Bay, and her experiences during her first month at school (see fig. 4.1). This is accessible after the nightmare scene, i.e. after the initial attempt at establishing a physical connection between player and player-character as shown

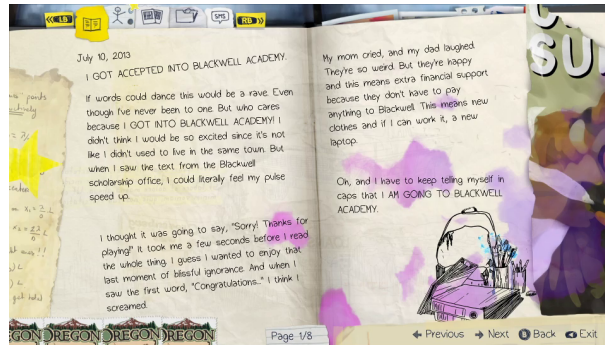


FIGURE 4.1: *Life is Strange*, Episode 1. Max's first diary entry.

in chapter 3. Aside from providing the character's background and motivations for her involvement in the narrative, Max's diary is used throughout the game to lend the character a voice. It is updated as the game progresses, providing commentary on the game's events from her specific perspective. This serves as a reminder of Max's status as a fictional character. Not only is she the player's representation on screen, she is a person in her own right, an impression that is further enhanced through text messages, which she automatically replies to without the player's input. Like the diary, the text messages pad out the narrative character, showing that she has a life before – outside – of the game. Rather than simply providing her thoughts, her diary is filled with stickers and doodles that lend an air of teenage authenticity to the character.

Max is portrayed as a creative, shy, and awkward character in those entries, an impression that in gameplay is confirmed through her interaction with other characters – particularly Mr. Jefferson – and her inner monologues. In a way, Max's anxiety and insecurity are the main reason for her involvement in the narrative. She goes to the bathroom after class to deal with being overwhelmed, and this is where she witnesses the incident between Nathan and Chloe that leads to her discovery of her rewind powers. Her powers feature in the development of the narrative in a major way, but they also contribute to and confirm her initial characterisation, as main decisions are accompanied by Max's second-guessing of her own actions, constantly worrying about having done something wrong and debating whether to change her decisions. In this, the game's mechanics are used as a tool for characterisation as well.

Similarly, *Life is Strange 2* features a sketchbook that Sean keeps with him at all times, which he uses to chronicle and process his experiences. At specific points in the game, the player is able to draw scenes into the sketchbook as well, infusing the object with diegetic and interactive meaning. As in *Life is Strange*, text messages are available to read on Sean's phone, providing more information about his life and his relationship with other characters before and during the first episode. At the end of Episode 1, Sean throws his phone away and does not replace it, symbolising that these relationships belong to a time in his life that he is unable to gain access to again.

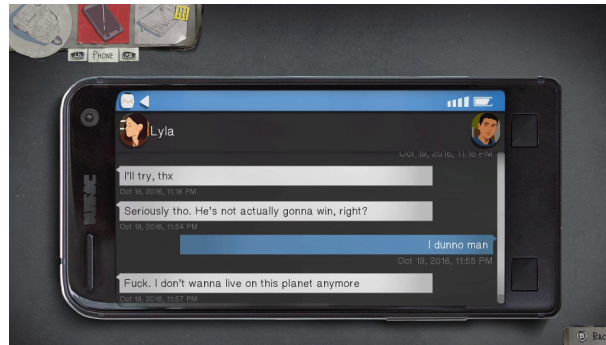


FIGURE 4.2: *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1, Chapter 1: '1452 Lame Avenue, Seattle'. The text message exchange between Sean and Lyla refers to the US presidential election.

The messages also serve to position the game within a specific context through various pop-culture and political references. In his text message exchange with his best friend Lyla, for instance, they discuss a 'freak show,' with Lyla asking 'He's not actually gonna win, right?' (see fig. 4.2) Based on the date of the message – 19 October 2016 – this exchange refers to the US presidential election, in particular the final presidential debate between Hilary Clinton and Donald Trump that took place on that date. While it is not necessary information for the completion of the game, the political context provided here hints at some of the themes dealt with in the game, particularly the racism and hostility that Sean and his brother experience when trying to flee to Mexico. In the autoethnography I comment on these text messages in particular: 'The horrible thing is that this really takes you back into the past, thinking about America [...] just thinking about the past few years and all the terrible stuff' (Autoethnography, *Life is Strange 2*, Session 1). This is especially poignant as the autoethnography of this game was conducted in September 2020, a few months before the US presidential election which was preceded by months of protests against police brutality, racial profiling, and systemic racism, thereby providing a fresh perspective on the specific context in which the game is situated.

Additional material such as the text messages, then, adds a layer of context to the game, emphasising that while the game itself is fictional, the underlying story is all too realistic, situated in the real world that the player is familiar with. This makes the player and player-character share a specific context and frame of reference: they exist in the same time and space because the player has inhabited the same space temporally, a connection that may not be quite as strong without understanding the period of time in which this game is situated. At the same time, the realism of the situation is acknowledged and understood by Participant 1 as well, who had not read the text message exchange but comments on the situation after the confrontation with the neighbour: 'It doesn't portray something that's not really real. Like, it is reality of many people in America at the moment if you have a less than white skin' (Participant 1, Interview).

While providing an alternative take on the events in the game, there is a distinct difference in function between Max's diary and Sean's sketchbook within the context of the game's communication with the player. Max's diary recounts in-game events from her perspective, adding a deeper level of context and understanding. Sean's sketchbook is filled in between episodes as well, thereby functioning as a device for narrative compression of off-screen events. This allows for the game to span several months: Episode 1 begins in October 2016 and Episode 5 ends in July 2017, with post-game events being portrayed until up to 2033 depending on the player's choices. However it can also deepen the divide between Sean and the player, taking away a degree of agency and ownership over the narrative: 'I'm feeling a bit conflicted about that because on the one hand it's good to have his reflections, on the other hand I'm feeling a bit cheated out of making these decisions and figuring these things out myself' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

Sean's reflections, much more than Max's, emphasise that it is *Sean's* story, not the player's, which is conveyed by the recap of the previous episodes as well. Starting with Episode 2, Sean recounts the events of the previous episodes in the form of a story about two wolf brothers and the challenges they face. Here, Sean re-interprets the events to fit them within this frame narrative:

Once upon a time, in a wild, wild world, there were two wolf brothers, living in their home lair with their papa wolf. They all lived happily together, but one day hunters took their Dad away. Forever. So now the brothers were alone... and they had to find a new home. (*Life is Strange 2*, Episode 2)

The story of the wolf brothers is told from the beginning at the start of each episode and expanded, with the exact details depending on the choices that the player makes throughout the game. In the autoethnography, I repeatedly appreciate the way in which the recap is done, and reflect on the impact that it has on my relationship with the characters:

These summaries just make me feel even closer to them even though it's [...] all about wolves. I don't think I would be as – I mean, obviously I would be involved, but I feel like it really adds another layer of closeness to that, having that wolf metaphor, or having Sean talk about it and tell it in his words. (Autoethnography, *Life is Strange 2*, Session 6)

The recaps can be initially interpreted as meta information with a diegetic aspect, but they later become part of the narrative, too, for instance when Daniel asks Sean to tell him a story about the wolf brothers, thereby making it another instrument of vocalising Sean's take on in-game events. The story of the wolf brothers adds a new narrative

layer, one in which Sean is able to show a different kind of emotional honesty through his need to process his trauma and make sense of events – to himself *and* to Daniel – using the vehicle of a fictional story.

In addition to the characters leading a life apart from the player in between episodes, the player-character becomes a *psychological*, rather than purely narrative, character through this multi-layered narration and distinct interpretation. As the game progresses, I start to acknowledge Sean as having a personhood that is decidedly different from my own: ‘I’m starting to understand Sean as a character a bit more [...] I’m also coming to accept that at the end of the day he is a traumatised teenager, so naturally he will say some things that I wouldn’t’ (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). This builds on frustrations with dialogue choices and the delivery thereof that I voice frequently throughout the episodes, wanting the character to react in a way that makes more sense to myself until I am finally able to empathise with him and acknowledge that we are different, and that ultimately the choices and reactions are his, not mine.

The second step in creating a meaningful player-character relationship, then, is the acknowledgement of the narrative character itself. While the incorporation of the player into game space and game space into player is primarily driven by spatial and kinaesthetic involvement as explored in chapter 3, Calleja (2011) discusses the other dimensions of the gaming experience as well, which describe the engagement with the goals of the game as ludic involvement, the imaginative aspect as narrative involvement, and the social and emotional aspects of gaming as affective and shared involvement. Shared involvement is mostly concerned with the relationship with other players, for instance in MMORPGs, but also includes a parasocial dimension by considering the cohabitation of player and non-player characters.

Being able to consider the characters that inhabit the game world socially rather than purely narratively opens up different possibilities for player-character interaction by presupposing that characters can be understood as *persons* rather than as characters. This represents an important shift in the player-character relationship, where the two entities and their individual characteristics are highlighted and acknowledged.

4.3 Narrative Information and Characterisation

Aside from the narrative devices contained in the text messages and journals, both *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2* embed narrative background information in the environment, adding to the understanding of the game world as a coherent and separate world with a specific history. Some of this information becomes important for the narrative, such as the Missing Person posters for Rachel Amber in *Life is Strange*, others enhance the player’s understanding of the characters and their relationships, such as letters to Sean’s father or family photographs in *Life is Strange 2*. As with the text messages

and journals, most of this information is not mandatory to take in, i.e. it is not a prerequisite to further advance the game. In the ethnographic study, neither Participant 1 nor Participant 3 engaged with the text messages beyond looking at them initially when prompted by the game. Participant 2 however was particularly interested in the background information, spending a lot of time reading the different diary entries, text messages and character profiles at the beginning of the game before even continuing to engage with the classroom scene. As the session progressed and became more dynamic and demanding, they did not engage with the updated entries, but checked the newly received text messages when prompted, thereby engaging not with Max's interpretation of events, but focusing on her relationship with other characters.

Information embedded in the actual environment appears to be more accessible, and Participants 2 and 3 engaged with it extensively throughout their sessions. In contrast, Participant 1 did not explore the story world much and showed little engagement with the character background and character narratives that can be found through in-depth interaction with the environment, which may be related to the time restrictions of the study as well, as Participant 1's gameplay session only lasted 45 minutes.¹ As such, they were focused primarily on completing the objectives set by the game even if they were different from their own personal objectives, and only engaged with objects if they seemed to be relevant for fulfilling these goals. This means that they missed out on optional ways to aid in the completion of their objectives as well. When looking around the house, they detected the money jar and commented that it might be helpful as Sean needs to get money for the party, however when focusing on the jar it initially only gave the player the option to look at it, causing them to dismiss it immediately. In reality, the player had the option to steal from the money jar *after* looking at it for the first time. Participant 3, who had a longer gameplay session, showed a high degree of narrative exploration throughout the session by carefully and deliberately investigating the player-character's house to find out more information about the family, claiming that this added to their overall narrative experience and understanding of the character, which in turn impacted the way in which they engaged with their choices as well:

There's quite a lot of points where you can look at photographs and stuff and they don't add anything to the gameplay, but you could ignore them and just go straight to the main points of the gameplay. But then you would lose out on all the narrative from getting all this extra information as you go along. [...] When you go around the house and you see the bits where he's talking about his dad, and you see that he has a fairly positive [...] opinion of his dad, it makes you want to be more positive towards the dad.
(Participant 3, Interview)

¹It is possible that the participant would prioritise exploration outside of a research setting and without time pressure.

In contrast to *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2*, the session for *Horizon Zero Dawn* started *in medias res*, a few hours into the game. Although Participant 4 was shown a 10-minute video at the beginning of their gameplay session, the video only provided a more immediate context to the game, i.e. Aloy waking up after the Proving and being made a Seeker. The participant was given a verbal summary of the game up to this point as well and was able to ask questions to clarify characters, narrative and context. Although the participant understood the narrative context, they had not gotten to know the player-character Aloy intimately. The hours of gameplay preceding this would have included Aloy's exile as an infant and her motivation to take part in the Proving in order to find out more information about her mother, other characters' reactions to her, her exploration of the caves that led to her finding her Focus, her experimentation with the Focus, and her close relationship with Rost.

In order to gauge the participant's understanding of the narrative, they were asked to recount the session in the interview and started by recapping the information from the video: waking up after the Proving, the attack that killed a number of people in the tribe, using the Focus to find out more about what had happened – 'I think I was a little bit confused – the character herself was a bit confused about that' (Participant 4, Interview) –, the Matriarch showing Aloy her birthplace, and Aloy being made a Seeker. They admitted that they did not understand what the purpose of becoming a Seeker was, 'but I was just gonna go and look for stuff and try to un-corrupt the door,' trusting that the game would clarify the narrative as they progressed. Rather than causing a sense of disorientation, however, the lack of knowledge and understanding of the situation appeared to increase their curiosity about the setting and characters:

It was interesting because I kind of wanted to go through the door to see what happened, because obviously I understand technology and stuff. But she, I don't know, it was weird because it seemed a bit culty when they thought that this magical door is talking to them and it was some mystical thing. Which was quite cool, because it's obviously something that you think that you'll solve at the end of the game or partway through the game at least. To see like who this person [Aloy's mother] is, and I kind of wanted to know where they came from and stuff.

Despite their clear interest in the narrative, the participant deliberately chose not to engage with the main quest, instead spending the session doing different types of quests to increase their familiarity with the game itself. Even in the 18 hours of autoethnography of *Horizon Zero Dawn*, my focus was often on non-narrative aspects of the game such as combat and plans for levelling up. As the narrative itself was not as ubiquitous as in the other case studies due to the open-world format of the game, my moments of closeness with Aloy were of a predominantly ludic nature: 'I'm starting to feel closer to Aloy, probably because of all the stuff we've had to do together so far' (Research Diary,

Appendix B.3). I was more intrigued by the general setting of the world, appreciating the data points that can be found all over the game world. Participant 4 echoed the sentiment of wanting to know more information about the setting as well and made it clear that in the normal course of a game they would spend more time finding out about this as well as the character:

I'm really interested to find out where it's going, and like I wanted to find out more the kind of mother figure type stuff. Find out [...] a bit more about how the character interacts with people, what the options are. Most people I guess were quite positive but there is also this sense that [...] she's an outsider, so I kind of wanted to know why. [...] If I were to research it I'd read stuff up and probably read a bit ahead of where I am to find out about different options. (Participant 4, Interview)

This need for understanding can be considered the flip side to the way in which more information about the character influences how the player makes choices (Jakobsen et al., 2017), suggesting that players want to have basic guidelines and a frame of reference to shape their choice-making behaviour, which will be further explored in chapter 8. At the same time, Participant 4 made clear that they would consider engaging with these kinds of paratexts cheating, but that this is an approach they frequently take in games.

The difference in engagement and presentation of narrative and character information may in part be due to the format as well as the genres of the games. As episodic games, *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2* are required to present a lot of information in a short amount of time. Devices such as journals and text messages are used to flesh out the characters' lives and personalities, embedding them within a real-world context, Sean more so than Max due to the integration of for instance political events. The episodic design of the games also means that players might have to wait a long time between episodes; here, the notebooks can be useful for recapping information and bringing into focus the narrative context for a given episode. Both games provide a recap at the beginning of each episode, but while, as discussed above, *Life is Strange 2*'s recap has a distinct function within Sean's characterisation, the recap for *Life is Strange* is factual and set apart from the narrative, replaying specific scenes to set up the context for the episode. The *Life is Strange* series is focused on the unique circumstances of the player-characters that set them apart from other characters in the world that they live in. *Horizon Zero Dawn* on the other hand is set in a dystopian futuristic setting in the 31st century, whose only connection to the player's personal context is in data points as well as items and artefacts that are considered historic, and whose use is misunderstood by the characters (a set of keys for instance is interpreted as 'ancient chimes'). In order to understand Aloy as a character, or even a person, the player needs to first understand the world that she lives in. The greater distance between Primary

and Secondary Worlds as discussed by Wolf (2012), then, leads to a prioritisation of setting over character.

This chapter highlighted the different factors that contribute to the creation of the player-character as a separate entity from the player and the player's role in establishing a relationship based on respect and/or curiosity. In the character-focused video games – *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2* – the player-characters are able to gain the status of a person by offering interpretations that are *their own*, not the game's or the player's, by showing that they have rich interior lives, and by inviting the player to share their narrative context while at the same time maintaining their psychological independence. In *Horizon Zero Dawn*, there is less focus on the individual character, with the game's voice being more dominant than the character's; here, the character's own personality is established through the game's setting. Having established the independence of the player-character in this way, the next chapter focuses on the player's engagement with the video game *through* the player-character, focusing on the way in which player and character negotiate their various identities and levels of control.

Chapter 5

Player, Character, Altercharacter

I, Connor, am chasing a deviant – a malfunctioning android. Prior to this, my investigation did not go well; in a moment of player (rather than character) curiosity, I probed another deviant's memory, causing him to self-destruct. This is why it is even more important that I catch this one. I am an android myself, and making progress in the investigation against deviants is my main objective.

In the back of my mind, I am aware from previous playthroughs that I need information to find the deviants at a later point in the game, so I am anxious to do well in this part of my investigation. The chase for the deviant feels intense; by now I am used to the quick-time events popping up on the screen and I am fairly good at pressing the correct buttons in time, but it makes me feel very alert and tense, and my attention is focused on the quick-time events rather than my in-game surroundings. In moments like this, the character vanishes from my consciousness: only I and the game exist, and there is a stubbornness to my actions too, a peculiar sense of pride, as if I am trying to prove to the game that I am good enough to do this.

More than in other scenes, the game forces me to make quick decisions about the route that I am taking: safer but slower options versus risky but fast ones. My priority is catching up with the deviant, and so I often opt for the riskier options, especially after I lose some time getting stuck behind a non-player character. The end of this scene is in the back of my mind and I am aware that last time I played this, the deviant got away. I want to avoid a repeat of that.

I suddenly end up in a cornfield and I can't see where I'm going; it is disorienting. I have to trust myself – or the game, or both. As I run, I hear my human partner Hank yell 'Stop right there,' and finally emerge onto a roof. I am given a brief respite from the high intensity of the chase as the game takes control away from me to show me a cut-scene in which I see the deviant push Hank off the roof. Although I knew that this was going to happen based on previous playthroughs, I – the player

– swear to myself, and after a close-up of Connor’s face, I see what he sees: a choice. To the left of me, the deviant is running away. To the right of me, Hank is hanging off the roof. Big letters tell me that Hank’s chance of survival is 89%. I sigh as I am confronted with this. My first instinct is to save Hank, but I’m also aware of the way my investigation has been going up to now, and I feel that I really do need to catch the deviant to make progress. 89% chance of survival does not sound too bad, and I make the decision to chase the deviant instead of saving Hank. I have faith that Hank will survive this; he is an important character.

I almost instantly regret the decision as soon as I make it. Connor’s LED turns yellow as he processes the choice, and the top right corner of the screen shows that Connor’s software instability is decreasing. As if this wasn’t enough, the game also informs me that Hank’s opinion of me is going down, and he is now ‘hostile’ towards me. This upsets me much more than the software instability. The game’s music, while still tense, slows down as the cut-scene shows the two androids facing each other. The deviant pleads with me, telling me that he has done nothing wrong, but Connor doesn’t react to the plea. As he explains that he is defective and will be sent back to be deactivated, Hank, panting loudly, catches up with us. Obviously angry, he tells the deviant not to move, then slaps me. I figure that I deserve that. ‘You bastard! You saw I was gonna fall and you’d rather let me die than fail your fucking mission!’ He interrupts Connor’s feeble attempt at de-escalation: ‘What am I to you? A statistic?’

I am struck by his accusation, feeling even worse than I already had, knowing that, indeed, my choice had been explicitly based on the chance of survival that Connor’s programming had calculated. ‘Fuck you and your fucking assessment,’ Hank growls, cutting off any further possibility to explain myself. To make a bad situation even worse, the deviant suddenly breaks free as we lead him away, and accompanied by Hank’s and my own frustrated curses, jumps off the roof. After a moment of Connor and Hank staring after the deviant, Hank simply exclaims ‘Fucking androids’ and walks away.

I, the player, am stunned. I feel the control of the game slipping away from me as I consider that not only is my investigation still going badly, I also antagonised my partner for what appears to be no gain at all. The situation reeks of failure to me, and I am anxious to make things right again.

5.1 Introduction

The above scene from the autoethnography of *Detroit: Become Human*’s chapter ‘The Nest’ highlights the variety of processes and modes of engagement that are at play, often simultaneously, during gameplay. Extending the previous discussions of the way in

which the player-character relationship is built through gameplay and game communication, this chapter focuses on the player's own negotiations of identity and the different objectives that accompany them. Three primary identities are represented in the above scene: a narrative identity revolving around the relationship between the player and the player-character, situated on the story level (I = Connor), a ludic identity that is primarily involved with the action level, where the player and their objectives and actions are separate from the narrative character (I = Samantha), and a third identity that emerges from the interaction between player and character identities, the *altercharacter*. These identities will be discussed separately in this chapter, but in fact they switch frequently and are often even represented at the same time, in a way struggling for ludic and narrative control.

According to Isbister (2016), the player's connection with the player-character takes place *viscerally* based on the changes in the player's skill level as manifested by the avatar's body, *cognitively* as tied to the strategic planning and taking of action and the way in which these are rewarded through gameplay, *socially* by focusing on the characteristics of the player-character that the player is able to experience even if they lie outside of their own personality or social competencies, or in relation to the player's *fantasy*, meaning that players are able to 'explore alternate fantasy selves through actual in-game performance' (p. 13). While the player's relationship with the character is formed with both ludic and narrative functions of the character independently, Klevjer (2012) highlights that vicarious embodiment incorporates fictionality, too.

Throughout gameplay, the player's mind continually distinguishes between the part of the game that is concerned with gameplay mechanics – the *action level* – and the part of the game that deals with the narrative itself – the *story level* (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008), the former dealing with goal-related or ludic engagement and the latter dealing with empathetic engagement (Lankoski, 2011). In dealing with aspects of both narrative and gameplay, then, the player is cognitively situated both inside and outside of the game (Jørgensen, 2009; Calleja, 2011), allowing for different immersive qualities to further define the gaming experience. Fundamentally, these dimensions are ludic/challenge-based or narrative/imaginative, and can additionally be based on the sensory qualities of the hardware used to play the game (Ermi and Mäyrä, 2005; Ryan, 2009).

Playing a game brings with it an awareness of the distinction between action and story level, meaning that a player can in parts *choose* to be engaged on a goal-related/ludic or an empathic/narrative level, with the ludic engagement depending on the player's ability to adapt a lusory attitude towards the game itself (Salen and Zimmerman, 2004). The quality of these two levels is often evaluated separately (Tocci, 2008), corresponding to two different kinds of understanding of the player-character. For the purpose of this thesis, the ludic character is considered a representation of the player's ludic focus,

which includes the player's skill level as well as gameplay-specific repertoire and objectives. The narrative character represents the character within the story as authored by the game designer, and can invoke a sympathetic or empathetic relationship with the player. In the context of the player-character relationship, this means that the player is aware that the movements of the avatar do not necessarily reflect the character itself, especially when there is a disparity between the player's and character's skill. The player is unlikely to think that the narrative character is unable to climb up a wall, for instance, but acknowledges that this is part of the ludic character's experience, which in turn is related to the player's skill level. In the same vein, the player-character's status is not always reflected in the game's narrative, either.

The player's actions, choices, and responses throughout gameplay are not only informed by their different levels of engagement, but also by the different levels of identity that inform and are informed by the player-character relationship. These correspond to the player's 'real-world identity' and their 'virtual identity,' i.e. the character that they play, which are linked through a 'projective identity' (Gee, 2003). All of these identities can be understood to impact the way in which the game is played and the different personal objectives that inform gameplay, but the real-world identity in particular corresponds to the player's ludic engagement as it is the identity that is situated the most outside of the game. The reliance on player skill that makes up a large part of the real-world identity can highlight the dichotomy of player and player-character as well: 'The projective identity of Bead Bead as a project (mine) in the making can fail because I (the real-world James Paul Gee) have caused Bead Bead (the virtual me) to do something in the game that the character I want Bead Bead to be would not or should not do' (Gee, 2003, p. 52).

This kind of failure does not only involve making choices that are at odds with the character, but is also reflected in the player's ludic failures, determined by their skill – or lack thereof – throughout the process of learning and mastering the game. However, as Giddings and Kennedy (2008, p. 30) argue, the pleasure of playing a game comes not only from learning how to master it and succeeding in this mastery, but also from 'the human pleasures of lack of agency, of being controlled, of being *acted upon*.' Therefore, failure is an expected part of the gaming experience, often communicated through the player-character's death and starting from a previous save point. While failure is an important aspect of agency as raised stakes give meaning to interactive capacities (Calleja, 2011), a case can be made for it to be reflected in ways that do not cause the player-character to die. Instead, Tocci (2008) recommends to treat failure through moral consequences or branching narratives, i.e. consequences that affect the narrative character rather than the avatar itself, which highlights the importance of translating ludic actions into narrative meaning.

Following the previous chapters' findings on the construction of the player-character relationship through processes of merging and separation, this chapter considers the

way in which this relationship is affected and refined through the interaction between player and game. In particular, the concept of the altercharacter will be introduced and defined before focusing on the negotiations of identity that are at play during the gaming experience.

5.2 The Creation of the Altercharacter

Story-driven games generally encourage a high narrative involvement on the part of the player due to the strong focus on character building within the context of the narrative. In *Detroit*, most choices occur in dialogues, and they are explicitly used to drive narrative and character development. By making choices on behalf of the player-characters, the player's own personality is highlighted as well, giving rise to an emotional connection with the choices and characters (both player- and non-player characters). Such an emotional involvement is time-dependent: Kway and Mitchell (2018) find that players first want to understand how the game works before making biased character decisions that have a narrative impact. This ties in with the notion that emotional engagement can only emerge through prolonged interaction with the game (Isbister, 2016). Once players are comfortable making those decisions on behalf of the character, emotional agency is built up through continually making small-scale choices that impact the way the character acts or is reacted to by other characters.

These choices do not need to fundamentally change the course of the story; rather, they are of sentimental value, and through making them the player is able to create a player-character that is individual to their specific gaming experience as part of the player's 'alterbiography' (Calleja, 2011). Once a connection with the character is established, the player's closeness with the character allows for their choices to be closer to the player's own choices, as for instance observed by Participant 1 in the ethnographic study: 'I feel [a] kind of ownership over the character now that I made so many choices on their behalf. So it's like a familiarity. It's a contract between me and the character' (Participant 1, Interview). The concept of ownership through choice-making emerged in the course of the autoethnography as well and is reflected, for instance, in my uneasiness about Sean's sketchbook being filled in in between episodes as previously discussed in chapter 4.2.

Participant 3 noted that most of the choices throughout their session did not appear to have a significant impact on gameplay or narrative, and were there primarily to establish a solid connection with the characters. They understood the player-character's choices as a reflection of the player's own personality. For both Participant 2 and Participant 3, the separation between player and player-character was more strongly defined than in the case of Participant 1, who as discussed in section 4.3 did not engage much

with the narrative background material that highlights the character's psychological independence. Where the choices were narrative- instead of gameplay-oriented, the participants were vocal about basing their choices on the way the character had been presented so far: 'It wasn't my choice, I felt that that was what Max would do' (Participant 2, Interview). In this case, the distance between player and player-character seemed to be more definite, and while they made choices on behalf of the player-character, they were clearly the narrative character's, not the player's. Participant 4 reflects on the role of their own identity as well, highlighting that their personality features heavily in their choice-making practices:

I think there are occasions in games where I take on a different role, but I tend not to take the more negative roles. [...] So I'm using a little bit of my personality but kind of doing a little bit of roleplay as well. [...] It's kind of like a boundary where I can fit and I'm happy going a little bit one way but not too much. (Participant 4, Interview)

Fundamentally, the connection between player and player-character is dependent on the recognition, i.e. construction and interpretation of the player-character, alignment – the way in which information about the player-character is communicated –, and allegiance, where the player evaluates the positive or negative traits of the player-character in relation to themselves (Lankoski, 2011). While the participants' experiences seem similar to the way in which Gee (2003) approaches the notion of the tripartite identity, the projective identity, while emphasising the powerful connection between the real-world and virtual identities, is still too player-centric in focusing primarily on the way in which the player invests the virtual identity with their own identity, goals, motivations, and skills. In this, the model does not fully account for the two-way relationship between player and player-character that informs the player's emotional engagement and overall behaviour: on the one hand, the player is able to shape the personality of the character through the choices that they make throughout the game (Mawhorter et al., 2018), and on the other hand, an enhanced understanding of the narrative character through exposure to additional information about the character can significantly change the way in which the player makes choices as well (Jakobsen et al., 2017).

The concept of alterbiography (Calleja, 2011), particularly the alterbiographies of entity and self, provides a useful framework for approaching the unique relationship that is established between player and player-character as it highlights the individual interpretation of the player. However, the concept itself mainly focuses on the *story* that is generated, both on a minute and overarching level. It does not account for the deeper dynamics of the *construction* of the characters in said alterbiographies, or the frequent modal shift between character or player as alterbiographical subject through the player's interpretation and re-telling of game events as happening both to the player from the first-person perspective and the character from the third-person perspective.

This is expressed through the distinction between ‘I did something’ and ‘the character did something,’ where ‘I’ can refer to the player as the entity that formally interacts with the video game, the player-character that inhabits the game space, or a combination of the two. Calleja does acknowledge the role of the player’s focus – or ‘disposition’ – in the creation of alterbiographies, but does not provide more detail about the type of disposition this might be apart from them being external or internal.

Extending both the understanding of Gee’s tripartite identity and Calleja’s alterbiography, I consider the creation of a separate entity called the ‘altercharacter,’ which is born through the intersection of player, player-character, narrative interpretation, and choice-making. This concept focuses on the communicative and transformative aspect of the player-character relationship through the creation of a ‘contract’ between player and game, as Participant 1 described it. Calleja’s concept of alterbiography forms the foundation of the notion of the altercharacter as it emphasises the player’s interpretation and meaning-making as inconsistent processes that are both triggered by the game and dependent on the context of play and the player’s degree of involvement. This thesis diverges from Calleja’s treatment of the subject in that, rather than focusing on this dynamic as a part of the incorporation process, it specifically focuses on the player-character relationship as opposed to the player-narrative relationship. In this way, the concept of the altercharacter offers a more nuanced version of alterbiography that is driven by the player’s choice-making behaviour. The altercharacter can be defined as follows:

The altercharacter is the entity that is formed as a consequence of the player’s continuous engagement with a video game and encompasses both player and character personalities. The altercharacter is a product of the player’s choice-making behaviours, their interpretation of actions and narrative, and the negotiation of control between player and game.

The altercharacter, then, is the character that dominates and drives player choice and is unique to each player’s experience. Focusing on the dimension of character as opposed to narrative as a driving force highlights the relationship that is established between player and game and the way in which this relationship is conveyed within the space of the game itself.

5.3 Narrative Identity

As mentioned in chapter 3.2, the matter of player-character relationship is complicated in *Detroit*, as the game’s story is told from the point of view of three different player-characters, all of which are androids: Kara, a housekeeper who breaks her programming to look after the child of her abusive owner; Markus, a domestic companion who,

after his owner's death, starts an android revolution; and Connor, a police investigator whose mission is to find defective androids that have broken their programming, so-called deviants – Kara and Markus among them. The constant changing of perspectives disrupts the construction of a coherent, stable player-character relationship.

Overall, Participant 5 felt closest to Kara as the beginning of her storyline provided the most meaningful narrative agency, and this connection was apparent in my own experience as well when in the beginning of my autoethnography Kara was the character that I most associated with my notion of self: 'I feel closest to Kara, maybe because her story is so emotional' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). This is exemplified by using 'I' most frequently when talking and writing about Kara as opposed to the other characters. Towards the end of the autoethnography, however, the notion of 'I' had moved away from Kara and was instead associated with Connor, and I had established a stronger distance between myself and the other player-characters even in those moments when I was playing them. This dynamic is especially interesting towards the end of the game, as the perspective frequently switches between characters in the 'Crossroads' chapter, even leading to a dialogue in which the player controls both parties, Connor and Markus.

This suggests that while the player still approaches their understanding of the game and its narrative through an alterbiography of entity due to their controlling only one character at a time (Calleja, 2011), in multi-character games one primary altercharacter is chosen and constructed throughout the course of the game. In the process of choosing the primary altercharacter, however, different characters may take precedence. The strong connection between Connor and myself is partly based on the active role that I had in shaping his character through gameplay. While all of the characters' personalities are shaped to a degree by the choices that are made in the game, Connor is the only character who can *choose* to become deviant or not, a choice that is pre-determined for Kara and Markus. I frequently reflect on feelings of identity throughout my autoethnography, and am clear about which character my main 'contract' is with: '[W]hen I saw Markus again [in the final chapter] and he said 'We did it', I actually did say to myself 'Yes, *I* did it, freeing the androids at the warehouse [as Connor]'" (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). Although the ending was a result of multiple player-characters' actions, choices, and successes, it was Connor's actions that I associated most with my own sense of achievement.

The scene from 'The Nest' demonstrates an emotional involvement driven by the narrative identity and the merging of the player's self with the player-character. Assuming ownership of the character and the choices in this case leads to a strong feeling of regret that emerges out of making what I perceive as a 'wrong' decision and facing the consequences thereof. Regret in this scene is first triggered by the game's explicit communication based on two of the main statistics that the game uses throughout, Connor's software instability and the relationship with certain NPCs. Before I am even faced

with the actual narrative consequences of my action, I translate the given information into potential consequences. It is not until I am confronted with Hank's reaction and accusations, however, that I start feeling not only regret but guilt, and I start talking and thinking about this scene as a *failure* especially given the focus on the relationship with Hank that I have built previously. This sense of failure informs future rationales for making choices, too:

I tried to build a better relationship with Hank and was very conscious of approaching him differently than how I would normally play [...] I felt that remarking on his diet or the company he keeps would alienate him more. Of course that didn't even compare to how much I alienated him right after that [...] Hank ended up being really angry with me, and dropped down to being hostile – I felt especially attacked when he asked if he was 'just a statistic' because... yes, in that moment he was and I felt guilty about it. That scene felt like a huge failure, especially given that the deviant committed suicide, so I didn't actually get anything in exchange for alienating Hank. Finding him passed out drunk at his house later felt very personal and I tried my best to be civil towards him hoping that our relationship will recover a bit. (Research Diary, Appendix B.5)

In this example, perceived failure stems from a clash between different modes of engagement, between ludic and narrative engagement; it is a failure in relation to the player's personal goals for narrative and character development. The game continues after this outcome, and therefore it *is* a valid path for the way in which the game and its narrative develop. Failure on a ludic level in other video games would for instance be reflected in having to replay a scene from a previous checkpoint. The kind of failure experienced here is based on the emotional involvement that emerges from the player's narrative identity, which in turn is developed through continuous engagement with the player-character, non-player characters, and the narrative in general. It is a failure because in this case, the player's – my – overall priority is the narrative development instead of being focused on completing certain ludic objectives, despite making the main choice in this scene based on those objectives.

5.4 Ludic Identity

Stepping away from the imaginative narrative engagement, the understanding of the self as a *player* – the real-world identity according to Gee (2003) – draws on ludic engagement with the game on a fundamental level, as demonstrated by an explicit stepping out of the narrative context in which I focus on the game's quick-time events only and am aware of the fact that 'only I and the game exist.' This is triggered by a need for

heightened concentration, of a state of 'flow' (Csikszentmihalyi, 2002), in this case the need to react quickly to the game's prompts. The quick-time events influence the narrative to a certain degree – after all, they are an enactment of a chase scene, which takes place in the context of narrative, and the player's performance of the quick-time events may well result in a different narrative outcome if the deviant is not caught. However, the narrative relevance fades to the background as the player translates the prompts to real-life movements, i.e. they need to remember where the correct button is on the controller and press it in time. As mentioned in chapter 3.3, pressing multiple buttons at the same time can feel challenging depending on their placement, particularly in a time-sensitive scene such as this one, therefore requiring stronger concentration in order to succeed.

The identity of the player is also highlighted in other ways, for instance when the player adapts a mindset focused on the objectives that are set by the game, or objectives that inform the gameplay rather than the narrative. In 'The Nest,' this is represented by the way in which the main choice of the scene – whether or not to save Hank – was made. I was aware of the fact that I had failed a previous scene and that I would need more specific evidence for a later part of the game. This, of course, was represented in the narrative as well, as narrative and gameplay are closely connected here and multiple characters have so far commented on the lack of progress and evidence. While on a personal and narrative level I wanted to save Hank, I chose to go after the deviant precisely to fulfil those objectives, and consciously chose a ludic focus over a narrative or emotional focus.

This mode of engagement can be understood as identifying as a *player* of a game, in opposition to identifying as the altercharacter that more predominantly informs the narrative identity. The identity of 'player' is informed by a variety of roles and separate identities, all of which may have an impact on the player's engagement with the game itself, informing the choices that are made on the level of gameplay. In order to understand the relationship between the different kinds of roles and the way in which ludic choices are carried out, I focus on the different identities that are apparent in the above scene based on my own experience.

First and foremost, the identity of the player ties in with identifying as a *gamer* in the larger sense of the gaming culture, drawing on the particular skill set and ludic literacy that come from a strong familiarity with video games. Having played video games from a young age, I am familiar not only with the way in which video games work in general, but also with the conventions of different game genres, some more than others, based on personal preference. For instance, I prefer to play games with a strong narrative, and so I am quite familiar with games like *Detroit* and have honed my skills through repeated engagement with them. If this research included, for example, MMORPGs or strategy games, which I have very little experience with, my ludic literacy would mainly cover general aspects of the game, such as controls, but would

not extend to the specifics of the way in which the game works and reacts to me or potential outcomes of my actions. Hardware plays a role in this as well: I prefer to use controllers to play video games, and would be much less proficient at first if I was to use mouse and keyboard to control the game.

In the ethnographic study, most of the participants reported playing video games frequently and therefore were familiar with gaming conventions, although not always with the genre of game played in the study. While identifying as a gamer, Participant 5 for instance discussed their lack of familiarity with games like *Detroit*: ‘Maybe if I’d played it longer or if I’d played more similar games I might know what I was expecting it to do and then I guess have a better idea of what effect my actions had. I guess maybe I was testing it a little bit’ (Participant 5, Interview). Participant 2, however, had very little experience with video games, frequently struggling with controls and voicing frustration about their lack of skill, both during gameplay and in the interview. Although these struggles highlighted the technical, ludic part of the gaming experience, as shown in chapter 4.3 Participant 2 was also strongly engaged with the story world, the narrative, and the characters, more so than the observations of the other participants suggested.

There is also a gendered aspect to my identity of player/gamer that cannot be neglected in a discussion about my gaming behaviour. Identifying as a *female* gamer in the gaming community, I often feel that I have to prove my skills and experience both to myself and others – even to hypothetical ‘others,’ as it may even occur when nobody else is watching. Having grown up with known issues of sexism within the gaming industry and the common perception of video games as a predominantly male domain, the need to justify my existence informs the strong sense of competition. According to Kivijärvi and Katila (2022, p. 475), needing to justify the legitimacy of one’s own belonging is a common aspect that informs the female player’s identity:

To gain a legitimate identity in the community of gamers, aspiring to the masculine Player One position becomes a necessity. Thus, the desire to be recognized invites the women to engage in the simultaneity of mastery and submission—to emphasize their belonging by reciting the masculine gamer discourse.

The sense of competition and necessity of skill surface especially in those moments that are based primarily on the player’s skills, which in the scene from *Detroit* is described as ‘a stubbornness to my actions [...], a peculiar sense of pride, as if I am trying to prove to the game that I am good enough to do this.’ Whether or not I do well in the ludic aspects of the video game impacts the way in which I make choices in this scene, too, as the paths that I choose – risky or safe for instance – are dependent on my confidence in my abilities at any given moment, and fluctuate depending on my

performance in the quick-time events. This sense of competition opens up another potential for experiencing failure, in addition to the emotions-driven failure discussed in conjunction with the narrative identity. This explicitly comes through in parts of my own reflections as well, for instance after a particularly difficult part in *Horizon Zero Dawn* which I did survive, but not skilfully so: 'I didn't die in the end, but I don't really have a sense of achievement from this and am quite frustrated with myself. Maybe I'm not as good at video games as I think I am' (Research Diary, Appendix B.3).

Last but not least, my role and identity as a researcher is also closely connected to this sense of stubbornness and pride, both in the context of this thesis and as a player-researcher in general. Although it is unlikely that the footage from my autoethnography will be viewed by others, at least not in its entirety, not doing well in the skill-based aspects of the games makes me feel uncomfortably self-conscious *as if* someone was watching and judging my gameplay – and, in turn, impacting my own perceived justification as a games researcher. In addition to this sense of pride, my engagement with the video game is, by necessity, impacted in some way by engaging with it for the purpose of a specific research project, as well as being able to draw connections between my own gameplay and that of the participants in my ethnographic study. This positionality tends to be neglected in game studies, however, as discussed in chapter 2, it is important to acknowledge the player-researcher's subjectivities that will inevitably inform even the most objective analysis.

As this brief discussion of the different types of identity shows, players frequently switch between their ludic and narrative focus depending on the needs of and communication by the video game. Their specific engagement with the video game can be based on a variety of personal identities; the roles presented in this section are meant to be illustrative and by no means exhaustive, and will be different for each player. In the case of the scene from *Detroit*, ludic and narrative identities are in strong competition throughout gameplay, leading to different potential choice-making rationales that determine the overall engagement with the game as well as the player's personal objectives and goals. The altercharacter itself, while a combination of the different modes of character, is particularly constructed within the framework of the player's narrative identity, where narrative and ludic choices are translated into emotionally meaningful consequences.

Chapter 6

Part I: Summary

Focusing on the ludonarratological aspects of the gaming experience, Part I of this thesis established a framework of player-character relationship based on the player's vicarious and physical connection with the player-character as well as the player's relationship with the narrative character as a separate person. Following on from this, I focused on the construction of the *altercharacter*, a third character that is a combination of both ludic and narrative character as established and changed through the player's gameplay, both in terms of ludic control and narrative interpretation based on the player's choice-making practices. Throughout this thesis I will still refer to the player-character when the individualised and interpretive aspect of the player-character relationship is not in focus.

Chapter 3 showed how the player-character relationship is initially constructed through a sensory framework that is shared between player and player-character. Particularly at the beginning of a game, the player lacks world and character context, leading to a more direct relationship between player and player-character and an initial approach to the game through the alterbiography of self (Calleja, 2011), in which in-game events are conceived of as happening to the *player* instead of the *player-character*. The degree of effectiveness of this quasi-physical impact is dependent on the real world of the player such as the specifics of the player's spatial context, but also on the player's ludic literacy. The shared sensory connection can be highlighted by the interface, increasing the player's perceived threat to themselves in addition to the threat to the character. Although player and player-character are merged through shared sensory experiences, players do not react solely on the embodied level that is in part negotiated by the player-character, but also on an extradiegetic level, focusing on the aesthetic and ludic context of the game. Shared experiences and the resulting player-character relationship can also be based on a deliberate loss or lack of interactivity or control.

By providing a shared sensory framework, player and player-character are merged in the first instance, serving to cement the player's presence within the world of the game,

both in the narrative space and the ludic – or rule – space. Once this initial connection is established, player and player-character are separated through narrative engagement, which is addressed in chapter 4. Various types of information can be accessed to present the character not only as a full-fledged narrative character, but as a person that exists outside of the specific narrative context, for instance by showing snippets of their life that refer to a life before the game. In *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2*, the player-characters' journals are a means to portray them as characters outside of their relationship with the player, and they are used to provide a different perspective on in-game events, functioning as a separate narrative device. In *Life is Strange 2* in particular, narrative compression as communicated through the journal takes away the player's sense of ownership over the story to a degree and highlights the player-character separation. The characters' rather than the game's objective interpretation of events emphasises that it is *their* story, lending them emotional and psychological depth.

The genre and the overall design of the game impact the way in which the player engages with narrative and ludic parts of the game, too. In *Life is Strange 2*, for instance, player and player-character can share a temporal, political, and social context, enhanced through additional material such as text messages. The episodic nature of the game and the strong narrative focus overall prompt high narrative engagement on the part of the player. When the narrative becomes less ubiquitous, for instance in open-world games such as *Horizon Zero Dawn*, the player-character relationship is primarily based on ludic rather than narrative engagement, although the lack of narrative information increases the player's curiosity as well. Lacking a shared context, the player initially prioritises the setting over the character to create a foundation through which to engage with and understand the narrative character.

Finally, chapter 5 focuses on the way in which player and player-character negotiate different modes of identity through gameplay. The player approaches a game based on two main identities, corresponding to the ludic and narrative modes of the game. Throughout gameplay, the player's process of making choices on behalf of the player-character establishes a contract between the two. Highlighting that this is a *contract* rather than *ownership* emphasises the initial separation of player and player-character and the conflict and cooperation that inform their relationship. The altercharacter is constructed through a merging of player and character personalities. In games with multiple player-characters, one 'main' altercharacter will be established throughout the course of the game, partially based on the degree of active impact that the player has on the character's development.

The act of making choices also leads to a sense of responsibility for ludic and narrative consequences, which in turn encourages feelings such as failure or achievement. A sense of failure in particular is caused by a clash of narrative and ludic identities as well as the player's emotional engagement with player- and non-player characters alike. A strong ludic engagement can lead to a disassociation from the narrative world by

highlighting the relationship between player and *game* rather than player and *character*, and the ludic identity itself is informed by a variety of sub-identities that determine the player's focus and personal gaming style. The game's explicit communication with the player can encourage which of the identities takes control in any given situation, which may be different from the identity that interprets and evaluates the outcomes of actions and choices.

Taking these insights about the player-game relationship as a basis, Part II of this thesis takes a closer look at the way in which players make choices in narrative video games by focusing first on the way in which choices are communicated to the player and the impact that the game's communication has on the player's justification and evaluation of their own actions. Following this, the different levels of choice-making are investigated to establish a framework of the *practice* of choice-making, as well as the emotional consequences of player choice.

Part II

Choice-Making Practices

We are 30 minutes into my first participant's session of *Life is Strange 2*. Up to this point, the session has been fairly relaxed. We have slowly gotten to know the player-character Sean and some important non-player characters: his best friend Lyla, his father Esteban, and his little brother Daniel. My participant has been busy getting supplies for the party that Sean is invited to that evening. Having played this episode myself, I know that Sean will never make it to that party, but both my participant and the player-character are blissfully unaware of the emotional drama that is about to unfold as, after being prompted by completing the game's current objectives, Sean sits down to have a video-call with Lyla and go over the final party preparations.

'Hola, loverboy,' Lyla greets Sean as her image appears on his laptop screen, 'just gimme a minute.' The camera pans behind Sean, showing him sat at his desk facing the window that overlooks the front yard before cutting back to the laptop, and Lyla and Sean continue their conversation. Lyla teases Sean about Jenn, his crush, asking what he is going to say to her tonight. 'I don't know... whatever,' Sean responds evasively. 'Do I need to practice?'

'I've seen you in action,' Lyla says. 'Yes. You're totally into her, right?' Sean's potential answers are displayed in the centre of the screen, giving the choice between 'She's super cool...' and 'So what?' The participant takes a short moment, then goes for the latter option that prompts Sean to talk about how he does not have 'any game.'

As Lyla attempts to provide some dating advice, the camera pans away from Sean's face to focus on the door to his room, and you can hear a voice call for Sean repeatedly before it opens and Daniel barges in with a zombie mask on his face and a bottle of something red in his hand, excitedly telling him that he is done: 'I made zombie blood. It's, uhm, corn syrup and food colouring...' Then he pauses, looking at the laptop screen and waving: 'Hey! Hi, Lyla...'

Sean now has the air of an annoyed older brother about him as he tells Daniel to get out even as Lyla reciprocates Daniel's wave, and he takes him by the arm to drag him out of his room. 'I was just...' Daniel protests, and Sean interrupts him, 'Just bugging the shit out of me again after I told you to knock? Yeah, I know.' He shuts the door in Daniel's face, and my participant makes a sympathetic noise as Sean goes to sit down at his desk again.

'Sean, you're an asshole,' Lyla chides him. 'What's your problem?'

'Yeah, Sean,' the participant tells the screen.

'I want to see his zombie blood if you don't!' Lyla continues. Sean's potential responses – 'You're right, sorry' and 'He's not always cute' – are separated by a

speech bubble with a red line around it, and that line starts turning black, indicating that this is a timed interaction and that the game will choose one if the participant does not. Clearly sympathetic with Daniel, the participant chooses the first option, firmly telling the screen, 'Yeah, check yourself, Sean' as the player-character apologises and says that he will make it up to him. The participant does not engage with the other interaction options on the desk – a post-it note and a lava lamp –, and Sean and Lyla resume talking. Suddenly Lyla remarks that Jenn has posted her outfit for the party. As she prompts Sean to look at her social media page, we can see Daniel walking past the window and the player temporarily has control of the camera again. They follow the prompt to check Jenn's page, revealing Sean's amazed expression – 'Woah, her hair!' – at the picture of a purple-haired girl with cat ears and drawn-on whiskers. While Sean and Lyla talk about the picture, you can hear Daniel's agitated voice in the background, but it is too quiet to exactly make out the words and they are not sub-titled, either. The participant is given the choice to comment on the picture, and they comment with a heart emoticon, laughing as they do so: 'This is an amazing comment.' Unsurprisingly, Lyla teases the awkwardly evasive Sean, and this time as the camera settles in behind Sean a new interaction pops up on the screen: looking out of the window. The participant follows it, prompting the start of a cut-scene in which Sean leans forward and sees Daniel arguing with their neighbour. 'Hold on, alright? Something's going on outside.' He rushes out of the room, ignoring Lyla's requests for clarification. I have been anxious to see my participant experience this scene, and so I watch as the cut-scene proceeds.

'Look at my shirt, asshole!' Brett, the neighbour, growls while Daniel is trying to defend himself – 'What's the big deal? It's Halloween!' Brett grabs Daniel's arm, and Sean interrupts him, pushing him away and protectively stepping in front of Daniel: 'Don't ever touch my brother! You hear me, Brett?'

'Fuck you, Diaz!' Brett proceeds to complain that Daniel got fake blood over his shirt; it is plainly visible as he talks. Daniel tries to reassure him that it was an accident, but Brett won't have any of it.

With an ominous resonating sound, time freezes and the screen changes. It is now in greyscale, split down the middle. Sean and Daniel are on the left side of the screen, giving the option 'Question Daniel.' Brett is on the right side of the screen, with the option 'Confront Brett.' The participant pushes the stick on the controller, highlighting Brett's side, which now is shown in colour, and the tense sound intensifies. The participant is evidently unsure what to do, moving the selection back to Sean and Daniel's side before settling back in the middle. They take some time to make their decision. 'Tough choice,' they exclaim with a little laugh, then they hit the button, choosing to confront Brett. 'But also, he was being a dick to a tiny kid.'

The cut-scene resumes, showing Sean again. 'Dude, step back! He didn't mean it, he's a fucking kid!' Brett retorts by insulting Daniel, leading the player-character to step up to him. Brett continues to provoke him, and soon they start pushing each other. 'You wanna go?' Brett says.

'Oh yeah, motherfucker?' Sean shoves his neighbour back.

'Then go back to your own country,' Brett continues.

The comment gets to Sean, whose answer is to punch Brett, but it also gets to my participant. 'Okay, I'm not feeling bad anymore,' they say. 'Go back to your own country?!' The fight between the two characters breaks out completely now – until a push by Sean causes Brett to fall backwards onto a stone on the lawn. Even as an overwhelmed Daniel is asking what is going on, Sean kneels down to check on him, and the sound of a police car interrupts the scene. A police officer steps up, asking the two brothers to step away to the rattled, choking sounds of Brett's breathing. Looking at the man on the floor, the officer pulls out his gun, ordering them to get on the ground. Sean is desperately trying to explain the situation, but the officer is not listening, and Sean and Daniel comply and lie down on the grass.

As the officer checks Brett's pulse, Sean's father steps out of the house. 'Oh no,' he mumbles, and runs towards the scene. The officer now points his gun at him. Sean's father is trying to diffuse the situation, explaining that they are good kids, but everyone is talking at once, even my participant who is clearly agitated: 'Oh, this is looking pretty angry...' They interrupt themselves and gasp loudly when the officer shoots. Daniel screams, the police officer is thrown back by an unseen force, and the screen goes black.

The only sound in the room now is the game's piano music. My participant stares at the screen in obvious shock. After a few moments, Sean is shown to wake up, surveying the scene – the damaged house, the burning police car, the dead officer, and he is starting to panic. 'What happened all of a sudden?' my participant asks. I don't reply, and we watch as Sean discovers Brett's dead body and, finally, that of his father. He breaks down in shock and tears, and to the sound of police sirens nearby, he tries to wake up Daniel, picking him up when it is apparent that he is unconscious. He briefly sets him down by the front door, grabs the backpack that so far has doubled as the player-character's inventory for the party, picks him up again and disappears as the police cars get closer, and the screen fades back to black.

'That's so upsetting,' my participant says. 'It's like a stupid fight.' I agree, and they ask again, 'What happened all of a sudden, did a storm or something happen? What was that blast?'

'Well, we don't know yet,' I reply cautiously, not wanting to give it away. The participant does not seem to be happy with my non-answer. With the impact of

the scene so fresh, and prompted by the game's screen informing us of the choice-based nature of the game and the consequences of the player's actions, I ask whether they felt that their actions have led them to this, and they agree. 'I felt like, oh no, I wanna take it back, I'm just gonna be a dick to my brother rather than, you know, allow this clusterfuck to happen. But also... He was a... he was a little dick. The – the neighbour. It's just really frustrating, you know. And it doesn't portray something that's not really real. Like, it is reality for many people in America at the moment if you have a less than white skin.'

They sigh. My participant is clearly upset, and I cannot blame them, remembering that I myself cried at this scene when I played the game for the first time. Even watching it now, in the capacity of a researcher, is difficult. We briefly watch the aftermath of the scene, the two brothers walking along a road, Daniel apparently unaware of what has happened while Sean is trying to put on a brave face, and on that note, we decide to wrap up this part of the session.

Chapter 7

Game Communication and Agency

7.1 Introduction

Part I of this thesis investigated the relationship between player and video game on the basis of narrative techniques, highlighting a number of points throughout the relationship at which player and character merge as well as diverge and the implications of these processes. In particular, the different levels of player identity as related to the ludic and narrative aspects of the game and the construction of the altercharacter through making choices that are emotionally significant were scrutinised, laying the foundation for a more thorough investigation of the player's choice-making practices and the ways in which they are influenced by, and influence, different aspects of the player-game relationship.

Building on these previous findings, Part II investigates player choice both on an individual game-specific level and on the level of choice-making as a *practice* that mediates the player's behaviour in conjunction with the video game's formal and technical characteristics, rather than merely being a consequence of interactivity. This practice is not only related to the game that is being played at a given moment, but is embedded in the player's gaming background and overarching and specific priorities, and is therefore dependent on the player's overall attitude towards the game and gaming as such. Continuing the discussion of the emotional impact of gaming, this part of the thesis also investigates the emotional component of choice-making.

Over the course of playing a game, and as discussed in chapter 1, the relationship between player and computer is one of two more or less equal entities that continuously act *on* and react *to* one another, lending the gaming experience an interreactive quality (Giddings, 2009; Smethurst and Craps, 2015) that is shaped through an assemblage of actors such as 'system, technologies, player, body, community, company, legal structures' (Taylor, 2009, p. 332). In considering the dynamics of agency and choice-making,

then, it is crucial to consider not only the human player's specific experience, but also the way in which player engagement is prompted, guided, and impacted by the game itself. Regardless of the technical agency that the player may or may not possess, the *experience* or interpretation of agency, even if it is at times largely illusory (Carlquist, 2002; Veugen, 2011), depends to a large part on how agency is fed back to the player. As the player's familiarity with the game increases, they will more easily understand the ways in which the game reacts to their actions directly, at the touch of a button, or indirectly, through the development of the narrative. The game's communication of agency influences how the player interacts with the game and their ludic – or lususory – attitude towards it, but also their emotional reaction, and is therefore able to feed directly into the player's emotional experience of gameplay as well. This section more closely investigates the role of different types of communication in the player's experience of agency as one of the building blocks of their choice-making practice.

As discussed previously in chapter 1.2.2, this thesis distinguishes between two main types of agency. Narrative or dramatic agency is concerned with meaningful choices within the framework of narrative. Technical agency is concerned with the player's impact within the framework of gameplay. This distinction leads to three main communicative levels that reflect on the player's choice-making in different ways: the diegetic level, the system level, and the meta level. Narrative agency is primarily reflected through the development of and changes in story and characters, wherein the player is addressed in their position as altercharacter, while technical agency tends to be addressed to the player as the person who engages with a formal game system and is reflected through written or symbolic game feedback. While narrative agency can also be partially mediated by written feedback, the distinction here is that narrative agency is mostly communicated diegetically, whereas the communication of technical agency is not typically part of the game's world and is situated at the intersection of player and game. Additionally, the player can be addressed on the meta level, which reflects on the player's formal engagement with narrative and technical choices and incorporates the single player within the context of a wider gaming community, briefly taking them out of the space that only they and the game occupy at a specific moment.

During the course of gameplay, the player's choices and their impact on the development of the game, both in technical and narrative terms, can be communicated prior to or during the making of a choice, or after a choice has been made to feed back the player's action. The first instance presents the player with their interactive possibilities, requiring them to consider the potential choices and their consequences; here, the game has the upper hand in the two-way relationship as the player ultimately has to trust the information they are provided with and use it to guide their choice-making. The latter reinforces the impression of player agency as it is a reactive communication based on the player's input, highlighting the player's role within the context of the gaming experience. Both of these modes have a distinctively different function in contextualising

the player's choice-making practices.

This chapter, then, investigates the dynamics of different kinds of game communication in feeding back, evaluating, and prompting both how players make choices and the player's engagement with their own gaming practice. Here, the player's expectation and execution of dramatic agency (Murray, 1997) is crucial as it highlights the player's powers within the game and provides them with a choice-consequence context that imbues their actions with meaning beyond their ludic impact. The above scene from *Life is Strange 2* presents the first crucial decision point in the game, drastically altering the direction and mood of the narrative in a way that Participant 3, who played the same game, described as 'jarring.' Due to the emotionally loaded content of the scene leading to the participant's interrogation of their own choice and their lack of context due to the time constraints of the ethnographic study, it will be used as a starting point to investigate the different facets of the practice of choice-making.

7.2 Pre-Choice Communication

When a game presents the player with a choice and the corresponding interactive possibilities, it is up to the player to make a decision based on the presentation of this choice as well as their understanding of the way in which the game works. However, just because a game communicates these choices in an explicit way does not mean that the implications of the player's actions and choices are easily recognisable to them, leading to situations in which players are able to determine that they have some agency, but are unable to draw the necessary conclusions that might inform their actual behaviour. This adds a degree of unpredictability and uncertainty to the overall experience.

One aspect of the execution of meaningful agency is the player's intentionality, i.e. the making of choices and taking of actions with a specific purpose or strategy in mind. Calleja (2011, p. 58) highlights that intentionality is not necessarily a main defining aspect of agency because actions and consequences can be unknown, so they cannot be intended, and in fact, '[t]he unintended and unpredictable consequences of one's actions are precisely what can make the exertion of agency in games so meaningful and compelling.' However, both throughout the ethnography and the autoethnography, the inability to at times assess the outcome of a situation had an impact on the player's enjoyment of the gaming experience. Participant 1, for instance, referred to the unpredictability of the interactivity that *Life is Strange 2* offers rather than to the outcome of narrative choices in general, talking about their frustration when 'the thing that was communicated by the little excerpt that they give you as an option does not necessarily correspond to the scenario where things unfold 100% that you would foresee if you picked that choice' (Participant 1, Interview).

This frustration is a recurring factor in my autoethnography, too, only lessening once I had consciously acknowledged that the player-character has a personal life that is apart from my own, i.e. acknowledging the personhood of the character as explored in chapter 4, and I '[came] to accept that at the end of the day he is a traumatised teenager, so naturally he will say some things that I wouldn't' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). Participant 3 extended the criticism of unpredictability to a more holistic view of gaming and gaming culture:

I get kind of frustrated with games where you don't know what's gonna happen based on a choice. And I consider that to be an indication of a bad game if I can't tell what the outcome's gonna be. Like if it's really unpredictable, you make a choice, and then something completely unpredictable happens. I find that really frustrating in the game, so that would put me off playing it more. (Participant 3, Interview)

The (in)ability to predict outcomes is only partially dependent on the game's communication as such and is also embedded in the player's overall gaming experience. Familiarity with similar games creates a type of literacy that sets the player's expectations in regards to their interactive capacities, but in the case of Participant 1, the frustration was still an issue despite this prior experience.

Some of the other case studies present their choices more explicitly. *Detroit: Become Human*, for instance, includes less information about the specific dialogue, instead often conveying an intention, action, or overall topic. At certain moments in the game, some dialogue choices in *Horizon Zero Dawn* specifically include a range of emotions – anger, reason, and compassion – to guide the player in their decision-making (see fig. 7.1). Additionally, *Detroit* also often employs ludic elements to help guide player action in numerical forms, for instance through the use of percentage bars or clue counters, wherein the player is addressed as a *player* of a game who is given information that the player-character is unable to have.

Participant 5 was outspoken about the way in which the presentation of choice and interaction was a driving factor in the approach they took during a given scene. In the interrogation scene, for instance, they – as the player – were interested in probing the deviant's memory, however the game provided a percentage bar indicating the deviant's stress level as well as determining the exact range of the optimum stress level (see fig. 7.2). Aware that probing the memory would likely increase the stress level too much, they instead chose less invasive options. In my own playthrough as part of the autoethnography, I did probe the deviant purely out of curiosity, causing him to attempt self-destruction and then to shoot Connor. However, I was clear that this was not an approach I would take normally: 'I would never have done that on first playthrough,



FIGURE 7.1: *Horizon Zero Dawn*. Aloy's emotional dialogue choices. Participant 4.



FIGURE 7.2: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 9: 'The Interrogation'. The deviant's stress level is indicated by a percentage. Participant 5.

or with any of the other characters; I already know that Connor gets replaced by another Connor when he dies' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). By providing information about the ideal outcome of the situation, the player is therefore able to determine what the 'correct' approach would be on a structural rather than character level, shifting the player's attention from making a choice to achieving a specific desired result.

Apart from the implication that the player's choices carry weight within the world of the game in a narrative sense, offering different *types* of choices suggests a degree of agency through the player's understanding of the ludic dimension of choice-making. This is done by for instance changing the actual means of interaction. In addition to the typical dialogue selection, certain options in *Life is Strange 2* are highlighted in blue following the incident with the neighbour. Participant 3 notices this change and ascribes special importance to it due to it being separate from the other interactions in the game:

Your choices change, so you can have a look at something yourself or you can share it with the brother. [...] I don't know how important it is to choose

between sharing the information with him, but that kind of implied that it was an extra choice that you've now been given. (Participant 3, Interview)

Although the player is not aware of the exact way in which the game processes these choices, they are aware that some kind of agency is conveyed in this way, and that it may be necessary to include or at least consider Daniel throughout the choice-making process. This strengthens the dynamic of the altercharacter through mirroring the player-character's narrative struggles in the player's ludic struggles. Throughout the game, Sean becomes increasingly aware of the responsibility that he has towards his younger brother and learns to actively include and listen to him. Equally, as the game progresses, the player becomes more aware of the way in which their choices impact Daniel's character development and overall behaviour, which is further explored in section 7.5.

In addition to these two types of standard choices that the player takes mostly within the context of dialogue, *Life is Strange 2* highlights certain choices in a very deliberate manner that indicates their importance for the development of the narrative. As described in the excerpt from the ethnographic session, time freezes and the player is presented with a binary choice about how to approach the confrontation with the neighbour (see fig. 7.3). As opposed to many of the other choices that sometimes have a time limit, in this situation the player is given plenty of time to consider which path to take and the potential effects thereof, an implication that Participant 1 seems to understand as well. While they typically made choices fairly quickly, they took some time to make this decision, going back and forth between confronting Daniel and confronting Brett.

Highlighting the choice in this way builds not only dramatic tension, but also the player's sense of responsibility due to the perceived importance that is attributed to the choice and the fact that they have been given ample time to think about it, implying that if they make what they perceive as a mistake, they are at fault. In this case, the player's interpretation of the choice and the choice-consequence dynamic is directly influenced by the way the game communicates it. However, this does not necessarily mean the choice carries the same kind of importance. This particular choice, whether or not to confront the neighbour, can in fact be considered a *false choice* (Andreen, 2017) that only gives an illusion of agency, but does not have a significant observable narrative impact except for Daniel's dialogue later in that episode referring to either Sean backing him up or never believing him. Whether or not the player chooses to give into the fight between Sean and the neighbour or to take a more cautious approach and question Daniel about the incident that led to the fight in the first place, the situation escalates regardless, causing the father to die and the brothers to run away and become fugitives.



FIGURE 7.3: *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1, Chapter 1: '1452 Lane Avenue, Seattle'. Confrontation with the neighbour. Participant 1.

7.3 Post-Choice Communication

Once a player has made a specific choice, it is the game's task to feed back the consequences of this choice. This is a crucial step in the player-game relationship as it highlights, more than the act of choice-making itself, that the player's actions can be understood to carry meaning within the world of the game, regardless of how much impact they actually have. This can be done implicitly through gradual changes in narrative and character developments, as well as explicitly following a choice.

While the game can feed back *that* a player supposedly has a meaningful role, it does not necessarily need to feed back *what* that effect is, once again adding a degree of uncertainty and imbalance to the player-game relationship where the game system, whose agency is distributed across a variety of actors (non-player characters, virtual environment, interface, etc.), has more insight than the player. *Life is Strange 2* in particular employs various techniques to explicitly communicate the player's agency while at the same time hiding the actual *mechanics* of agency. For instance, the symbol of the two wolf brothers is shown after a choice has been made, or after the player fails to take a certain action on time (see fig. 7.4). Whether the big or small wolf is highlighted indicates which of the two brothers will be affected by a particular choice; if both are highlighted, the choice affects both of them.

This mechanism doesn't come into play until after the father's death. Although the symbol itself accompanies the statement that choices have consequences in this game and the 'How to Play' section of the game explains that the symbol of the little wolf is shown to indicate that an action will have an effect on Daniel, the meaning of it is not communicated clearly and organically during gameplay in a way that is immediately obvious to the player. For this reason, it does not necessarily increase the player's feeling of agency. In opposition to the wolf brother symbol, *Life is Strange* is more explicit in communicating player agency, with significant choices being followed by

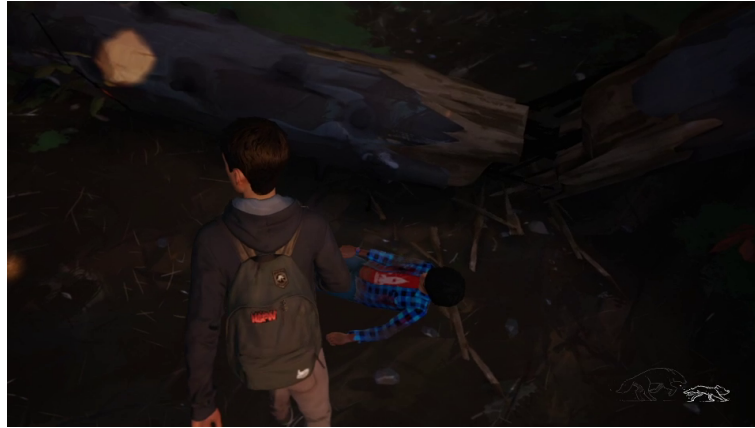


FIGURE 7.4: *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1, Chapter 2: 'Into the Woods'. Wolf brother symbol with Daniel's wolf highlighted. Autoethnography.



FIGURE 7.5: *Life is Strange*, Episode 1. The game states that the choice has consequences. Autoethnography.

the written statement 'This choice will have consequences' (see figure 7.5). However, *Life is Strange* thematises choice-making and agency within its main narrative and the specific gameplay mechanics of the player-character's ability to rewind time, which necessitates a clearer communication to prompt the player to reflect on their choices and the altercharacter's potential desire to redo a specific action.

Although in this example, the game's communication of agency is more straightforward, having agency communicated in this way does not rid the player of uncertainty; it merely shifts from uncertainty about the choice to uncertainty about the outcome. Participant 2 for instance was unclear about the consequence of the written statement:

I didn't fully understand if that meant – if it's the thing I'd just done or if I choose this, by turning left and walking out of the door, will that have consequences? That wasn't entirely clear to me. It's interesting, I don't think I really understood what those consequences were going to be. (Participant 2, Interview)

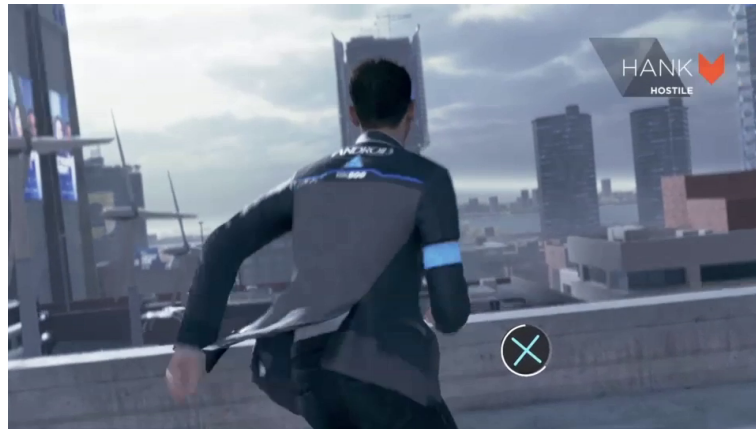


FIGURE 7.6: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 15: 'The Nest'. The relationship with Hank becomes hostile as a consequence of the player's choice. Autoethnography.

While this may in part be due to their unfamiliarity with these particular gaming conventions, they generally experienced a high degree of agency overall, both in technical and narrative terms due to the game's rewind mechanics, although interestingly they did not use this function much for narrative purposes. The only choice they consciously changed for narrative rather than gameplay purposes was the last choice before the end of the session, where they decided to rewind to confront David instead of taking his picture. This decision was prompted not by the game's written note (although it accompanies the choice), but by Kate's upset reaction, which made them feel 'guilted or shamed by having made that decision.' They also pointed out that the existence of the rewind mechanism might have had an influence on their feelings towards the choice in the first place: 'If I didn't have the chance to rewind it, would I have regretted it?' (Participant 2, Interview) In this way, the game's communication of agency feeds directly into the player's perceived agency as well as their emotional relationship with the process of choice-making as such.

Life is Strange's statement is incredibly vague, emphasising merely *that* there is a consequence to a specific choice, but not what this consequence is specifically. This is where *Detroit*, which has demonstrated a higher focus on ludic transparency, differs in displaying the main stats of the game and immediately indicating the effect that a choice has on them (see fig. 7.6). The effect of the player's choices is evaluated by the game through Public Opinion, referring to the public's perception of androids based on the events and actions throughout the game, the relationship levels for specific non-player characters, and in the case of Connor, Software Instability denoting his relationship to his programming and his degree of deviation from it. This is what I consider communication on the 'system level' of the game, i.e. the player is given some insight into the numerical values underpinning the mechanics of the game.

While these stats show more clearly the area of the game that is going to be affected, it is up to the player to make an assessment of the potential consequences their actions

might cause. As discussed in chapter 5, I used these stats to make a preliminary assessment of my choice, but it was not until I was faced with the narrative consequence of Hank's hostility, which the game implied to be a *direct* result of my action, that I had an emotional reaction of regret and guilt. This example, as well as the previous example of Participant 2's decision to change their choice based on Kate's reaction, emphasises that having a narratively integrated reaction to a choice is more effective in making the player reflect on their choices due to the emotional dimension of the relationship between altercharacter and non-player character.

7.4 Meta Communication

It may be argued that a game system addressing the player on a player rather than character level always carries a meta element with it as it takes place outside of the game's immersive or incorporated space, but the space between player, game, and the real world can be used to further communicate and impact choice-making outside of the presentation and feedback of specific choices that takes place during gameplay. Both the *Life is Strange* series and *Detroit: Become Human* present the player's choice statistics at regular intervals. The *Life is Strange* games highlight a number of specific situations and the player's responses at the end of an episode, while *Detroit* offers a more holistic overview by presenting the player with a flowchart after each chapter that shows the pathways that the player has taken as well as the points where pathways diverge. Both of these approaches have an impact on the way in which the player interprets and contextualises their past actions, setting specific expectations for their future gameplay. They are also imbued with information about global choice stats through which a direct comparison with other players can be made.

The games' different approaches to turning gameplay behaviour into data that can be analysed by the player provide insights into the relationship between the game's evaluation of player activity and the player's emotional involvement that results from being an active choice-maker within the game. This analysis of player behaviour is the game's most explicit and transparent way of communicating agency. Highlighting specific player choices draws attention to the fact that even though the player may not understand the specific significance of them for the game as a whole, they have some relevance for its progression. This is similar to the way in which Participant 3 talked about how the change in choice mechanics implied some agency, but were unsure about the relevance of these choices.

In *Life is Strange 2*, the fact that two characters are explicitly affected by the choices that the player makes means that the evaluation of the global choices, where 'global' is understood geographically, focuses not only on the choices that the player has made via the player-character, but also on the actions that Daniel did or did not (have to) do as a



FIGURE 7.7: *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1. Global Choice Overview, page 1. Autoethnography.



FIGURE 7.8: *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1. Global Choice Overview, page 5. Autoethnography.

trickle-down effect from the player's cumulative choices. Fig. 7.7 and 7.8 show some of the choice feedback that the game presents at the end of the first episode, first focusing on Sean's, i.e. the player's explicit choices, such as whether or not Sean confronted Brett, showing that the majority of global players (70%) made the choice to confront him. Following these direct actions, the impact on Daniel is highlighted.

Given that this is the first time the player receives this type of information, this can be understood not only as a way to give the player an overview of their choices and their behaviour within the context of the global gaming culture, but also as a way for the game system to show the player which actions may carry which kinds of consequences. In this case, the game highlights that not only Sean is affected, but Daniel is as well. In showing that the effect on Daniel is an important enough factor in the context of the overall game to be mentioned explicitly, the game trains the player to be able to more easily recognise or expect when their actions might carry the potential for agency.

As the participants in the ethnographic study only played a relatively short part of the first episode, they were not confronted with this kind of overview, but throughout the

autoethnography I recognise the effect of this feedback and the way in which it determines my own choice-making behaviour as well as my feelings and attitude towards the game and characters. This shows that these choice statistics are used not only to evaluate one's own behaviour, but also as a tool to help shape one's own choice-making practice as it draws attention to the kinds of factors that may become an issue:

throughout this [first] episode I've been incredibly anxious about taking care of Daniel, especially because I don't know what kinds of things are going to have what effect on him. [...] When the game showed me the choices that I had made vs. the global choices at the end of the credits, it did say that Daniel didn't eat enough, so apparently that's something I need to be mindful of as well. (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

In the moment of making a specific choice, the player is typically unaware of the different potential outcomes; this uncertainty can cause an uncomfortable kind of anxiety as the player is trying to predict the result of their own actions. By presenting alternative outcomes after the fact, the player is able to better understand what the game expects of them and, in turn, what the player can expect from the game. Fig. 7.8 for instance gives different outcomes for Daniel – 'Daniel had an ok night,' 'Daniel got sick from the berries,' and 'Daniel was afraid of your stories and had nightmares.' At this point in the game, the player has had no indication that these were different possible outcomes of the first night in the woods, but being provided with them raises the player's expectations of agency, knowing that what appeared to be fairly minor choices could have some kind of impact.

The first time the global stats are shown also prompts me as a player to start making the connection between my choices and Daniel's behaviour, for instance when seeing that in my playthrough, Daniel didn't steal anything: 'So I guess maybe that would have been if I had asked him to steal [in a previous choice], maybe then he would have actually stolen something from Brody' (Autoethnography, *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 1, Session 3). Here, I recognise that my actions trickle down to Daniel's behaviour, although I am not explicitly aware of the actual way in which these choices are processed on a system level.

During the autoethnography, being presented with this overview causes an observable shift from a general anxiety throughout the first episode, in which I was unsure how the game would react to my choices and whether or not they would become relevant both from a ludic and a narrative point of view, to a more specific anxiety about the choice dynamic that leads me to re-evaluate my own attitude towards characters and gameplay in relation to the outcomes that were perceived as negative, such as the aforementioned awareness of Daniel not having eaten enough: 'I'm enjoying that we have

the puppy now, she's very cute, but I'm already wondering how we'll afford to feed her (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

Transferring the worry about Daniel that the game has built up to a different non-player character that is also very vulnerable helps strengthen the relationship with that non-player character, too. 30 minutes into the next episode, I start wondering once again about how expensive the upkeep will be, but I have also formed a clear attachment with the dog: 'If something happened to Mushroom, I would be extremely upset' (Autoethnography, *Life is Strange 2*, Episode 2, Session 4). Consequently, when Mushroom dies only 45 minutes after voicing my concerns, I am shocked and heartbroken, although in my post-episode reflections I consider the narrative logic of this, too: 'I was afraid of something happening to her because, well, I know how stories work' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). This shows that the player's expectations are not only related to the ludic literacy that they have built up through continued engagement with video games in general and in a genre-specific sense, but also draw on the player's overall media literacy, in this case an understanding of dramatic progression.

The choice-consequence communication of *Life is Strange 2*, then, keeps the specific dynamics of agency veiled – the player still doesn't know what kind of effect their choices have long-term – while at the same time raising the player's expectation of their own impact within the space of the game. This lends itself to a more cautious approach of evaluating one's choices not only when they seem narratively significant, but also on a moment-to-moment basis when considering more small-scale, seemingly insignificant choices, leading the player to consider their impact as *altercharacter* rather than their impact as *player*.

In opposition to this, *Detroit's* flowchart at the end of each chapter shows not only the specific path the player took, but also the existence, albeit not the details, of alternative paths (see fig 7.9). The overall intent and information is the same and the player is at times even presented with less choice-specific information than in the case of *Life is Strange 2*, which does include the alternative choices or outcomes from the beginning. Instead, it gives insights into the actual mechanics and make-up of the game, albeit not offering much information about alternative choices. Presenting a chapter as an actual flowchart that shows the player exactly where the different paths diverge, at which points they are coming back together again and at which they start yielding different end results of a scene highlights the status of the game as something that is played, appealing to a completionist attitude.

When evaluating the flowcharts, my language is markedly different from the language I use when discussing *Life is Strange 2*. Rather than focusing on what I have done and the potential implications of my choices with a look towards future episodes, I am encouraged to take a look back instead, noting the completion level of the chapter. While some aspects are narratively interesting to me as well, I am mainly concerned

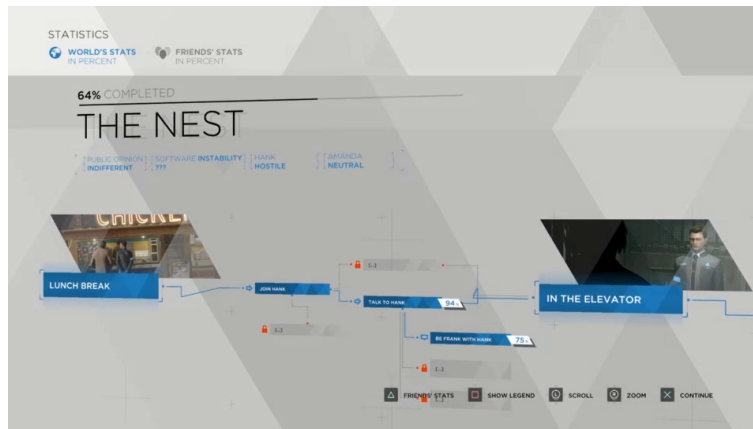


FIGURE 7.9: *Detroit: Become Human*, Chapter 15: 'The Nest'. The flowchart at the end of the chapter shows the player's choices and the current stats. Autoethnography.

with the different content that I might be able to experience on a different or future playthrough. This, however, means that when it comes to evaluating my agency, I am conscious of the mechanics that are driving it, at least visibly, and of learning at regular intervals what I did in the context of the overall game. It should be noted that the flowcharts are shown at the end of each chapter, leaving considerably less time between these evaluations than in the case of *Life is Strange 2*, thereby taking the player out of the immersive space of the altercharacter and reminding them of their own status and identity as a player who is *experiencing*, rather than *making*, a story. The distinction here is that when the player thinks of themselves as the player of a game, the artificial nature of the game itself is highlighted; while they are still making the decisions, they are more aware of the fact that they are experiencing pre-written content. When they consider themselves to be a part of the ludonarrative space via the altercharacter, they are an active participant who shapes the story itself.

As mentioned previously, not only the player's own behaviour is analysed and presented in these overviews; they also reflect the global statistics of players. The integration of individual player statistics within a wider dataset drawing on global player statistics has been used widely as a reward for the player with a focus on their achievements, and as a way to integrate their gameplay within their social network through sharing their achievements (Medler, 2011). In the case of *Life is Strange*, *Life is Strange 2*, and *Detroit: Become Human*, however, these statistics are not made to be shared across a social network – there is no button to do so within the game –, but instead offer the player the opportunity to evaluate their own behaviour more objectively. At the same time, it raises the awareness that the player has essentially shared this particular experience with a wider community. In this way, a semi-social component is added to the experience of a single-player game, strengthening the player's sense of belonging to a wider gaming culture. Even though in this case, the *activity* of gaming itself is still a solitary one, the *practice* of gaming becomes a social one that extends beyond the moment of gameplay itself (Thornham, 2016). The presentation of global game stats in this

way not only highlights the different choice options, but also adds an additional layer of evaluation and judgement to the player's choice-making practices, appealing to the player's identity as a gamer and potentially to their competitive side as discussed in chapter 5.4.

The possibility of comparison with other players' performances gives the player what feels like an objective benchmark to evaluate their own behaviour. When considering these overviews at the end of each episode, I often ended up comparing my choices with those of other players, at times voicing reassurance when one of my choices was made by the majority of players, too, and a degree of surprised satisfaction when a negative effect was apparently experienced by a majority of players, but my own choice put me in the minority. Indeed, I was deliberately using these stats to determine whether the choices that I had made were the 'right' or 'wrong' ones, reassured that if the majority of players had made a choice that I had considered right, it might have been the 'correct' one. This focus on making choices that are perceived of as 'correct' and the distinction between 'ludically correct' and 'morally right' is further addressed in chapter 8.

Communicating with the player directly outside of gameplay, but still within the space of the game as an object encourages the player to consider their actions from a more rational standpoint instead of the more instinctive or emotionally charged response to choices during gameplay. This focus on rationality does not necessarily need to coincide with a ludic perspective, but can also encompass a narrative perspective in considering the player's plans for narrative or character development. As this analysis shows, making the player aware of their choices in a more structured way can take them out of the immersive space, as tends to be the case in *Detroit*, but it can also be used as a way for the game to teach the player about the mechanics, setting specific expectations for future play and allowing the player to refine their behaviour in accordance with their overall practice of choice-making.

7.5 Communicating Control

As discussed in the previous sections, one of the game's responsibilities throughout the process of playing is to teach the player how to play in a way that, ideally, does not interfere with their notion of freedom, regardless of how much freedom the player is actually offered. This is done not only through written feedback, but also through narrative and character development as the game essentially tries to shape the player into a kind of ideal or 'implied' player (Aarseth, 2007), highlighting the fact that at the end of the day, players are ultimately restricted in their interaction with a game. The exact degree of being in control and being controlled varies depending on the design and scope of the game: an open-world game like *Horizon Zero Dawn*, for instance, gives

the player more freedom in terms of how and when to approach their quests and interact with the world, while the other case studies do not offer this kind of freedom of movement. Ultimately, however, the player is rarely able or advised to do something that the game has not intended. At the same time, the negotiation of control is one of the main attractions of playing an interactive game. As laid out in chapter 1.2.2, agency is closely connected to making choices that are considered *meaningful* and significant, suggesting that the player wants to feel in control to some degree, but as Veugen (2011) highlights, the subjective feeling of agency is at times more important than having actual technical agency. At the same time, as Giddings and Kennedy (2008, p. 30) point out, one of the pleasures in playing a video game is also ‘being controlled, [...] being *acted upon*,’ i.e. experiencing a lack of control.

These notions of agency are not exclusive. The player can still derive pleasure from feeling as if they exerted agency, be that dramatic or technical, but the moments in which they are *acted upon* drive the game forward by presenting the player with ludic or narrative conflict. This emphasises the essential collusion between the player and the game system: the narrative, and the gaming experience as a whole, emerges from the negotiation between the two entities, which can be cooperative or competitive depending on the exact context (Ferri, 2007). Taking an active role within the game creates an underlying assumption of agency, a kind of ‘ambient agency’ that is embedded in the game’s ludic and narrative spaces, and that is the default until proven otherwise. This thesis however focuses not on the design of agency, but primarily considers the way in which the player processes and interprets their control, or lack of control, within the game. This means that while not offering agency in a mechanical sense, illusory agency – the responsibility that is communicated to the player even if they do not actually carry responsibility for an outcome – can in many ways be more impactful for the player’s emotional engagement than the ambient agency that is embedded within the structures of the game. In this sense, this thesis focuses on the player’s *experience* of agency and the emotional consequences thereof. This experience of agency is not a property that automatically emerges from interactivity, but is instead situated in the communicative relationship between game system and player.

The game, then, has to navigate a careful line between prompting and teaching the player and providing a sense of agency, control, and responsibility. In order to communicate meaningful dramatic and functional agency to the player, the game first needs to give the player the feeling that their actions matter within the space of the game. Secondly, the player needs to be able to encounter challenges that raise the stakes of the game itself, creating a conflict that needs to be overcome. As the previous sections show, the feedback provided during gameplay, the feedback that is directed at the player outside of gameplay, and the player’s ability to make informed choices are all crucial in assigning a sense of responsibility that carries with it emotionally significant consequences.

Throughout gameplay, the player is expected to learn which choices may be more relevant than others and how the game reacts to and processes the player's actions in general. However, a high level of predictability would limit the player's stake in the game as well, making it into a less meaningful experience overall. In order to raise the stakes for the player, then, a degree of uncertainty needs to be implemented. This can be done through reducing predictability both on a narrative and system level. Although a degree of frustration was voiced both by participants and myself regarding the unpredictability of certain actions, this frustration, while reducing a player's sense of *control*, did not necessarily negate the fact that players were aware that they had agency at all. After all, causing unintended consequences still gives the player the power to have an impact, albeit not in a wholly informed manner.

In the case of *Life is Strange 2*, as discussed in section 7.2, the game presents three main types of choices: the standard in-dialogue choices that sometimes appear to be mundane and inconsequential, choices that are specifically related to Daniel and his relationship with Sean, and narratively significant binary choices that appear to place the player at a crossroads. The impression of major and minor choices that is generated by this, however, is not necessarily consistent with the choice-consequence system that takes place on a system level, i.e. the actual values (technically, not morally speaking) that are associated with the respective choices. Instead, the choice-consequence system in *Life is Strange 2* is subtle and complex, with certain actions increasing or decreasing the two stats of Brotherhood and Morality behind the scenes and determining Daniel's behaviour not only in individual episodes, but also across episodes:

Daniel's Morality state determines how he acts in any given situation. Does he act in a kind and considerate way, or is he entirely selfish, without regard for other people's feelings or safety? [...] Daniel's Brotherhood state determines how he responds to what you, as Sean, teach and ask of him. Does he trust you to make the right choice for the two of you, or will he disregard what you say because you've been unable to win his trust? [...] While major choices will have a greater impact on Daniel's education overall, the lessons they teach him can still be outweighed by the many smaller choices you may make throughout your journey and the example you set. (Square Enix, 2019, par. 5)

The choices in *Life is Strange 2*, then, are accumulative rather than depending on specific branching within the narrative, and while the game clearly states that choices do have consequences and highlights a few specific choices at the end of each episode within the context of global choice-making behaviours, the player is never able to see these points. According to Square Enix (2019), the first episode alone features sixteen choices that affect Daniel's Brotherhood or Morality, however this is not always communicated clearly by the game, as the meaning of the wolf brother symbol can be easily

missed by players. In fact, *Life is Strange 2* is deliberately opaque about the existence of the Brotherhood and Morality values in order to give players the opportunity to ‘experience Life is Strange 2 using [their] own personal feelings about right and wrong as a guide, rather than trying to “build” a specifically good or evil and obedient or rebellious Daniel’ (Square Enix, 2019, par. 21). In doing so, the game sets the player’s expectations for agency while at the same time raising their uncertainty by obfuscating the actual effects of certain choices. As the game progresses through the different episodes, the mechanism is presented in an implicit manner as it becomes clear that Sean’s choices are reflected in Daniel’s behaviour and the overall relationship between the brothers, which in turn has a clear impact not only on inter-character interactions but also on the narrative itself.

Whether or not a game is transparent about the way in which it evaluates player choice depends on the goals and mood of the game, too. Being open about the game’s inner workings gives more power to the player by increasing their understanding of the system itself and giving them the ability to make more informed choices. This in turn takes away an element of uncertainty, which however might have an effect on the player’s emotional engagement due to highlighting the artificial nature of the player-game relationship. However, giving the player feedback in this manner takes them out of the immersive (narrative) space. If these mechanics are hidden from the player, they are able to base their choices on the altercharacter rather than their ludic goals or personal preference, in a way forcing the player to establish a stronger connection with the character.

The tension between predictability and unpredictability and between agency and a lack thereof is an interesting one in the context of interactive fiction, given that, according to Salen and Zimmerman (2004, p. 174) ‘[u]ncertainty is a central feature of every game’ and plays a key role in creating meaningful play by raising the stakes of the game and assigning value to the player’s actions. On the one hand, coping with this type of uncertainty and the game’s reaction to certain player actions is dependent on the game teaching the player what kinds of expectations they can have of the game and vice versa (Giddings and Kennedy, 2008). On the other hand, being confronted with those consequences and learning more about how the game reacts to player input may increase the player’s certainty that actions *do* matter, possibly even which kinds of actions, but it also increases the player’s potential for anxiety, which is a recurring theme throughout my autoethnography. In the context of this thesis, uncertainty can be considered from different angles: the game’s communication of agency or non-agency, the emotional impact of uncertainty, and the struggle between narrative and technical control. These different perspectives can shed some light on the *experience* of choice-making, rather than simply the *making* of a choice.

This chapter highlighted one of the most transparent ways in which player and game work together to create a coherent, fluid gaming experience by taking a closer look at

how the game feeds back the player's interactive role. The conceptualisation of agency as a communicative matter that relies on the interplay between the game's feedback and the player's interpretation allows us to step outside the confines of the debate of whether or not the properties of interactivity and the player's narrative interests can be equally satisfied throughout the gaming experience. This makes room for an in-depth investigation of player behaviour that fully acknowledges the complexity of the player-game relationship. In this vein, the next chapter takes a closer look at the player's choice-making behaviours both on the scale of the individual game and in a wider context, feeding into the conceptualisation of choice-making as a practice.

Chapter 8

Choice-Making Behaviours

8.1 Introduction

If I didn't have the chance to rewind it, would I have regretted it? You know, and if she hadn't... For sure I would have felt bad just like that, but coincidentally because it did come up straight away, I felt that maybe I should go back and try to stand up. Even though I really didn't want to encounter that creepy guy. But I did it anyway. (Participant 2, Interview)

Participant 2's musings about their sense of regret being potentially caused by the existence of the rewind mechanism, previously addressed in chapter 7.3, hint at the power that the game and its ludic properties inevitably seem to have on the player's experience, shaping their minute-to-minute behaviour and the way in which they consider their relationship to game and character. The significance of the game's communication in shaping choice-making behaviours and the player's overall approach to the scene, i.e. a ludic or narrative focus, was also evident in the case of *Detroit*. As discussed previously, the game not only has a strong transparency about the fact that the player has a high degree of narrative agency, but communicates the impact of certain choices by, for instance, showing an increase or decrease in the game's main stats. Chapter 5 also touched upon the way in which the gameplay stats can impact the player's relationship with the altercharacter and non-player characters, highlighting the different kinds of approaches that the player might choose for an interaction.

Building on the player's understanding of gameplay and choice-making that, as explored in chapter 7, is prompted by the game's communication, and with a look to continue the investigation of the different layers of the gaming experience, this chapter focuses more specifically on the ways in which players actually make choices at different stages in the gaming experience. Here, the distinction of micro and macro levels to describe the player's engagement temporally or interactively that was first addressed

in chapter 1 needs to be highlighted. Throughout the analysis, I use the notion of micro and macro choices as described by Salen and Zimmerman (2004, p. 61):

The *micro* level represents the small, moment-to-moment choices a player is confronted with during a game. The *macro* level of choice represents the way these micro-choices join together like a chain to form a larger trajectory of experience.

In the context of this chapter and the analysis of the player's choice-making behaviours, then, the micro level focuses on the player's specific behaviour and attitude that is largely independent of the game's wider context, i.e. choices that are made on a smaller scale without the intention to shape the overall game progression in a particular way. The macro level describes the player's behaviour in regards to the overall progression of the game and includes choices that are based on the player's understanding of the game as a whole. This understanding takes place both on a system level, such as the player's expectations about how the game processes certain actions and choices, and on a story level in the player's plans and predictions regarding narrative or character development. As the deliberate macro choice-making depends on the development of the player-game relationship through continued engagement, this chapter primarily draws on the ethnographic data to investigate the micro level as the participants only played a short segment of the game, and on the autoethnographic data to delve deeper into macro choice-making.

Finally, the players' overall approach to choice-making is explored, highlighting the fact that it is not merely an activity, but that choice-making should instead be conceptualised as a practice that is embedded in a wider personal and cultural context. From the perspective of the player's incorporation into the game, Calleja (2011) describes the player's immediate engagement with the game during the act of playing as 'micro involvement,' whereas macro involvement is related to the player's engagement with a game outside of the act of playing, including pre- as well as post-gaming experiences and the 'ongoing motivation to interact with the game and the off-line thinking that fuels it' (p. 37). In the context of Calleja's model of incorporation, this means that the player's experience of a video game extends beyond the actual act of playing or the individual gaming session, with each of the dimensions of involvement manifesting differently in these phases.

To avoid terminological misunderstandings, when referring to micro and macro levels throughout this chapter I only refer to the micro and macro levels of choice, as opposed to the micro and macro levels of the player's involvement. However, this thesis extends the notion of Calleja's macro involvement by considering not only the temporal aspect of the player's various levels of engagement, but, more specifically, the construction of the player's behavioural *patterns*. This chapter in particular sets out the practice

of choice-making as building on the player's overall engagement with this and other games, drawing on their ludic and narrative literacy as well as their own motivations and personality traits. Here, the narrative context, the player's understanding of their own agency, and the guidelines and rationales that underpin the player's decisions will also be examined in order to better understand how choice-making moves from behavioural patterns within a singular gaming experience to a phenomenon that is embedded in a wider gaming culture.

8.2 Micro Choice-Making

With the participants playing only short segments of the games, they had not spent enough time with them yet to learn how the games react to and process their decisions, thereby still relying heavily on the game to feed back their actions and set their expectations accordingly. For instance, although Participant 3 was aware of the change in choice-making mechanics after the confrontation with the neighbour, as discussed in chapter 7.2, they were unable to determine the reasoning behind it and the potential effect that these choices might have on gameplay. This change in gameplay mechanics also suggests that there is a clear cut between the fairly minor choices that were made prior to this scene and those coming after. In the ethnographic study, this led to an overall lower perception of agency for Participant 1 and Participant 3, although Participant 1 was more cautious in denouncing agency completely, pointing out that while they had trouble seeing how their actions mattered apart from the confrontation with the neighbour, they had not played the game long enough to see the outcome of their choices.

Overall, all participants were outspoken and aware about the different factors driving their choice-making within the sessions. As a rule and as explored in chapter 5, their choices were based to a large extent on the player-character's personality and on keeping in line with the narrative. In addition, other factors driving their minute-to-minute choice-making were the participants' own personality, eventually merging into the altercharacter, humorous dialogue options where applicable in the case of Participant 1, and the participant's own sense of morality in the case of Participant 3: 'I don't want to steal from a car personally, so I don't want my character to, because it's kind of like a reflection on your sort of personality' (Participant 3, Interview). Generally, as shown in chapter 4, the participants' play styles ranged from being highly exploratory, i.e. engaging with the different information about narrative and characters where possible, to being more objective-oriented, where players engaged with parts of the game only if they seemed to be relevant for the continuation of the game and narrative.

Occasionally, players chose to pursue paths that were relevant neither for the continuation of the narrative nor for the overall game objective. In *Life is Strange*, for instance,

Participant 5 observed that their focus frequently switched between ludic and narrative, mostly in between chapters, but occasionally within the chapters themselves depending on the game objectives and the game's communication thereof. The investigation, for instance, was entirely gameplay-focused due to the mechanics of the clue counter (see fig. 8.2), while the chapters focusing on Kara and Markus were driven by more narrative decisions, with Kara's storyline suggesting the highest degree of narrative agency for the player. In the interrogation chapter, Participant 5 again focused primarily on gameplay due to the percentage bar indicating the deviant's stress level, but they continued to switch between ludic and narrative approaches throughout the scene:

One of the options was go through his memory, and that seemed like that would put too much stress on him, so I wouldn't get the optimum confession. But equally it was a choice I wanted to make. But I was driving myself by the – get to the end and get the results the game wants to you to get. But then at the end when he was being taken away it didn't seem to make any difference. [...] So that was more narrative based off I guess trying to develop your character or otherwise. (Participant 5, Interview)

Participant 5's reasoning of which choices to pursue is of a similar nature to my own struggles in 'The Nest' as discussed in chapter 5, extending to other scenes as well. Along with the different gaming styles, Participant 5 made an effort to make choices that were in line with the character narratives as long as they didn't affect gameplay negatively. The emotional setting of Kara's storyline however caused them to focus more on their own wishes as well: 'I didn't like the fact that he was trying to beat up his kid [...] even if there'd been an escape option, I was already looking for the attempt to beat him up. Regardless of whether that would be the right approach, it's what I wanted to do' (Participant 5, Interview). Here, the participant seemed to make a clear distinction between the character's personality and their own wishes, which may or may not align, highlighting the role of their own identity in the choice-making process as discussed previously.

Life is Strange, *Life is Strange 2*, and *Detroit: Become Human* are all similar in their strong narrative focus, causing the participants to display the same kinds of narrative- and character-prompted behaviour. As an open-world game, *Horizon Zero Dawn* forms an interesting contrast to the other case studies. As the section played took place about an hour into the game, there was less need for the game to explicitly coach the player unless a new mechanism came up, leaving the participant to figure out gameplay on their own. Accordingly, most of Participant 4's interaction choices were based on establishing a greater familiarity with the game's ludic system: they were almost entirely focused on exploring the game world and engaging with the more basic gameplay objectives and mechanics, such as looting, combat, crafting, and levelling up. In order

to do this, they chose not to follow the main quest that they were presented with. Instead, they followed smaller side-quests to become more proficient at the game before engaging with it narratively:

I thought because I'm quite early on, I don't really know what I'm doing and how to find stuff, so I thought I'd pick the kind of low ranking quests. [...] The first quest I chose was the hunting one so that I could test my skills, because I'm not very good at shooting and stuff. So I thought I'd get some practice and stuff. But it was actually harder than I thought it would be. Quite a lot harder. (Participant 4, Interview)

The main choices that Participant 4 made were gameplay-related, and they felt that those did give them a degree of agency over the character's development. Here, they specifically highlighted that they were deliberately exploring the interface as a representation of the way in which the game works in general: 'I kind of wanted to see how it worked as well. So like doing a few of these clicking on things, see what happens, just to see how that works and get a bit of practice, and then I'd come back to it later on, realise I'd made a mistake probably.' Without the more straightforward narrative guidance of the other case studies, then, the player's focus was first on becoming better at the game before engaging with longer and presumably more demanding quests. As the quests were chosen primarily for their rewards and their requirements, the participant did not pay much attention to the associated narratives, either, at least not as a factor that determined the choice of the quest. Instead, Participant 4 was more focused on convenience over narrative, deliberately choosing quests that were shown to be nearby and rejecting those that seemed to be too far away as they prioritised learning the game quickly, perhaps due to the time constraints of the study, over the actual content of the side quests.

As part of making these decisions that primarily have an impact on the player's ludic experience, Participant 4 chose options that they considered immediately useful for gameplay. For instance, rather than crafting everything that they were able to craft with their given resources, they chose to only increase their weapons and resources satchels to be able to carry more of those items, but decided not to increase any of the other satchels as they did not seem to be immediately relevant to them. In doing this, they were able to see the impact of only a few choices, which once again forms part of learning how to play the game in the first place. However, they chose not to modify their outfit or weapon, the most relevant parts to modify with the most noticeable impact on gameplay, as they were unsure which of the available modifications would be more appropriate for them, pointing out, 'There's probably not much point doing extra stuff if I don't know what I need' (Participant 4, Gameplay Session).

Participant 4 spent much more time levelling up the player-character (see fig. 8.3), going through the different options and deliberating which would be relevant for their



FIGURE 8.3: *Horizon Zero Dawn*. The player chooses which skills to level up. Participant 4.

gaming style. Eventually they settled on skills to improve critical hit damage, to take down small enemies silently, and to increase the damage of certain types of attacks – the latter chosen after they decided they wanted to have ‘something interesting.’ The choices made here may be in part a reflection on the set-up of the study – being aware that the time spent with the game is limited may have prompted the participant to choose options that seemed immediately relevant rather than taking a more long-term perspective. However, Participant 4’s overall ludic engagement highlights the necessity for the player to first have a good understanding of what the game expects them to do and what types of feedback the game is going to give them before they commit to a certain path.

Without the guidance that players might receive from a more holistic view of the game and the overarching narrative and choice-consequence dynamics, then, the players’ micro choices were determined by three factors. Firstly, players tended to make choices that gave them quick, immediate gratification. This could take for instance the form of humour for Participant 1, or the form of instant quest rewards for Participant 4. Secondly, since the participants had no sense of the overarching narrative yet or the shape they would like this narrative to take, they prioritised making choices that were in line with the player-character’s established personality. Thirdly, players made decisions that were important for their own experience of the game as well, such as Participant 2’s decision to take a moment to rest in Max’s room as both player and player-character had just been through a lot.

Many of these initial choices serve as a way not only to understand and start constructing the altercharacter, but also to test both the expectations and the possibilities of the game itself, i.e. testing out how the game reacts to specific player interactions. This helps players carve out their own role within the player-game relationship and highlights the communicative and collaborative dynamic thereof, where the players are aware of the game system as an entity that helps guide their behaviour.

8.3 Macro Choice-Making

The previous section investigated the player's micro choice-making behaviour in relation to the beginning of the game, or relative beginning in the case of *Horizon Zero Dawn*, which is heavily coloured by the player's negotiation of their own and the game's expectations as well as the initial understanding of the implied player (Aarseth, 2007). Particularly in the learning stages of playing the game, or after long breaks in engagement, the player is necessarily at a disadvantage, lacking a full understanding of the narrative and the underlying mechanics that process player choice and relying on narrative, character, and ludic exposition. As the game progresses, however, the player is able to assume a stronger sense of responsibility for the altercharacter's choices and the narrative development as such.

The increased understanding of the game, its narrative, and the player's impression of agency as emerging from the negotiation of control discussed in chapter 7.5, regardless of whether this agency is technical or illusory, means that players need to make a conscious decision about the driving force behind their actions. Extending the discussion of the different levels of player engagement in chapter 5, the player's underlying focus can be of a ludic or a narrative nature. Specifically, an in-depth investigation of the choice-making behaviours that manifest throughout the autoethnography reveals that the choices driven by a ludic rationale are typically aimed towards the fulfilment of the player's personal objectives, the specific gameplay objectives with a focus on a completionist, competitive attitude, or the demonstration (even if it is to no-one) of correct and skillful gameplay. The narrative choice-making rationales were overall divided between the explicit construction of the altercharacter and the development of the narrative itself.

The different priorities or dispositions are not necessarily mutually exclusive – a course of action that is taken for the purpose of fulfilling specific ludic objectives may also at the same time fulfill specific narrative objectives. Where they are at odds with one another, however, the player has to make a conscious decision based on their priorities at any given moment. This is something that I was explicitly aware of in my own choice-making behaviour, necessitating a conscious choice of the grounds upon which specific choices are made. In *Life is Strange 2*, for instance, I acknowledged that 'there is a very strong distinction between what is good in terms of gameplay objectives, and what would be good or right in terms of narrative and character development' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). This section, then, covers the different levels of choice-making as observed through prolonged engagement with the games.

8.3.1 Narrative Choices

Principally, the choices that were observed on the micro level, i.e. the maintenance of choices that were in line with the character's personality, carry over to the observations on the macro choice level, too. Here, the distinction is that rather than taking the game's lead and maintaining the image that has been presented of the narrative character, the character choices on a macro level focused more strongly on not only maintaining, but deliberately *constructing* the personality of the altercharacter rather than the narrative character. In the ethnographic study, players only had just enough time to start forming the initial altercharacter based on the overall interactive nature of the experience – they had time to sign the 'contract' with the player-character, to use the metaphor put forward by Participant 1, but they did not have the chance to fully fulfil their part of this contract. The increased familiarity with game, character, and story, however, allows the player to project their own narrative goals onto the overall experience and use this as one of the pillars on which to base their choice-making rationales.

In all of the case studies, the Research Diary shows a clear progression from initially meeting the player-characters to forming a – rudimentary at first – psychological understanding, or at the very least the player's interpretation of their personality that is in part based on finding points of similarity, identification, and empathy with the character. Following this initial relationship, the altercharacter eventually became a conscious vehicle for the player's ability to shape the character into their ideal version of them. Here, 'ideal' is not necessarily referring to a moral character, but to the type of personality the player hopes to develop as a consequence of their direct interaction with the game. This development takes place over the course of the game, but the player's actual understanding and plan for the character can be formulated relatively early in the process. By the end of the second recording session of *Life is Strange*, for instance, I had formulated my own wishes for Max's character development, making reference to specific changes in character: 'I realised that while I disagree with a lot of Max's past choices, I can make her a better person or character through my own choice-making, so it was aimed at making her more confrontational and standing up to people when possible or appropriate' (Research Diary, Appendix B.2).

In part, the quick development of character goals may be due to the similarities that I perceived between Max and myself, contextualising her within my own experiences, or the prior knowledge I already had from having played the game before. In *Life is Strange 2*, the ideal altercharacter took longer to formulate; this may be due to the unfamiliarity with the game itself, but also due to the perceived differences between player and player-character due to a lack of shared experiences. This distinction was highlighted even more through continuous frustrations about Sean behaving differently from my own wishes. While I was still constructing my version of the altercharacter, I was more insecure in my choice-making, second-guessing my choices even more than

usual and leading me to reflect on the need for having specific character goals to use as a basis for my behaviour: 'I find I am having to constantly re-evaluate what kind of choice I want to make; after two episodes I'm still not entirely sure, apart from having to be strict with Daniel. [...] I really have to figure out what I want to do with these characters' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

Once the altercharacter was formulated, however, I was aware that my own interpretation of the character's personality guided my choice-making on an overarching level, such as when meeting Sean's mother for the first time: 'I understood Sean's anger but I didn't want him to behave that way. I think despite his anger, *my version of Sean* is glad to see her especially after losing his dad' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4, emphasis added). These reflections suggest that formulating and executing one's own version of the altercharacter is an essential part of the gaming experience, forming one of the core reasonings for choice-making, or at least for being comfortable and confident about one's own choice-making.

There is a clear awareness throughout the autoethnography of the distinction between the narrative character and the personality of the altercharacter, an awareness that is carried over to the player's narrative goals as well. Choices that are made with the narrative development in mind often align with the altercharacter's goals, but the *focus* of these choices is different, reflecting an engagement that takes place in the liminal space between altercharacter, narrative character, and the player as choice-maker and as someone who experiences a scripted narrative. The latter focuses strongly on the player as a consumer and highlights the awareness of narrative content as well as a reluctance to miss out on content. This means that players are driven to want to experience the available content regardless of the narrative or emotional value associated with it. This kind of completionist attitude can be found in the overall engagement with the game: at certain points in the autoethnography I acknowledged that I was exploring aspects of the game world 'for the sake of being completionist, but without real interest' (Research Diary, Appendix B.2). These situations typically occurred towards the end of a gaming session, when fatigue and a lack of concentration made it more difficult to muster up a high degree of emotional or narrative involvement unless triggered by a dramatically intense scene.

In terms of narrative engagement on a macro level, the autoethnography of the case studies presented an interesting point of view due to my familiarity with most of the games. With the exception of *Life is Strange 2*, of which I had previously only played the first episode, I had played all of the games before. Here, I was most familiar with *Detroit* due to having seen it played in full earlier that year. This means that for the most part, I was aware of the overarching main plot points of the games and therefore had a general understanding of the way in which the narrative was going to develop, but more specific events were foggy, and for the most part I was not aware of the specific choices that determined the outcome of those events. The emotional implications of

having such prior knowledge is further explored in chapter 9; for the sake of this chapter, it suffices to say that prior knowledge may have affected the attitude to specific choices and characters, but the way in which the individual narratives were shaped by choices was close to what I consider my ‘normal’ choice-making behaviour. I did note however that I was intrigued by the possibility of different endings in *Detroit*, and that after having engaged with it in a way that felt natural to me, I may replay certain scenes at a later time in order to see the different outcomes.

Another factor that drives narrative engagement is embedded within the player’s lived experience of gaming and media as such, which is related to the player’s ‘literary repertoire’ as discussed by Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al. (2008). My experience with narrative-driven games and other narrative media led to my anticipation of possible narrative outcomes based on the game’s communication. These potential outcomes formed part of my behaviour both in making specific choices and estimating their outcome, and in my attitude towards the narrative and characters, for instance when reflecting on Mushroom’s death as discussed in chapter 7.4.

This awareness means that as the game progresses and the storylines are explored more, possible narrative trajectories are considered to first justify and then evaluate choices and their outcomes. Significantly, I occasionally found myself thinking *beyond* the narrative contained within the game itself, imagining the possibility of the characters having a life beyond that of this singular story. I used these reflections as a guide for my own choice-making as well, for instance when making the final choice in *Life is Strange 2*: ‘At that moment, my main priority was Daniel’s well-being and I didn’t think I would be able to guarantee that without surrendering’ (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

The relationship between character-driven and narrative-driven long-term choices is one of focus. As stated above, they may align, and in those instances, the narrative can serve as a justification for more specific character choices, too: ‘Connor’s software instability is up which I’m aiming for I guess – I just think it’ll be a more interesting story if he does have that instability but of course I don’t know what it would be like if it was very low’ (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). Here, the appeal of an ‘interesting’ story is one, but not the only determining factor for setting goals for character development. At times, the tension between them results in the player making a conscious choice to put the well-being of the character above a preferential narrative outcome or vice versa. In *Life is Strange 2*, for example, most of my long-term choices were focused on taking care of Daniel and ensuring that Sean was a good example for him, leading to me putting Sean’s own wants and needs behind Daniel’s at times. The times when I broke from this pattern were justified by making a conscious character choice as well as acknowledging the nature of the overarching narrative:

As soon as Finn started talking about the heist, I knew he was going to rope Daniel into it no matter what, so I decided to spend time with Cassidy during the party and sleep with her. I knew it wasn't the best decision – I didn't want to leave Daniel alone – but I also knew it was the right decision for Sean's character. Daniel would be jealous of her no matter what, I figured. (Research Diary, Appendix B.4)

In this example, two different factors come into play that determine the player's choice-making behaviour. On the one hand, the link with and understanding of the altercharacter's wants and needs provide a basis upon which the player is able to make a decision, acknowledging that the character's needs do not necessarily coincide with the apparent narrative or ludic objectives. On the other hand, the player takes a top-down view of narrative and game and recognises the patterns that have already been demonstrated through gameplay, reflecting on a lack of significant narrative agency. While this choice still has an impact on the relationship between Sean and Daniel, the focus here is on the *overall* development of the narrative, allowing the player to use the lack of high-level narrative agency as a justification for the choice-making approach that they are taking in this specific scene. This lack of agency is a continued point of contention throughout the autoethnography, where at several points I complained about situations escalating or the narrative forcing me into choices and situations that, from a player *and* altercharacter point of view, I would have liked to avoid: 'The game is making me feel sad about my choices, because no matter what I try to do, it always goes wrong...' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

Regardless of the exact type of choice that is favoured at a given moment – character- or narrative-driven –, the player's narrative macro choice-making behaviours are determined by their ability to analyse and recognise narrative patterns as well as the strength of their connection with the altercharacter, suggesting that the altercharacter first needs to be formed through the techniques explored in Part I of this thesis in order to provide the player with a choice direction. The counterpart of this is that an inability to form a connection may lead to inconsistent choice-making, which in turn might lead to an overall lower emotional engagement with the game.

8.3.2 Ludic Choices

First and foremost, engaging with a video game means implicitly agreeing to work within the confines of the game itself. Highlighting the player's identities of *player* and *gamer* as discussed in chapter 5, this means that the player takes up the interactive possibilities provided by the game. While the player-game relationship is not one-sided but acknowledges the interactivity between the two entities, there is a sense of surrendering to the rules of the game's world in what can be considered a ludic

version of suspension of disbelief. It should be noted that this section considers the ludic choices that are made when adhering to the game's framework and does not consider subversive or transgressive play (cf. Aarseth, 2007; T. J. Tanenbaum, 2014). While this mode of play forms an important part of gaming culture and is essential for the player-game relationship particularly regarding the negotiation of control, an investigation of it is outside of the scope of this research.

On a macro level, the investigation of choices that were concerned with the ludic dimension of the game can be broadly addressed in terms of the player's personal objectives, gameplay objectives, and skillful gameplay. As is the case with the narrative choices, a more thorough understanding of gameplay and the player's interactive and embodied agency within the space of the game needs to first be developed before meaningful and intentional choices can be made in this regard. While the understanding specific to the current game is built up, the player tends to default to choice-making behaviours that they have established through prior experience with other similar games.

As observed in both ethnography and autoethnography, the player's personal ludic objectives in particular tend to be driven by the game's communication, appealing to the player's completionist or collector attitude. In *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2*, for instance, Max's photographs and Sean's souvenirs offer the player a guided reason, rather than simply narrative or spatial exploration, for engaging with the game world in a different way. Collecting photographs and souvenirs does not have an impact on the state of gameplay, nor does it have a narrative effect. Instead, the appeal lies in having to look for and find something that is perhaps not easily found. Due to the difference in scale, the items that can be found in *Horizon Zero Dawn* are varied and spread across the entire open world of the game, making it harder to be guided to them, and while there are maps that can be bought during the course of the game to show the locations of the different types of items, they appeared to be overall less intriguing than the ones in the *Life is Strange* games. Additionally, having this added information in *Horizon Zero Dawn* failed to inspire me to go out of my way consistently to find collectibles, instead leading to frustration when I was in an area that was marked with a specific item and was unable to find it:

I'm enjoying the freedom of choice in terms of where to go and what to do, but I get a bit overwhelmed with all the information on the map, now that I bought some extra maps with collectibles on. I tried to find one of the ancient vessels and wasn't able to locate it and gave up because I got annoyed, *but* instead I found some random data points in the wild. I really enjoy those because they give insight into the way the world was prior to whatever happened to get the world in this kind of state. (Research Diary, Appendix B.3)

Lacking the personal and emotional significance for the altercharacter, the collectibles in *Horizon Zero Dawn* did not form a considerable personal objective during the autoethnography unless they specifically intersected with the narrative background. This makes sense given the observation made in chapter 4 that where a shared world context is missing between player and player-character, an understanding of the game world needs to be established first, including the background information that informs the current state of the game world.

From a gameplay point of view, the biggest impact on the player's long-term engagement with the game and actual gameplay behaviour lies in the customisation of the avatar as the vehicle of the player's interaction. In the closed-world games *Life is Strange*, *Life is Strange 2*, and *Detroit: Become Human*, character customisation is not possible; only certain aspects of Kara's appearance can be changed, and only at a narratively significant point in the game. This means that in those games, the player is not able to have an impact on *how* the game is being played. In *Horizon Zero Dawn* on the other hand, customisation includes Aloy's outfits and weapons, all of which can be modified with modification coils found during the course of the game, as well as the distribution of skill points when levelling up.

Lacking a wider understanding of the game itself, Participant 4 was unsure which choices to make initially, but taking a more holistic macro view of the game, my own gameplay was very much geared towards maximising Aloy's potential according to my own gaming style and habits, partially prompted by this particular game but also informed by my prior engagement with similar games. Throughout the autoethnography, for instance, I repeatedly made statements to suggest that I enjoyed an overall stealthy approach to gameplay while at the same time wanting to have as much flexibility and freedom of choice as possible. This means that my long-term goals involved upgrading my carry capacity as well as wanting to level up to the Tinker skill, which, according to the game's written feedback, was a requirement for switching out modifications without destroying them. Rather than being focused on what was immediately relevant for my gameplay, as was the case with Participant 4, I tried to ensure that I optimised Aloy's skills and characteristics to eventually suit my personal style.

Due to the open-world design of the game, one of the main choices that players have to make in *Horizon Zero Dawn* are which quests to follow in which order. The completion of quests is what drives the game's progression forward and, on an overarching level, is essential for the player's understanding of the link between narrative and gameplay:

Quests are a way of structuring the events that constitute the game, as they incarnate causality at two levels. On a semantic level, quests demonstrate how and why a player's actions are connected to each other and to the end of the game's story; and on a structural level, quests embody the cause and effect relationship between a plan of action and its result, or between the

interaction of objects and events. [...] Ideally, quests are the glue where world, rules and themes come together in a meaningful way. (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008, p. 183)

Strictly speaking, the progression of the game depends on the completion of main quests, while side quests are optional, but may intersect somewhat with the main storyline. Therefore, quests fulfill various functions: they are localised ludonarrative instances of play that both help familiarise the player with the game on a smaller scale and drive overall game progression by honing the player's skills, offering specific rewards that in turn can be used for other ludic purposes.

In the autoethnography, the choice of which quests to follow and when was determined by several factors. One of these is the deliberate execution of personal gameplay goals; working towards obtaining the Tinker skill for the purpose of having more opportunities to customise the avatar, I occasionally chose quests purely to gain experience points. Other ludic choices included choosing quests because they were in the vicinity without any real interest in the actual quest, similar to Participant 4's reasoning for choosing quests, and picking more specific quests due to the expected outcome, for instance when I chose to go to the Cauldron because it would allow me to override certain machines. This in turn would help with my stealthy gameplay approach.

As a rule, I attempted to complete as many side quests as possible before moving on with the main quest, in part due to gaining appropriate experience and in part because I did not want to miss out on content, as addressed in the previous section. The *order* of quests however was dependent on my specific needs during the game as well as the need to balance combat, story, and low- and high-effort engagements. The latter in particular was due to the high effort, both cognitively and kinaesthetically, of specific types of quests, necessitating a deliberate balancing of the different types of encounters the game offered. Again, it was only possible to form these kinds of evaluations and expectations of quests after becoming more familiar with the game on a larger scale.

Overall, the ludic choices that were observed on a macro level were often dependent on long-term planning rather than the more reactive approach that tends to be accompany ludic choices on a micro level. This long-term perspective is similar to the plans that are established on a narrative level, with the difference being that they generally did not appear to contradict each other. Instead, the different ludic goals and the resulting choices were either complimentary or did not have a considerable effect on each other. Conceptually, throughout the autoethnography there was a clear distinction between making 'correct' choices and making 'right' choices, where the former refers to the correct and expected execution of gameplay and the latter appeared to embody a moral component. At times, these distinctions complicated choice-making as there was not one, but two 'preferred' ways of solving situations, causing some of the conflict that has already been observed in chapter 5.

8.4 Choice-Making Frameworks

As addressed in the previous sections, both micro and macro choices are principally informed by the player's wider behaviour in the overall context of gaming culture. This means that particularly while they are familiarising themselves with the game's specific needs, requirements, and overall behaviours, they default to choice-making patterns that have been established through continued interaction with similar games where possible. Of the study participants, only Participant 2 had very little experience with video games, and none with narrative video games, whereas the other participants identified as frequent gamers, although the exact frequency varied between participants. Participant 1 for instance had experience with similar games to *Life is Strange* 2 and was able to form expectations based on this prior experience. Participant 3 generally had a broad taste in games, claiming that they liked to play any game except for role-playing games that, for them, required a lot of micromanaging of stats, inventory etc., although most of the games they referred to when discussing their particular choice-making behaviour were RPGs.

Both Participant 4 and Participant 5 enjoyed role-playing games as their preferred game genre. Participant 4 took pleasure in the openness of RPGs and in getting a sense of reward and achievement for their progression and improvement, while Participant 5 enjoyed games with in-depth storylines that offer the player a decent degree of control over the story. Previous negative experiences with similar games set an expectation or worry of low agency for Participant 5, but they found that *Detroit: Become Human* was more interactive and gave them a higher sense of agency than they expected.

All of the participants had a clear understanding of their own choice-making behaviours in general and were able to draw comparisons between the types of choices and agency that they experienced in this game and the types experienced in other games. Participant 1 explained that they always start making choices in line with the character before making them based on the altercharacter that has been constructed through play. This means that they initially follow their interpretation of who the character is before the choices become 'what the game expects' of them, until ultimately the choices become closer to their own: 'So that's why towards the ending I was more like "Yeah, that would be me. That would be right." But because I made the character to be that kind of a person, not because they were actually that person or whatever' (Participant 1, Interview). Similarly, when playing longer games, Participant 5 generally tries to stick to a steady character, making choices that are in service of the storyline and character traits. As a rule, however, they 'tend to stay on the side of the traditional fairytale style good overcoming evil type' (Participant 5, Interview). When, occasionally, they go in the opposite direction of what would be considered 'good' in terms of character and story development, they do so in games that deal with this creatively, focusing on not letting the storyline digress too much.

Participant 3 and Participant 4 are more outcome-oriented in their established choice-making practice, with Participant 3 relying on their own sense of morality and Participant 4 occasionally relying on external sources, where they look up background information, how to do certain quests, and the different outcomes of a choice if they are unsure which one to choose. Both participants tend to make choices that represent a moral or rational response to a situation, although Participant 3 also pointed out that there is the need to balance one's own morality and the fulfilment of ludic goals:

I think it's half moral choices based on your own preferences and half what's gonna benefit you in the game. [...] I don't necessarily wanna like kill a load of people to get certain perks or whatever, because that to me just morally isn't very nice. I know it's a game and there's no like consequence to it, but I think you kind of do want to reflect your own personality in the choices and with moral choices in the game. (Participant 3, Interview).

Comparing their choice-making behaviour in the ethnographic study to their behaviour in other games, the more story-based games seemed to overall feel more restrictive for the participants. Participant 1 noted that they experienced less agency than they usually do, however they assumed that the reason for this was that they played the prologue of the game, where a considerable amount of agency would have interfered with the game's exposition. Participant 3 found that the choices in *Life is Strange 2* were less nuanced, with a clearer positive or negative outcome associated with the options, and Participant 5 felt that the more narrative- or dialogue-driven nature of the choices created stronger restrictions on the player than ludic choices, which allow the player to determine their own path to a set goal. They did highlight that when playing games, the creation of an involved gaming experience relies on addressing the player's need to feel as if they are an integral part of the game itself:

I enjoy things that [make] you feel like you're part of a story and you're involved in the narrative, so whether that means that it lets you run around between cities and then gets you in cut-scenes and things. [...] I enjoy those a lot more than the ones that tend to sort of ignore you as a player. (Participant 5, Interview)

In all of the observed cases, participants based their expectations of the game's response to player input and the general arc of the game on prior experience of other video games until their specific expectations of the game were adjusted with increasing familiarity. In some cases, these expectations were related to the overall genre, and for instance in the case of Participant 5 created more negative expectations in the beginning, which led to an initial experience of perhaps lower agency than they might have felt otherwise: 'Maybe if I'd played it longer or if I'd played more similar games I might

know what I was expecting it to do and then I guess have a better idea of what effect my actions had. I guess maybe I was testing it a little bit' (Participant 5, Interview). In other cases, the expectations were created by prior experience with the specific series. Participant 3 for instance was expecting being able to rewind time and undo choices based on having played *Life is Strange* before, contributing to their experience of the neighbour incident as particularly jarring. In my autoethnography, these expectations went beyond gameplay mechanics and choice-making, and also extended to narrative development and the player's emotional involvement: 'Knowing how emotional *Life is Strange* was, I have no doubt that *Life is Strange 2* is going to be a rough one as well' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4).

The observations made in this chapter highlight that not only the act of playing a video game, but also the player's *approach* to playing – their rationales, behaviours, and attitudes – are not isolated and confined to the specific game that is being played. The player's choice-making behaviours are informed by experiences made through sustained engagement with the medium as well as the player's disposition towards agency that forms the main basis, rationale, or instinct for choice-making. In the instances that were observed in the ethnographic study, the two main choice-making trends were character-based on the one hand and outcome-oriented on the other hand. In the first case, this means making choices in line with the character, be that game-constructed, player-constructed, or a progression from narrative character to altercharacter as observed by Participant 1. In the second case, choices are made based on their predicted moral or ludic value.

This extends choice-making from an observed behaviour that is confined to a singular gaming experience to a *practice* that is embedded within a wider culture, expanding the notion of macro-involvement (Calleja, 2011) as discussed in section 8.1. The conceptualisation of choice-making as a wider phenomenon that spans the player's entire experience with games and therefore draws on the literacy that they have established through continued engagement allows us to better understand not only how players act and how they establish preferences, but also how they engage with the different levels of gaming in general.

However, it is important to note that focusing on one approach to playing does not mean that choices are never made based on other grounds, too. It merely highlights the dynamics that are brought about by the different modalities of the gaming experience and the player-game relationship, as well as the player's self-imposed priorities. The balancing of the player's own priorities with the game's needs is one of the factors that can cause an emotional reaction in the player, but it is by no means the only one. Being able to feel an emotional connection not only with the characters that are populating the game world, but also with the act of gaming itself highlights the potential intensity of the experience and opens up different ways of thinking about the player's engagement with contemporary video games, where emotional involvement finds a

basis in the intersection between interactivity, narrative engagement, and player behaviour. In order to enhance our understanding of how the player's choice-making practice is established, then, it is important to consider the interplay between player behaviour and emotions as well as the emotional impact of choice-making, which will be addressed in the next chapter.

Chapter 9

The Emotional Impact of Choice-Making

9.1 Introduction

Up until the confrontation with the neighbour, the atmosphere of *Life is Strange 2*, as described in the vignette at the beginning of this part of the thesis, has been comfortable and wholesome, establishing a solid foundation of family and friendship for the Diaz brothers. The emotionally meaningful connection between the characters, and by extension between player and characters, makes the narrative act of taking this connection away even more impactful as reflected in both Participant 1's horrified reaction and my own. Here, it is notable that previous knowledge of the event does not lessen the emotional consequences. In my autoethnography, fully aware of the course of events in the episode and the lack of agency in this particular scene, I still acknowledge experiencing shock and guilt, describing the overall effect of the situation as 'heartbreaking.' A similar reaction can be observed in the autoethnography of *Life is Strange*, in which I am continually aware of the emotional choice at the end of the game, but still start crying in the moment of making it.

Generally speaking, the player's ability to directly influence events or actions in the game lends itself to establishing *emotional* connections. These are not necessarily related to the narrative itself. Bizzocchi (2007) claims that emotions tend to be related to gameplay rather than character, i.e. focusing on the player's emotional responses to the ludic aspects of the game in relation to their skill level, and Ryan (2009) claims that emotional immersion is the most difficult type of immersion to achieve in an interactive environment as it depends on the actual relationship that is established between the player and the player-character. Many of the emotions that are evoked throughout the gaming experience are indeed related to the game's flow and therefore to the more

mechanical engagement with the game, but they can also be of social or parasocial nature relating to other players in the case of multiplayer games, or characters within the narrative itself (Isbister, 2016).

How can a binary choice at the relative beginning of the game produce the kind of strong emotional reaction that both Participant 1 and myself displayed, particularly if there is a temporal aspect to establishing a sense of emotional agency (cf. Isbister, 2016; Kway and Mitchell, 2018)? The player's emotional engagement with a video game is a difficult one to assess from an outside perspective precisely because the experience of emotions is a deeply personal matter that strongly depends on the player's subjective experience. As Leino (2010, p. 5) points out, most existing research approaches emotions and video games from the perspective of psychology, which does not fully capture the dynamics of emotional involvement in play:

While we may accept that the psychological method can tell us for example which emotions the players experience and when, we cannot see it accounting for *why* a particular emotion was experienced. [...] For the attempt of fully comprehending the player's emotions, the scientific attitude needs to be complemented with an *understanding* of the emotions.

Understanding the processes at work in the player's emotional involvement during the gaming experience deepens our insights into the way in which the player's personal and individual experience intersects with the video game as an agent in an interactive relationship. The player's emotional reaction to their own choice-making continually emerged over the course of this thesis. This chapter, then, complements existing research by taking an in-depth look at the *emotional impact* of choice-making, particularly analysing the ways in which a game can trigger different emotional reactions based on the player's status as an agency-bearing participant in the gaming experience. The emotional reactions that were observed in the course of the ethnographic and autoethnographic studies reflect the different modalities of the game-player relationship and can be broadly categorised into ludic, narrative, parasocial, and agentic emotions. Here, the first two are based on the ludic or narrative experience that is strongly guided by the properties of the game itself, while the latter two are related to the player's choice-making processes, both in terms of constructing the altercharacter and in terms of being a responsible decision-maker.

9.2 Ludonarrative Emotions

The interactive nature of the medium means that playing a video game is to a large degree based on the player's development of their own skills and abilities, making the

player responsible for their successes and accountable for their failures. This direct link with the player's skill, be that of a cognitive or kinaesthetic nature depending on the requirements of the game at any given moment, has direct emotional and physiological consequences. In this context, the difference between the experience and the interpretation of emotions needs to be highlighted. While emotions such as stress, frustration, or guilt would commonly be considered negative and they are not necessarily pleasant emotions to experience, they can still affect the player's experience in a positive way and, in some cases, make up one of the pleasures of playing a particular game. Therefore, negative emotions do not automatically equate a negative experience. However, not every emotional response leads to a positive experience, and not every kind of emotional involvement is desirable or even conducive to the gaming process.

In both ethnography and autoethnography, negative ludic emotions revolved primarily around the player's own skill and the design of the game. Annoyance and frustration with the game itself, for instance, was observed when the game design restricted player freedom, such as being annoyed at the carry capacity in *Horizon Zero Dawn* in the autoethnography. The opposite – *too much* freedom – could also have a negative emotional effect in the form of being overwhelmed or intimidated by the open world, the abundance of choice, and the large amount of map information. Unclear or jarring game communication was another observed cause of frustration. This was evident for instance during the ethnography, when the drawing mechanics in *Life is Strange 2* were not communicated in a way that was obvious to the player, causing Participant 1 to give up on this particular in-game activity. It also showed in my own irritation at *Life is Strange 2*'s repetition of tutorials across episodes, which I interpreted as 'patronising.' This kind of emotional reaction leads to an interruption of the symbiotic game-player relationship. Instead of player and game working together, the game's nature as a technical pre-programmed entity is highlighted, which in turn shifts the balance of the relationship to one of inequality. In those instances, the game is seen as something that gets *in the way* of the gaming experience and can lessen the player's overall involvement with it.

A perceived negative emotion that can actually enhance the player's involvement with the video game is stress.¹ In the observed instances, stress was often caused by the technical requirements of a specific scene, such as timed quests for Participant 4, rapid quick-time events for both Participant 5 and myself, or a general sense of stress caused by a mismatch of the player's skill level and the game's requirements. The latter occurred for instance in more time-sensitive situations for Participant 2 and due to navigational and visual issues in the autoethnography. Here, the intensity of the stress and

¹The experience of stress is not necessarily a hindrance to playing, and indeed, in some genres, such as first-person shooters or platform games, the stress that is derived from the fast pacing of the game and its kinaesthetic requirements may form one of the primary pleasures of the experience. In this thesis, the emotions described are related primarily to the experience of narrative-focused adventure games, with the exception of *Horizon Zero Dawn* which due to its design is expected to have a more kinaesthetic component.

my repeated failures of the scene eventually prompted me to look up the solution to the first part of the nightmare maze in *Life is Strange*. In these cases, stress can be considered to be directly related to a fear of failure on the player's part, and is therefore a reflection of the interactive nature of the medium itself. This fear of failure does not necessarily have to be related to the player's ego, either, and instead can be related to the ludic inconvenience of failure: 'Running away from all those machines felt quite stressful and I was a bit scared that they might kill me, primarily because I didn't want to re-load' (Research Diary, Appendix B.3).

A sense of stress can also be caused by physiological factors due to the quasi-physical nature of gameplay. At several points in the autoethnography, I commented on feeling a physical exhaustion after a particularly challenging scene, primarily when playing *Horizon Zero Dawn*, and I deliberately changed my ludic behaviour to minimise this type of physical or mental stress, for instance by changing to a stealthy approach. While this might in part mimic the player-character's experiences, thereby sharing a physical framework and increasing the players perceived stakes and feelings of relevance, a delicate balance needs to be maintained; as observed in the autoethnography, physical and mental exhaustion can also lead to the player's impatience, reducing interest in the game overall.

The experience of stress can be enhanced by the game's communication as well as reflected, for instance, in the pacing of a scene, fast-paced music, or time pressure imposed on specific activities. Understanding and acknowledging the relationship between the game's communication and the ludic consequences means that the player is able to respond to changes thereof, such as when I started responding to musical cues in *Horizon Zero Dawn* that alerted me to the presence of an enemy before I had spotted them. This allowed me to hide to observe the situation and formulate a plan for how to respond to this particular ludic challenge. Here, the recognition of the game on a meta level and the awareness of the way in which information is communicated extradiegetically to the player can therefore be used to assist gameplay, rather than merely being seen as a matter of creating atmosphere.

Given the hold that the player has on the game world via the prosthetic relationship with the avatar, previously addressed in chapter 3, the development of the player's ludic skills can lead to a sense of pleasure or enjoyment when mastering a specific challenge. This challenge can be determined by the game objectives, but can also be imposed by the player themselves, where the way in which a challenge is handled can be satisfying: 'Markus's warehouse scene was fairly standard, but I did enjoy having to figure out how to get past the guards to get the key, and I was pleased that I managed this without any casualties or confrontation' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). Here, the enjoyment was felt both in the difficulty of the challenge itself and the player's execution thereof, but was also observed when encountering the prospect of a ludic challenge. This is the case particularly in the narrative-heavy games *Life is Strange* and

Life is Strange 2, where I audibly appreciated the change from dialogue-heavy encounters to more gameplay-oriented situations, suggesting that the development of one's ludic skills is one of the explicit enjoyments of playing a game.

The familiarity with the game that is created by the player's increasing skill in conjunction with their overall ludic literacy can feel not only enjoyable, but comforting in its own right: 'It's like putting on a well-worn glove. The familiarity of gaming is somewhat soothing' (Research Diary, Appendix B.3). Moreover, a sense of achievement emerges from the player's increasing ability to take advantage of and utilise the game mechanics deliberately and tactically, which in this study has been observed most frequently in the more gameplay-oriented *Horizon Zero Dawn*, and can be triggered by the game's written feedback as well: 'It was really satisfying whenever the game told me that I had removed a component' (Research Diary, Appendix B.3). The player's active involvement in being able to do something correctly or well in these challenges also opens up the player for feelings of pride. In more gameplay-oriented situations, this is mostly pride in the player themselves for being able to handle them, but can also be related to the player's level of engagement with the narrative and characters: 'I felt quite proud of myself when I managed to make him [Hank] see that I was the correct Connor through bits of the "personal information" that I got out of him throughout the game' (Research Diary, Appendix B.5). Here, the positive emotions were related to the player's previous prioritisation of the relationship between player-character and non-player character, which ended up having both a ludic and a narrative effect.

While the above emotional engagement is based on the player's skill and ability to navigate the rule set of the game, the game's narrative content itself is another means by which the player becomes emotionally involved with the game. One of the functions of narrative in video games is to make sense of the rule system by integrating more abstract rules within a framework that carries meaning beyond functionality (Egenfeldt-Nielsen et al., 2008). Narrative can therefore function as a way to anchor the player's interest in the game by giving them something concrete to follow and care about – be that the characters of the story world, the actors within the game's narrative as tied to the player's interaction with them, or the storylines themselves. As such, an engaging narrative in a video game appeals to the basic human desire to tell and experience events *as* stories (cf. Copley, 2001), enriching the process of gaming itself.

The observed emotional reactions related to the narrative in particular can be divided into two main types. In the first instance, emotions like relief, shock, and satisfaction were often related to the *development* of the narrative rather than the specific subject matter that was being portrayed. Here, the player views the narrative as a formal sequence of events that is not only being told, but that they are an active actor in as well. In this vein, the player's meta knowledge and their narrative or generic literacy result in a whole different emotional engagement, one that is concerned with how the narrative *works* as opposed to how it is *told*. During the autoethnography, for instance,

I was concerned for Mushroom's fate 'because I know how stories work' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). This refers to the necessity for dramatic plot developments to not only drive the narrative forward, but also to cause player and character development, and the overall awareness of the emotional consequences that this is expected to have on the player. In this case, the knowledge of how stories work creates the player's expectation for stronger emotional reactions. This, in turn, might cause the player to care more about the plot and characters, contributing to the player's overall emotional engagement.

The second type of emotional engagement with the narrative is related to the specific subject matter that is portrayed. While partially related to the player's relationship with the characters as actors within the story, some of the observed emotional responses were independent of the player-character and were instead based on the atmosphere, such as feeling peaceful and relaxed in the commune *Away in Life is Strange 2*, satisfaction and happiness based on the fulfilment of the player's own narrative goals, or discomfort based on specific subject matters such as racism or religious zeal.

The most memorable and strongest instances of emotional involvement in relation to narrative were related to negative emotions, going as far as being reflected physically by crying in the real world. Crying as a result of the player's own actions as well as the development of the narrative was the case in the final decision for both *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2* during the autoethnography. Both of these instances are very different, highlighting that the emotional reaction can be partially independent of the player's cognitive evaluation of the narrative and their part in it. In *Life is Strange*, there is a strong sense of guilt associated with the final choice – saving Chloe or saving Arcadia Bay –, and interestingly it did not fail to produce an emotional reaction despite the fact that I as a player was fully aware of this ending due to my previous playthrough of the game. While it would be a valid assumption that such previous knowledge would lessen the emotional reaction as it would no longer be a surprise, it turned out that it strengthened it instead by colouring the interaction with the game where 'I suspected I would want to save Chloe at the end and already had a sense of pre-guilt about knowing that it would be the wrong decision, logically and morally speaking' (Research Diary, Appendix B.2). In fact, the guilt resulting from the end choice in *Life is Strange* was so strong that I felt compelled to justify it days after the event, which was not the case for any of the other games. I also cried when making the final choice in *Life is Strange 2* despite the fact that I was convinced that it was the right choice for both characters *and* narrative; as explained in chapter 8, what can be considered right for the development of the story does not necessarily have to coincide with what the player feels is right for the development of their altercharacter. In this case, a strong emotional reaction occurred despite fulfilling the player's narrative and character needs.

The player's constant switching between ludic and narrative modes of engagement, which impacts their approach to a scene or situation, complicates their ability to have a consistent and coherent emotional experience. In *Life is Strange 2*, for instance, I observed that 'there is quite a big difference between what I felt on behalf of the character – stress, anxiety, urgency – and what I understood in terms of gameplay – that I had all the time in the world to look at everything because the story wouldn't progress until a specific point' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). While in some cases, ludic and narrative emotions can be used to enhance each other, moments such as this one, where narrative and ludic emotions collide, create a disparity, temporarily interrupting the player's ability to fully involve themselves emotionally.

Overall, most of the emotions that were observed as emerging from the ludic aspects of the game were related to the player's ability to handle the space of the game and the challenges that are posed within. Negative ludic emotions were in some cases useful for conditioning the player to do things in a certain way, but when pushed too far, they could hinder the player's involvement with the game itself. Most of the positive ludic emotions were challenge-based, focusing on the player's skill level and the observable progress that was made throughout the game. In contrast to this, while there were some positive emotions associated with the development of the narrative, the strongest and most emotionally involving situations were negative, suggesting that there is, perhaps, some desire on the player's part to let themselves feel those negative emotions that they know are going to be fuelled by the drama and conflict inherent in any story.

As Leino (2010, p. 7) points out, less intense emotions are not necessarily less relevant in the bigger picture of emotional involvement and 'the seemingly extremely emotional moments, such as crying in front of a computer game, should not be elevated to any special position,' but in the overall experience of the game, they are the moments that tend to stand out to the player more and provide them with a reason to continue the gaming experience in a meaningful way. In the end, ludic emotions are frequently related to the idea of 'correct' and 'wrong' gameplay, and are therefore directly linked to success and failure in comparison to what the 'implied' player should be doing.

9.3 Character and Emotion

The distinction between abstract and defined characters discussed in chapter 4.2 reveals two primary modes of engagement with the player-character. Where characters 'leave more room for the player,' as Pearce (2004) puts it, the player is able to project their own personality and objectives onto the 'shell' of the character. This is not identification in the literary sense, but a direct transportation of the player into the game world. Where the character is more clearly defined, the player takes meaning from an empathetic relationship with the character by being made to care about the character as

a *person* rather than a narrative character. However, as shown previously (see chapter 5) in discussing the different layers of identity and emotional engagement (Gee, 2003; Isbister, 2016), the cognitive and emotional bond between player and player-character is more complex than the question of whether the player projects themselves onto the character or whether they see them as a separate entity. This is the case particularly when taking into consideration the impact of ludic or narrative engagement and the constant switching between these two modes. A model of player-character relationship therefore needs to incorporate the player's specific understanding of their role within the world of the game *and* the world of the narrative, which is addressed in this thesis through the conceptualisation of the altercharacter as a product of player interpretation, choice-making, and the constant re-negotiation of ludic and narrative control.

As discussed throughout this thesis, the relationship between player and character (both player- and non-player character) plays an important part in the gaming experience. On the one hand, the characters are the driving force of the narrative around which conflict centres. On the other hand, non-player characters can be used to react to player choice, thereby highlighting the player's role within the space of the game and feeding back their decisions and agency. Far more than a means to simply convey narrative or interactivity, characters in video games are able to drive and highlight the player's feeling of emotional agency (Kway and Mitchell, 2018) that is determined by the player's caring for and empathising with the characters. In order to become emotionally involved with the characters in a video game, the player needs to establish a relationship with them that acknowledges their interior lives as people. Part I of this thesis highlighted the process of merging and separating player and player-character through acknowledging the personhood of the character itself, i.e. allowing oneself to be immersed in the narrative, suspending one's disbelief, and rejecting the knowledge of the character as a narrative and ludic construct.

Opening oneself to the imagined reality of the characters and making oneself vulnerable to them in the process leads to a kind of emotional engagement that tends to be parasocial in nature. In part, this is related to the player's suspension of disbelief, due to which 'we [...allow] the characters to cross boundaries we normally reserve only for intimates' (Brown, 2012, p. 87). Previous research into relationships with video game characters highlights that the relationship with the avatar is often based on identification or projection rather than parasociality due to the interreactive nature of the player-character dynamic (Hart, 2017). Research on *non*-player characters suggests a parasocial element in the relationship, where '[p]layers [express] intense emotional attachments and [view] the NPCs as characters possessing distinct personalities' (Burgess and Jones, 2020, par. 27). Although the latter study specifically discusses the option to romance non-player characters, where the player, via the altercharacter, has a romantic investment in the relationship, the overall dynamics can be applied to non-romantic

player-character interactions, too. The fact that players are able to interact with the characters through the player-character makes the relationship not entirely parasocial, given that the concept is based on a distinctly one-sided relationship, but the player's ability to acknowledge characters as distinct persons is a crucial point of this relationship. For this reason, I continue to refer to this kind of emotional engagement as parasocial.

In the ethnographic and autoethnographic studies, the emotional consequences that emerge from having a parasocial attitude towards the characters give rise to a wide range of emotional possibilities. On the one hand, the player is able to establish a decidedly negative relationship with non-player characters, particularly where the game presents them as antagonistic in the first place. In most cases, this ranged from mild annoyance to hostility, for instance in the immediate hostility that I displayed towards Finn in *Life is Strange 2* due to my own narrative predictions: 'I instantly felt hostile towards Finn though because it was obvious what kind of influence he was having on Daniel, who was getting more hostile and angry towards me' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4). In some cases, the player's hostile attitude towards characters even went so far as to have a manifestation in the real world, such as disgust, physical hatred, or fear for the character's personal safety which the player experienced vicariously: 'Mr Jefferson disgusted me so much and I felt physically unclean just watching him in those scenes, while also feeling helpless because I wasn't able to control Max as much as I normally could' (Research Diary, Appendix B.2).

While this shows that the player's emotional engagement with characters can be severe if they allow it to be, their emotional state is not necessarily the determining factor for their actual choice-making, highlighting once again that players operate on different levels throughout gameplay. This can be seen for instance in choosing a compassionate response in *Horizon Zero Dawn* despite being severely angry with the non-player character. In other cases, the player's own persona deepens the negative relationship with the non-player character. A positive and empathetic relationship with non-player characters was much more likely to impact the player's behaviour due to wanting to make choices that would strengthen or maintain that relationship. Again, the player's positive emotional engagement occasionally transferred to the real world as well, such as Participant 4 feeling physical attraction towards a non-player character.

Interestingly, the player's ludic emotions are sometimes reflected onto the characters as well. In the case of Participant 4, they were aware of the fact that they were transferring their annoyance with the game design onto a non-player character who was merely the conveyor of these game design issues when they didn't react to the player's actions sufficiently. Due to the character embodying the game's rules in a way, they became a focal point for the player's emotions. While this had an impact on how the player felt about this particular non-player character, it did not affect their ludic decisions such as wanting to complete the follow-up quest for the character.

Emotions that emerged from the player's decisions seemed to be generally more effective in determining their behaviour. While often sticking with their choices in *Life is Strange*, Participant 2 experienced a strong sense of guilt and felt shamed when Kate confronted Max after the latter took a picture of her confrontation with the security guard as opposed to interfering. As discussed in chapter 7, they reported this to be the sole reason for rewinding and choosing the other option despite having made the original choice for a specific reason. In a similar vein, as explored in chapter 5, Hank's negative reaction to my choice in 'The Nest' caused me to feel a strong sense of guilt despite deliberately choosing to follow my ludic goals in that situation. Feeling guilt due to the character's reaction highlights that the player does acknowledge their personhood to a certain extent already early on in the game, and that they feel a sense of empathy towards them that often wins over the player receiving a ludic advantage:

I deliberately didn't shoot the android at the sex club because the loving gesture towards her android girlfriend made me feel for them – of course I'm aware that from a gameplay perspective I would have needed them for information. (Research Diary, Appendix B.5).

Overall, the emotions that were observed in relation to the player-character were tied to the player's closeness with the altercharacter at a given time. Since the gaming experience is not a fluid, coherent experience and is necessarily fragmented (Newman, 2004), the player's relationship with the altercharacter changes as the game progresses. In those moments where the distinction between player and player-character was highlighted due to a discrepancy in their goals, behaviour, and overall approaches, the player was more prone to experiencing emotions like frustration. This both highlights and strengthens the character's separate personality in a move from identification and control towards a more parasocial relationship. Where the altercharacter's behaviour was more in line with the player's own goals, feelings like satisfaction and pride were more frequent, for instance when considering the advancement of my narrative and character goals in *Detroit*:

My heart really went out to Connor and I was really proud of him – though it's strange to feel proud of a character that you also control. It's not pride in myself, but in the player-character, while at the same time thinking about the fact that *I* was becoming a deviant. (Research Diary, Appendix B.5)

In addition to Participant 1's musings about establishing a contract that eventually leads to the construction of the altercharacter, this suggests a complex interplay between different modes of incorporation, in which the player frequently moves between alterbiography of entity and alterbiography of self as set out by Calleja (2011) while at the same time maintaining the altercharacter as a separate entity from the player. These

muddled modalities allow for a complex emotional engagement that is dependent on the player's role within the space of the game.

9.4 Agency and Emotion

According to Isbister (2016), interactivity in video games creates the possibility for strong emotional consequences. The previous sections show that an emotional connection is created with the player-character in its different iterations as a narrative or psychological character as well as the avatar that is a vehicle for the player's interactivity, and with the game system on a ludic level. In the first instance, the player-character is incorporated – in the words of Calleja (2011) – into the player, who 'moves through the game world taking actions as this person, adopting his or her concerns and struggling towards his or her goals' (Isbister, 2016, p. 11). In the second instance, the player is continually assessing potential choices and their consequences, which allows for the player to be emotionally attached to their choices and, by extension, to their narrative impact on the world itself. Here, the player is incorporated into the world of the game on a narrative and ludic level.

The ability and necessity to make choices gives the player a sense of responsibility for events and consequences within the game, although not necessarily for the narrative as a whole. Fundamentally, the player takes responsibility for *action*, while the game takes responsibility for the *story* (Carlquist, 2002; Muriel and Crawford, 2018). Isbister (2016, pp. xvii-xviii) notes that emotional engagement in general is dependent on a prolonged interaction with the game itself:

games can actually play a powerful role in creating empathy and other strong, positive emotional experiences. [...G]ames reveal these emotionally positive qualities over time, through the act of playing. An observer can't see these qualities by occasionally watching other people play. Yet most people do not have the time to immerse themselves in play and develop enough mastery to fully experience the emotionally transformative aspects of games.

Here, Isbister highlights the temporal aspect of establishing an emotional connection with the game and its characters. However, it should be noted that based on the analysis in the previous sections, the player's emotional engagement has many different dimensions that are not all dependent on prolonged gameplay. Similarly, mastery of the game itself is not a prerequisite for the experience of strong emotions, either, considering the emotional involvement displayed by Participant 2 who possessed little ludic literacy and struggled with the controls of the game. Even in the case of the study

conducted by Kway and Mitchell (2018, p. 235), who find that ‘time and a commitment to making sense of the characters and the narrative is essential before players feel a sense of attachment to the characters,’ the average play time of the participants was only 25 minutes, which was enough for the player to establish an emotional connection with their choices and the characters. However, as explored throughout these chapters, the player’s increasing understanding of the game system, the narrative, and the characters allows them to contextualise their own choices. Both ludic and narrative aspects of character are established throughout the course of the game in response to the player’s interactive capacities. The relationship between the player’s choices and their outcomes takes time to develop in particular on a macro choice level, leading to the recognition of a clear cause-and-effect chain centring on the player as an actor and as someone who, in the words of Giddings and Kennedy (2008, p. 30), is being ‘acted upon.’

The player’s direct involvement in the game events via the avatar, then, establishes a clear chain of responsibility: the player acts purposefully in the real world, and the avatar acts out these commands within the space of the game. While occasionally, the player-character may behave in ways that the player did not anticipate or intend, leading to a lower sense of agency for the player or even negative emotions towards the player-character as an entity as explored in the previous section, ultimately it is the player who makes choices, regardless of whether these choices are prompted by the game or the player. Throughout the autoethnography, this sense of responsibility could be observed to grow the more the player’s agency was communicated and the consequences of their actions were highlighted.

Overall, the emotions that were observed in relation to the player’s agency tended to be on the negative side more than the positive in both the ethnographic and autoethnographic study. Feelings of success and satisfaction were relevant for the player’s self-evaluation, but they mostly occurred in relation to technical rather than dramatic agency, as explored in section 9.2. Dramatic satisfaction was observed when the player achieved specific goals, for instance when working towards a specific character goal such as Connor’s deviancy in *Detroit: Become Human*. The degree of satisfaction seemed to be closely related to the extent of agency, particularly when juxtaposed with the possibility of failure on the player’s part. When deciphering the different clues from Nathan’s room in *Life is Strange*, I describe experiencing satisfaction when finding the correct answer, but felt that the scene ‘would have been a lot more interesting if I had actually been able to fail that situation and not receive as much detail or as good information’ (Research Diary, Appendix B.2). Therefore, a sense of satisfaction that is not purely based on empathy through narrative and character development is tied to the player’s own experience of agency in the game.

More frequent agentic emotions came from either the experience of negative consequences, or from the *possibility* of negative consequences. As such, guilt and regret

were frequently experienced both in the ethnographic and the autoethnographic study. Due to the length of the ethnographic study, this means that this is only partially dependent on an established feeling of agency and is, instead, an emotional consequence resulting from a direct response to player action. However, the *extent* of the player's emotional involvement and the overall emotional impact of a situation appear to depend to a large degree on the characteristics of the choice that preceded the particular outcome.

In the case of *Life is Strange 2* and the confrontation with the neighbour, this outcome is the father's death. The participants' different approaches to the situation and the resulting emotional consequences provide interesting insights into the way agency is interpreted by the player. While the scene was uncomfortable for both participants, Participant 1 was evidently more affected by it as they displayed a strong sense of shock and guilt at the escalation of the conflict, while Participant 3, choosing the less confrontational option of the two – to question Daniel – appeared less emotionally connected to their own role as active decision-maker within the scene. Participant 1 made a choice that can be considered active in the sense that it directs Sean to confront Brett which, based on their previous verbal interaction, can be predicted to be potentially violent either physically or verbally. This establishes a direct cause-and-effect relationship between the player's choice and the way in which the narrative unfolds, although the specific outcome could not have been anticipated by the player. On an emotional level, this causal link in turn establishes a clear chain of responsibility, in which the player, who to a degree is in control of Sean in this scene, considers themselves to be the main agent responsible for the fatal consequences. This sense of responsibility was missing for Participant 3, leading them to question the lack of agency in the scene: 'I don't think in that scenario, anything different would have happened. Just judging by the fact that I tried to pick the one that would not lead to confrontation and it led to him punching him anyway' (Participant 3, Interview). The potential for triggering a sense of responsibility as observed in the case of Participant 1 is particularly interesting given that the choice itself does not have an impact on the overall progression of the game as discussed in chapter 7.2.

The dramatic progression and the way in which it changes the dynamics of the game however do impact how agency is perceived in general. Participant 3, for instance, felt that their choices had a meaningful effect only up until the point of the confrontation, which for them retroactively voided any meaning that previous minor choices might have carried. The only choice that, in their opinion, would have made a difference was Sean's reaction to Daniel when he wanted to show him his Halloween costume. Interestingly, as shown in the vignette of *Life is Strange 2*, this was not a choice that was presented in the game as it took place during a non-interactive cut-scene. Participant 3's skewed memory here might be a result of narrative immersion or of the game design in general, as cut-scene and gameplay look similar and dialogue choices frequently take

place in the cut-scenes as well. Participant 1 was more cautious about condemning agency in the overall game, but acknowledged that the choices that they made prior to the confrontation did not carry a strong sense of agency due to the inability to see and understand how the game would take these choices forward:

The other parts you do feel like your choices mean something, perhaps they have more long-term effect, like I don't think I played the game for long enough to feel that every choice feels like they will have a repercussion or not. Because right now the reason I only remember that one [the confrontation with the neighbour] is because it's a very, like, you did something and there's immediate consequences, kind of thing. (Participant 1, Interview)

Here, Participant 1 highlights the temporal aspect of choice-making and the importance of a bigger narrative and ludic picture that can enable the player to contextualise their own behaviour on a larger scale. On a macro choice level, i.e. within the context of the whole game, the relationship between player and choice becomes one of responsibility due to being shown the positive as well as negative impacts of the player's behaviour. The player's interpretation of actions and consequences not only as positive or negative, but also as right or wrong (in both a moral and a ludic sense) means that regret and guilt were some of the emotions frequently triggered in the course of the autoethnography more so than during the ethnographic study due to a more holistic understanding of the game.

The full knowledge of previous cause-and-effect chains, combined with the game's own responses, can further instil a strong sense of anxiety as a counterpart to those emotions. In the autoethnography, I became progressively more cautious and deliberate when making choices rather than relying on my choice-making instincts. Given the emotional nature of the games that were played, this eventually led to a somewhat fatalistic attitude to choice-making: 'The game is making me feel sad about my choices, because no matter what I try to do, it always goes wrong...' (Research Diary, Appendix B.4) Additionally, apart from seeing one's choices played out on a macro level, the player's feelings about them are further triggered and affected by the game's communication as discussed in chapter 7, particularly when relating to specific choices and their effect on the characters or the possibility of different outcomes.

The above examples show that the stronger the player's acceptance of their own agency, regardless of the reality of that agency or the nature of the driving factor behind the choices (the game or the player, and in the latter case, which of the player's sometimes conflicting identities), the stronger the player's emotional involvement as they shift responsibility for actions from the game to the player, disregarding the game as an artefact and accepting it as a real consequence. Here, the game's role in responding to the player's actions and occasionally twisting their agency in a 'careful what you

wish for'-type situation plays an important role in deepening this involvement. While on a ludic level, players experience feelings such as joy and satisfaction based on their performance in the game, when it comes to their role within the *narrative*, i.e. when related to dramatic agency, the player's personal investment in the events drives more negative emotions such as anxiety or guilt due to the conflict-driven nature of game design. After all, if there was no conflict at all, there would be little reason for the altercharacter to engage with the game's narrative in the first place.

The observations in this chapter expand the understanding of the player's emotional involvement by considering the role that the specific relationship between game and player has in the gaming experience and shows how *choice-making*, as opposed to mere interactivity, has emotional consequences. Ultimately, the player's emotional engagement is heavily dependent on how much they *want* to be involved. As Leino (2010, p. 2) points out, 'it is well within our powers to inscribe the in-game encounters with whatever significance we can imagine in whichever quantities we desire [...] As voluntary players we can decide what is at stake.' One of the tasks of the game, then, is to drive, raise, and incentivise the player's stakes within the narrative. Often, the main agents of this are the non-player characters that not only populate the game world, but are shown to be directly affected by the altercharacter's choices. The emotional agency that results from this therefore directly drives the stakes the player has within the game and impacts how much responsibility the player accepts for their own actions.

Chapter 10

Part II: Summary

Part II of this thesis set out to establish choice-making as a practice rather than an activity that takes place in a vacuum, highlighting that the experience of playing a video game is a partially social practice that is embedded within the player's connectedness to and experiences with a wider gaming culture. In order to better understand how players make choices and what role choice-making plays for the player's emotional involvement with a video game, chapter 7 first focused on the way in which agency is communicated to the player by investigating more closely how choices are presented to the player prior to making a choice, how they are fed back to the player as a result of their action, and how agency as a whole can be communicated to the player by presenting statistics about the player's choices as well as alternative pathways. Chapter 8 formulated the practice of choice-making by investigating the rationales and impulses on different choice levels – micro and macro as well as ludic and narrative. Here, the player's choice-making behaviour during gameplay was further investigated in the context of the overarching frameworks and rationales that guide player choice in a move from the *act* to the *practice* of making choices. Finally, chapter 9 investigated the player's emotional engagement with the game, with a focus on the interplay between emotion, character, and agency.

As explored in chapter 7, the way in which a game communicates the player's interactive possibilities impacts the player's perception of their own agency and control within the game. Being aware of the potential outcomes of a choice prior to making it plays an important part in the player's ability to make intentional, meaningful choices. The case studies that were more transparent about the game mechanics allowed for planning on the player's part, whereas a lower transparency on the part of the game created a degree of uncertainty. Overall, the game influences how the player interprets choice, and this understanding is strengthened by the game's direct feedback of player choice, too. The player may be given more insight into the way in which their choices are processed by the game through communication on a meta level, for instance choice

statistics that give the player the possibility to not only see which of their choices carried meaningful agency, but, by integrating them within the wider gaming culture, also allow them to assess their own performance. This gives them the chance to change their choice-making approaches accordingly.

These choice-making approaches are integrated within wider choice-making trends that can be conceptualised as a practice. As explored in chapter 8, choices on the micro level are often based on immediate gratification and the player-character's established personality as they did not have a chance yet to formulate clear goals for character and narrative, lacking the holistic view that comes from a deeper ludic and narrative understanding. As the game progresses, the player is able to assume stronger responsibility for the altercharacter's choices and the narrative development. The player's narrative macro choices were observed to be determined by their prediction of the narrative and their specific connection with and goals for the altercharacter, suggesting that the altercharacter itself is often used as guidance for the player just as much as the player guides the altercharacter's development. Similarly, ludic choices were based on the player's long-term planning and their established gaming style, but were often more consistent and coherent than the player's conflicting narrative choices.

Chapter 9 highlighted the way in which the player's relationship to the different elements of the game affects their emotional engagement with the gaming experience. Ludic emotions tend to be mixed and are primarily related to the player's evaluation of their own performance, containing a lot of positive emotions as the player advances their skill. Opposed to this, the strongest emotional reactions in relation to narrative elements of the game are often of a negative kind, with the player willfully engaging and perhaps even seeking out such negative emotions for their dramatic fulfilment. The player's observed emotional engagement with the characters that populate the game highlights the constantly shifting nature of the player-character relationship. While the engagement with non-player characters tends to be parasocial in nature, the relationship between player and altercharacter tends to switch between identification and parasociality, dependent on the negotiation of player and character goals and personalities and the overall struggle for control at any given moment. Finally, the emotions that relate to the player's choice-making practice in particular are dependent on the player's acceptance of their own agency and responsibility within the space of the game, and are therefore partially dependent on the *quality* of choices that the player makes, such as active or passive. This sense of responsibility is highlighted and steered by the game's feedback of the consequences of the player's actions, as well as the player's understanding of their agency, both dramatic and emotional.

Chapter 11

Conclusions

This thesis set out to investigate the relationship between the player – as an entity as well as a person – and the narrative video game with a focus on choice-making and emotional engagement. The primary aim of this thesis was to rethink the player-character relationship in particular by incorporating player choice, emotions, and subjectivity into the way in which we conceive of the narrative video game and its transformative potential. Specifically, it investigated the driving factors behind the player's choice-making behaviours and the way in which this behaviour intersects with the player's subjective experience, interpretation, and emotional engagement. For this purpose, it analysed the roles of the different aspects of the player-game relationship in the player's choice-making behaviours, and further considered the kinds of approaches and methods that are needed to address these subjective and emotional dimensions of the gaming experience.

This thesis, then, offers both a theoretical and methodological model for engagement with video games and contributes to existing theories and understandings of the player-game relationship by looking at the state of the art of gaming and video game research. It presents an analytical framework of the player experience that draws on player-character relationships, interpretation, meaning-making, and choice-making. In order to investigate these aspects of the player experience, this thesis formulates and demonstrates a new games research method that focuses on subjective experiences and creates a synergy between ethnographic and autoethnographic research.

Principally, I establish that the dynamics of the player-game relationship are not only informed by, but actively shape the player's engagement with an interactive narrative. In the context of this research, this relationship is built around the way in which player and game affect one another, drawing on the concepts of interactivity (Smethurst and Craps, 2015) and collusion (Giddings, 2009). Throughout this thesis, I formulate a framework of the gaming experience that acknowledges the specific relationship between game and player, as well as the player's active role of interpretation,

meaning-making, and choice-making through the notion of the *altercharacter*, a concept that draws on and extends the notion of alterbiography (Calleja, 2011) by contextualising the player's subjective experience within their ability to make meaningful choices through the vehicle of the player-character. In focusing specifically on player-character rather than player-narrative interactions, the concept of the *altercharacter* can be understood as a nuanced version of alterbiography, offering an in-depth understanding of the interplay between player interpretation, choice-making, and player-character relationships. Building on the foundation of the player's subjective experience and the communicative nature of the gaming experience, I establish choice-making as a practice that is shaped by both player *and* game, and is embedded within a wider cultural framework of gaming behaviours and literacies. The player's choice-making practices are also shaped by the *altercharacter*, whose construction has emotional consequences for the player via a shared sense of responsibility.

Although the debate of whether or not video games can function as a narrative medium has been largely laid to rest, there is still some hesitation in the game studies community to reconcile interactivity with narrative capacities, for instance by focusing on the way in which the player's agency or interactivity appears to be only illusory. This thesis contributes to this discussion by showing that agency and interactivity are more complex than the binary opposition of whether or not a player has mechanical agency. Instead, agency can occur on a variety of levels, and can in fact be considered a communicative or collaborative experience that is based not only on the player's input and the technical structures of the game, but is guided by the game's feedback, the player's interpretation of their own role within the game, and the constant negotiation of control between game and player. Perhaps contradictorily, one of the most meaningful aspects of agency lies in *not* having agency, in *not* having full control, in having to reconcile the moments of non-interactivity and non-agency, in which the player is acted *upon* by the game, with the player's interpretation of their own actions and responsibilities within the game.

By viewing the gaming experience from a close-up of the player's moment-to-moment as well as overarching experience of the game through an analysis of micro and macro choice-making (Salen and Zimmerman, 2004), I highlight the necessity of acknowledging the player's individual and deeply personal experience in video game analysis that, in relation to the player's emotional involvement, has been previously addressed by for instance Leino (2010). For this purpose, this thesis develops and applies an empirical research method that gives a fuller account of the gaming experience by using the player's and the researcher's subjectivities as a *tool* for conducting research. In doing so, I make both theoretical and methodological contributions to the interdisciplinary field of game studies and enhance the understanding of the way in which player and game work together to create a coherent gaming experience, adding to early game studies

work on narrative by analysing recent games with new ludonarrative mechanics and aesthetics.

11.1 The Dynamics of the Player-Game Relationship

Part I of this thesis deals with the relationship that emerges from the player's experience of and engagement with the various elements of the game, primarily conveyed through the player-character and the player's changing relationship with this character. The player-game relationship is primarily based on the construction of a framework that both player and player-character engage with. As plotted throughout the chapters, the player's initial relationship with the game is constructed through a framework that is of a sensory nature, with the prosthetic qualities of the avatar as established by Klevjer (2012) playing a crucial role in the embodied dimension. While the player finds themselves reflected physically in the avatar, the relationship with the narrative character has a parasocial dynamic in which the player recognises the character as a person in their own right, a notion which is supported through additional information that highlights the character's own voice and interpretation of in-game events.

The player's relationship with the player-character, which combines the ludic and narrative modes of the character, is found not to be based on a dynamic of identification alone. Instead, the player-character is formed based on a merging of the sensibilities and character traits of both player *and* character, taking the player's tripartite identity as observed by Gee (2003) as a starting point and complementing it with the interreactive nature of the experience. This merging leads to the creation of a third entity, the altercharacter, that is based on the player's interpretation of the character, in part prompted by the game's various modes of communication, as well as the ownership and kinship that they have established through the process of making choices on the character's *behalf*, but not *as* the character as such. The formal definition of the altercharacter is set out in chapter 5.2:

The altercharacter is the entity that is formed as a consequence of the player's continuous engagement with a video game and encompasses both player and character personalities. The altercharacter is a product of the player's choice-making behaviours, their interpretation of actions and narrative, and the negotiation of control between player and game.

By characterising the entity between player, ludic character, and narrative character as the altercharacter, I formulate a ludonarrative framework for the player-character relationship that teases out the connections between the interreactive nature of the medium

in the form of choice-making and the narrative elements of the game. Rather than focusing on storytelling as a rigid process in which the player merely experiences a pre-conceived narrative, the concept of the altercharacter accounts for the flexibility of the process, i.e. the discourse between storyteller and story recipient, in this context intersecting with the interactivity that is inherent to the medium, and the negotiations of control and responsibility that continually take place between player and game.

11.2 The Practice of Choice-Making

Throughout this thesis and particularly in Part II, choice-making is established as a *practice* as opposed to a mere *act* that takes place during gameplay. The evaluation of the ethnographic and the autoethnographic data shows that the way in which a player makes choices is not arbitrary, but is instead embedded in a more complex behavioural framework. This framework is determined by the different facets of player identity and their relationship with and prioritisation of different elements and objectives within the game, as well as the integration of the player within a wider gaming community and gaming as an overarching practice that produces a kind of literacy for the player to draw on.

While some overlap can be observed between the participants' choice-making rationales, often where this is prompted by the game itself, the reasoning for making specific choices is dependent on the players' personal moral and emotional frameworks as well as the way in which the game both characterises the narrative character and acknowledges the player as a separate entity that occupies the liminal space between game and reality. Here, a link between choice-making, emotion, and altercharacter is established. Through the process of creating the altercharacter, often on the basis of deliberate interpretation on the player's part as well as the observed effect of the player's actions within the game world, the player's active role within the game creates a strong sense of responsibility, which in turn opens the player up for potentially strong emotional involvement. These findings are especially significant given the long-standing criticisms of the emotional capacities of video games, which often tend to be placed beneath other media such as film. The model of emotional engagement established throughout this thesis demonstrates how games can and do engage the player at a lot of different levels, such as narrative, character, and ludic levels, and how this engagement is driven by the interactive nature of the player-game relationship.

On both ludic and narrative levels, the quality of the player's emotional involvement is dependent on the player's interpretation and explicit evaluation of their own interactive capabilities. Where ludic emotions tend to be related to the player's skill progression, the emotions elicited by the game's narrative and the player's role in affecting it tend to be based on dramatic conflict that the player only has limited control over.

This highlights how the negotiations of control have emotional consequences for the player. The control that the player does exert over the narrative and character development through their ability to make choices, regardless of the degree of mechanical agency that the player possesses, creates a choice-consequence scenario with the player as central actor. Here, choices that the player interprets as being more active or confrontational evoke a stronger sense of responsibility, leading to an increased emotional engagement.

11.3 Methodological Contributions

This thesis consistently highlights the importance of not only acknowledging, but *utilising* the notion of gaming as a subjective, deeply personal experience. The individual player's experience and the necessity to view choice-making as a practice that extends beyond the singular gaming session form the core of this thesis's methodological contributions, in which I formulate a comprehensive research method that addresses and utilises the player and player-researcher's subjective experiences. Here, the notion of the player-researcher draws on the discussions of the term by Aarseth (2003) and Karppi and Sotamaa (2012). My method relies on recordings of the moment of gameplay, the player's reflections during gameplay where applicable, and the player's reflections and interpretations *after* the experience, inspired by the method of micro-ethnology as developed by Giddings (2009).

In this study, ethnographic and autoethnographic data is combined to paint a holistic picture of the experience of a specific game, but also of the experience of gaming in general. The ethnographic part of the study is based on participant observation, in which participants play a segment of a video game with the researcher present. While the player is encouraged to verbalise their thoughts and explain their behaviour during the game, the bulk of the player's reflections about their experiences is addressed in a semi-structured interview directly following the gameplay session. Drawing on retelling as an additional discursive layer (Eladhari, 2018), this allows the researcher to access the player's raw experience as well as their experience as mediated through their own interpretation. The autoethnographic study takes a more holistic approach to the case studies, where the player-researcher plays through a more substantial part of the games, at times in their entirety depending on the length of the game. Here, the player's thoughts are recorded in an entry in the research diary at the end of each session.

Being able to access the raw data of the gameplay sessions as well as the player's own reflections provides the researcher with a more complete understanding of the different aspects of the gaming experience and highlights the wider practice of gaming and choice-making. In order to understand how people experience games, why they make

the choices that they make, and how they are emotionally and cognitively affected by the experience, it is necessary to look at what people are doing in the moment of gameplay, what they *think* they did in the moment of gameplay, and what kinds of conclusions or predictions they make based on these experiences. Moreover, focusing on shorter segments during the ethnographic study and longer segments during the autoethnographic study gives the researcher access to behaviours and interpretations on a micro level as well as on a macro level, providing important insights into the variety of relationships and dynamics that are at play during gameplay.

As with every method, there are certain drawbacks to this methodological approach as well. Approaching the data through textual analysis, in which ethnographic and autoethnographic data is allowed to speak to one another, allows for an in-depth understanding of the gaming experience that would be lacking in a quantitative or statistical study. However, the approach also means that, by virtue of feasibility and data oversaturation, the study sample itself is rather small and, in this case, is fairly homogeneous. This is a trade-off for being able to access people's experiences deeply as opposed to collecting more superficial data, allowing for an in-depth theoretical contribution. Considering the gaming experience itself as well as the player's reflections on this experience is crucial for understanding how people play games and are affected by them, particularly considering that there were observable differences between how players played and how they *thought* they played.

The method developed in this thesis is not one that can be easily applied to smaller research studies due to the significant time investment on the researcher's part and the wealth of different types of data that this approach generates. However, it is my hope that the overall insights – the necessity of marrying ethnographic and autoethnographic data with a focus on the highly subjective aspects of the gaming experience – can be used to inform future methodological considerations in video game research. As demonstrated throughout this thesis, this approach allows for an interweaving of ethnographic material, textual description, and conceptual development that provides a great level of depth and insight into the engagement between player and game. This new kind of microethnographic thick description contributes to game studies, and media studies in general, by providing a way of engaging with research subjects that puts a greater focus on their actual experience.

11.4 Industry Applications

The main focus of this thesis is to present a new understanding of the player, their different levels of engagement with a video game, and the way in which they make choices. As such, the framework of player experience formulated throughout this thesis can offer new insights and considerations not only for the analysis, but also for

the development of video games. The analysis of how the player-game relationship is formed includes an investigation of the game's numerous ways of signalling and impacting this relationship, including an investigation of how agency is communicated in the case studies, and what impact this communication has on the player's actual experience of agency. Similarly, understanding how the player's interpretation, emotional engagement, and choice-making behaviour is prompted by certain game design choices can help developers design more fluent and organic gaming experiences that allow for the player to engage with the video game and its characters in a more meaningful way. The concept of the altercharacter is particularly relevant here as it highlights the multitude of character interpretations that may or may not be initially intended by the designers.

In highlighting and utilising the subjective nature of the gaming experience and drawing attention to the way in which players respond differently to certain mechanics, this thesis can also be applied to testing and quality assurance, falling within the remit of user experience design and research. As such, its methodological considerations can find direct applications in the games industry. The method developed throughout this thesis can be considered a highly nuanced form of user experience research, allowing researchers to capture and analyse data on the deeper levels of the gaming experience that are not necessarily accessible through more conventional research methods. It can therefore form a valuable addition to existing games user research toolkits.

11.5 Recommendations for Further Research

The exploratory nature of this study and the strengths and limitations that emerge from taking this particular approach as outlined above open up many different avenues for future research. This thesis takes a holistic perspective with its aim to gain a more comprehensive understanding of the gaming experience and the player-game relationship in particular. Consequently, it covers a lot of different aspects of the human-technology relationship, some of which are regrettably not able to receive the in-depth treatment that they deserve. The relationship between the player's notions of identity – in regards to themselves and the player-character – and their gaming behaviour, the link between the player's memory and their ludic and narrative interpretation of in-game events, and the role of the player's emotions in shaping choice-making behaviours are only some avenues that can be pursued in more detail in future studies. Given this thesis's focus on subjectivity both on the part of the player and on the part of the player-researcher, an intersectional study focusing on the link between the player-game relationship and aspects of player identity such as gender, race, disability, neurodivergence, or age, would form a particularly fruitful extension of this thesis's findings.

While this study looks at both short-term and long-term engagement with video games by combining the ethnographic and autoethnographic studies, future research can involve more long-term studies by for instance conducting similar participant-observation over the course of several months with a focus on the player's continuous engagement with the same video game. This would enable observations regarding the player's changing relationship with a game over time, and further allow for an evaluation of the way in which their own interpretations and objectives affect their behaviour and cognitive and emotional engagement with a video game.

Building on the limitations of the study sample addressed above, the engagement model that is constructed throughout this thesis can be further refined by increasing the diversity of the players that are analysed. Incorporating different backgrounds and media literacies and more deeply considering their impact on the player's choice-making practices would enable us to better understand the different processes that are at play in the gaming experience, and could be extended to our understanding of engagement with other digital media as well.

Finally, the concept of the altercharacter has only been established and applied on the basis of a narrow sample of games, focusing on a specific type of narrative video game that uses a playable protagonist as a focal point of both the story and the gameplay mechanics. In its current form, the applications of the altercharacter are limited to these types of character-driven narrative games. Future studies may extend the findings of this thesis by testing the concept of the altercharacter against other game genres, and more deeply investigate choice-making practices in relation to, for instance, games of emergence, narrative games without a focal character, or games with shell characters rather than characters with an established or communicated personality.

Appendix A

Interview Structure and Questions

- **Brief recap of the purpose of the interview**
- **Game-specific questions**
 - Was there a specific point or points in the game where you felt your choices had a meaningful effect?
 - Did you feel that the choices you made in the game were meaningful
 - * for gameplay purposes?
 - * in terms of the development of the story?
 - If applicable, how did the game communicate to you whether or not/what kind of impact your choices had?
 - *Examination of specific choices that were made in the video game – depending on the video game, certain decision points were identified beforehand, both meaningful and non-meaningful.*
 - * Did you have a reasoning for the choices that you made in the game?
 - * Why do you think you made choice X/Y/Z?
 - * Do you feel there were any other significant decisions that you made?
 - *Open discussion based on the observations during gameplay.*
- **General gaming questions**
 - How do you typically make choices in video games? (Is there a specific rationale for making choices?)
 - How did the way you were able to make choices in this game compare to other games that you have played?
 - How often do you play video games?
 - * What kind of video games do you like to play?
 - *Open discussion based on the participant's gaming experiences.*

Appendix B

Research Diary

B.1 General Notes and Thoughts

Game	Research Period	Total hours played
<i>Life is Strange</i>	17-21 August 2020	18:28
<i>Life is Strange 2</i>	14-23 September 2020	19:19
<i>Horizon Zero Dawn</i>	25 August - 7 September 2020	18:48
<i>Detroit: Become Human</i>	8-16 October 2020	12:28

TABLE B.1: Autoethnography – Overview

The autoethnography of the four games took place between August and October 2020. Based on an initial read-through of the below research diary, a majority of my observations revolved around the relationship between player and character, which became particularly complicated in *Detroit: Become Human* due to the presence of three player-characters whose storylines intersected and at times even competed with one another. Interestingly, the characters that I felt closest with changed throughout the course of the game as well, which is also reflected in the use of ‘I’ throughout the research diary: At first, ‘I’ was associated more closely with Kara than the other characters, however towards the end of the autoethnography the notion of ‘I’ had become associated mainly with Connor and I had established some distance between myself and the other characters. To a degree, this might be due to the active role I had in constructing this character in a narrative sense. While the other characters’ personalities do respond to the choices that are made throughout the game, his struggle between his programming and his shifting attitude to deviancy had a much stronger impact on my thoughts about the game than Kara’s mother-daughter relationship with Alice and their attempted escape to Canada, or Markus’s role in transforming the public opinion towards androids. Connor is also the character that is being played most (14 chapters), closely followed by Markus (13 chapters); Kara on the other hand is only present for 9 chapters in the

game, which was cut short in my case because she died prematurely in the final chapter. Kara's and Markus's deviancy is predetermined by the game however; Connor's was entirely my choice. In addition to that, I had experienced most failures and mistakes in Connor's storyline and had to actively work on improving the relationship with Hank. This seems to be a significant aspect of my relationship with Connor because there is a sense of being able to *fail* to produce the kind of character that I wanted him to be, which gave me a sense of anxiety that went beyond simply wanting to have a specific narrative outcome. I already knew some potential outcomes from previous playthroughs and knew that I would likely be able to turn him into a deviant either way, however this prior knowledge did not seem to impact my own sense of anxiety as a player.

In *Life is Strange* and *Life is Strange 2*, I was presented with complete narrative characters in the form of Max and Sean, but being able to decide what kind of character they would become through gameplay made me feel more in control of them on the one hand, and accept them more as autonomous beings on the other hand. This may seem like a strange combination, however being in control of the character's development (to a certain degree) allowed me to explore their personality through choice-making as well. Especially when the player-characters ended up doing, saying, or reacting to certain things in ways that I had not intended, their autonomy as a person was highlighted. In Sean's case, I specifically comment on *understanding* him at a later point in the study, an understanding that highlighted our differences, but brought us closer together as well. This kind of relationship was largely missing in *Horizon Zero Dawn* as I had no influence on Aloy's narrative character at all, and due to the open-world format, the almost 19 hours of gameplay contained limited narrative engagement. While I appreciated aspects of her character in cut-scenes or in dialogues, our relationship was more physical, to the point where Aloy often disappeared from my vision quite literally, as I specifically mention that I often fail to *see* her on screen unless it is in a cut-scene.

Another aspect that I observed frequently was the diegetic and non-diegetic communication of gameplay-relevant aspects of the game. Here, the use of music was highlighted in particular, to the extent where a change of music in *Horizon Zero Dawn* alerted me to the presence of enemies sooner than diegetic markers. When this happened, my first reaction was often to find a hiding spot, followed by navigating the camera in order to identify where the enemies were and devise a strategy to deal with them. In one session I had issues interpreting the music, which caused a sense of disorientation. The game's communication was often perceived as helpful when it was indirect and 'invisible' – such as music –, but I comment on feeling patronised when *Life is Strange 2* reiterates in tutorial pop-ups how to perform certain actions at the beginning of an episode, and when the player-characters in the various games talk about what needs to be done. There is a sense of stubbornness there, too, a feeling that the game doesn't think I'm smart enough to figure it out by myself and wanting to 'prove it wrong'.

B.2 *Life is Strange*

17 August 2020 (partial Episode 1) I started my autoethnography a bit frustrated and exasperated because of the never-ending issues with setting up gameplay recording at home – after having figured out the recording setup for *Life is Strange* last Friday, OBS kept crashing this morning and in the end I had to give up recording on my own laptop and switched to my partner's. (Recording in the games lab would have been perfect if we were allowed to access campus.)

I've played and seen the beginning of *Life is Strange* so many times through testing the recording setup and doing the ethnographic study last year, and that makes me feel comforted. It's probably been about five years since I played the entire game though and since then I tended to play the first episode only for research purposes (and even that not fully at times). My knowledge of the game itself is quite good and I do remember the main plot points, but there are a lot of minor decisions and details that I don't remember and I'm sure that will become more evident as the sessions continue and I am out of familiar waters. I remember that Mr Jefferson is the bad guy of course, and knowing what I know of his actions, his statement at the beginning – "I could frame any of you in a dark corner" etc. – creeps me out immensely. The first time I played this I remember being somewhat infatuated with Mr Jefferson; now I just recognise him for the pretentious and arrogant character that he is and I want to avoid spending time with him as much as possible. I remember Kate will try to commit suicide at some point, but I don't remember what the choices were that would have stopped her. I remember changing the past so that Chloe's dad survives, and Chloe ending up in a wheelchair, and I remember the fateful choice at the end, whether or not to save Chloe once and for all. Those really are the main points I remember, but knowing about them vaguely and not remembering the details or the 'right' decisions makes me anxious playing.

I am immediately drawn into the game in the nightmare scene, primarily because of the sound effects and the controller vibrating in my hand – it makes it feel more real and more tactile. Most of today's session felt very much like going through the motions since I had played it so much in testing, but I really enjoyed exploring the campus, looking at everything and talking to everyone, and reading up on Max's journal in more detail, which I hadn't done in a while and it added some more context to how she was feeling. I was particularly drawn to the collectibles – the photos – and found myself seeking them out more than I had in previous playthroughs, feeling a sense of achievement when I found some of the more elusive ones. I'm not sure I got all of the ones in the scenes that I played today.

I made a few major decisions today – I told the Principal the truth, knowing I would get in trouble with my parents but feeling it would be the right thing to do, and I didn't change my choice. I dislike Nathan to such an extent that I thought telling the truth

would help (even though I knew it wouldn't). I was kind to Victoria because I don't particularly like confrontation, and I don't think it was really necessary in that moment either. Victoria clearly has some issues and I don't have to get down to her level. I initially took a picture of the security guard threatening Kate, but changed my decision because I'd rather be kind to Kate, who I have a lot of sympathy for. Knowing that I can change my choices in the scene does affect my behaviour; I would normally feel quite anxious about making the right choice, but knowing that I can rewind within the same scene and see different immediate consequences does make me feel more in control. It does mean that my instinctual decisions don't matter as much though and my rational thinking takes over more.

I do feel a lot more empathy for Chloe than for Max, especially after reading Max's diary and having the conversations with Chloe about Max never getting in touch after moving away. I feel quite conflicted about Max's personality, and I developed a much better understanding of Chloe through *Between the Storm* as well, so I feel myself disagreeing with Max's evaluations of things or reactions to things a lot more. I'll see if I feel closer to her as time goes on.

18 August 2020 (end of Episode 1, partial Episode 2) I was more annoyed than intrigued with today's session, though the ending of Episode 1 (which I played in the morning) was fine – I realised that while I disagree with a lot of Max's past choices, I can make her a better person or character through my own choice-making, so it was aimed at making her more confrontational and standing up to people when possible or appropriate. Maybe I do empathise with Max a lot – I had a lot of social anxiety as a teenager as well and left my friends when I moved away. Maybe this is the point that annoys me the most; having spent most of the past 11 years away from my home country and from my friends and family that were still there, I know how hard it can be to keep in touch, but Max's way of handling it made me furious, especially given what happened to Chloe's father.

So far, Episode 2 was not particularly exciting, and my attitude towards Max and Chloe changed quite a bit in this episode – Chloe was a primarily annoying with her bossy, petulant attitude and blaming Max for everything, while at the same time worshipping her powers. The junkyard was a particularly frustrating scene though because of its geography. I found it difficult to navigate and the objective – finding five bottles to shoot – was not particularly exciting. It was especially annoying when I encountered a bug that would not let me rewind the bottle that fell and I had to play the whole scene again (which I didn't like in the first place).

The scenes before that were much more interesting though, and I feel anxious about Kate to the point where I looked up the particular choice of what advice to give her, though I didn't look at all the consequences of her choices because I didn't want to

spoil it too much. Looking it up basically gave me confirmation of the choice I had settled on anyway, and I rewound to that one because Kate's reaction was quite harsh. So far Kate seems to be the character that is most effective in making you change your choices. I am curious to see how her situation resolves and whether I'll be able to get her a good ending.

19 August 2020 (end of Episode 2, partial Episode 3) Today I played the rest of Episode 2, which was quite an emotional episode finishing with Kate's suicide attempt that I had anticipated already – although I wasn't sure in which episode it would take place. Overall the episode felt very stressful in terms of the game's pacing – the railway scene was intense as I was unsure what I would have to do and was under time pressure, and heard the crash and Chloe's yells for help several times before I managed to get the correct tool. I cut the correct wire completely by accident and was expecting to rewind a few more times there. The scenes at Blackwell Academy at first seemed inconsequential until Kate's suicide attempt and I was thrown by the change in gameplay mechanic, as I had gotten so used to being able to rewind everything that I was feeling anxious and tense when I was not able to do so in trying to prevent Kate from jumping. The feedback throughout the conversation was promising and validated some major as well as some seemingly minor choices that I had made throughout the game so far, such as erasing messages or the link to Kate's video. I was extremely relieved when I succeeded in saving Kate. The next big choice that I was very unsure about was who to blame for the incident, and unlike with other choices I went through every single option to see the consequences before I settled on blaming Nathan – even though a big part of me felt that I should blame Mr Jefferson as I know he's the bad guy, but Nathan seemed more immediately threatening. I am finding myself switching between what I want for the narrative, what I want for the character, and what I want from a gameplay point of view, and I am not sure yet what triggers which mode.

So far, Episode 3 (which I assume I have almost finished) was less intense, but consisted of more 'gameplay' as I had to use the rewind mechanic several times to sneak around and avoid detection, rather than simply re-doing a dialogue option. It doesn't feel that there were too many important choices in this episode yet – I don't know what the significance of kissing Chloe is (or if there is one), and I was very torn about whether to side with David or Chloe. This is another major choice that I rewound several times before going with one that I wasn't completely convinced about, and I sided with Chloe mainly because I didn't want to face her anger and disappointment – I do think it would have been better to be in David's good books as he might be a good ally further along in the game. I did notice that I got gradually more impatient as my session went on however, and when I was at the diner I ended up not exploring as much anymore – or just exploring for the sake of being completionist, but without real interest –, which

goes to show that after about four hours of playing in one go I was getting a bit tired of it.

One thing that I got incredibly annoyed with today was the way the rewind mechanic works, particularly the fact that I wasn't able to cancel a rewind anymore once I had started it by going with the "undo last action" mechanic. Also, knowing that the dots on the spiral signify specific actions in the game is not of much use if the individual actions aren't shown, and I ended up having to re-do things I didn't want to undo. I wonder what else I have missed and accidentally undone along the way. Maybe it's a way to signal that time travel is unpredictable, but it feels more like a flaw in game design and a failure to communicate the main game mechanic properly.

20 August 2020 (end of Episode 3, partial Episode 4) I felt a bit more stressed today because of taking my cats to the vet's, so it took me a bit to get into the gaming mood. I had hoped to finish Episode 3 and complete Episode 4 today, but in the end I didn't manage to complete Episode 4 – I think I must be somewhat close though. Last night I kept thinking about the choices that I had made in this episode and was unsure whether I should have sided with David after all. From a gameplay perspective I feel I should have sided with him, but from a narrative perspective I had to call him out on his paranoia. I think this presented the biggest clash so far in my personal objectives.

I had expected the ending of Episode 3 – I vaguely remembered Chloe in a wheelchair from my first playthrough – but being in the past still made me feel a bit nostalgic, and knowing what would happen didn't get rid of the sense of guilt at the beginning of Episode 4. The whole section in the alternate timeline was heartbreaking, but I genuinely started to cry a little bit when Chloe asked me to help her commit suicide, to the point where I didn't know what choice I would want to take. I was going to roll a die to decide, but accidentally bumped my controller in the process and chose to decline the request. However, Chloe's reaction immediately told me that I didn't want to stick with that choice, even though I knew I would go back to the current timeline eventually, so I went back and accepted her request instead – a very sad thing. I changed my choice because I didn't want to let Chloe down again – especially not in that situation – and it seemed like the right thing to do, though I'm not sure if that's what Max would be able to do. However Max's character has changed a lot and she has become more assertive (both in the narrative and in the way I play her it feels), so maybe she would.

A large part of the episode seemed to be the regular going around, talking to everyone and looking at everything kind of thing as I was investigating Nathan. For a while I was more focused on taking the photos so my objectives shifted a bit, but investigating Nathan's room drew me back into the narrative and I felt very engaged with what was going on – started to feel sorry for Nathan as well, which I hadn't really done yet. The more interesting – and frustrating – scene was the one with Frank, as I had to rewind to

get a decent outcome, and wasn't sure I would get a better one. However, I did rewind a few more times just to see what would happen with some of the other approaches and was positively surprised to see that I had actually gotten a good ending to this – I had expected that there would be no 'good' ending and that it would be a matter of accepting one bad thing versus the other bad thing. Investigating the different clues felt more game-like again and I was enjoying actually puzzling out the different clues, though some of them were just trial and error. I was also a bit annoyed at the way Max kept reiterating what I needed to do, as I felt that she was a bit unnecessarily pushy towards me. I felt quite a bit of satisfaction though when I did find the correct answer – I think that would have been a lot more interesting if I had actually been able to fail that situation and not receive as much detail or as good information (maybe that would be too branching though). I'm looking forward to finding out more tomorrow and finishing the episode – and maybe I'll be able to play the last episode as well.

21 August 2020 (end of Episode 4, complete Episode 5) Today was an incredibly intense session – to be expected from the game's ending, but I didn't remember quite how intense it was. Episode 4 had indeed almost been at an end and the Dark Room was incredibly creepy – it didn't take long to figure out the puzzle to get in, which was fairly straightforward. My heart broke for Chloe when they found Rachel's body and I expected the episode to end then, had I not seen the preview of this episode that included the Vortex Club party. Even though I already knew the outcome of the situation and that Mark Jefferson was the bad guy, I was incredibly anxious about finding out where Nathan was (I didn't remember that he had been killed), and the situation felt very stressful both for me and for the characters. The party situation definitely didn't help and overall I felt very overwhelmed, and kept second-guessing the choices that I had made earlier.

I'm glad that I managed to play Episode 5 in one go as I don't think I would have been able to stop halfway through. This episode really felt like the high of all the guilt I had accumulated over the past episodes, and going back into different realities and timelines was interesting but intense, especially given that the scene in the Dark Room had to be played several times with different objectives. Mr Jefferson disgusted me so much and I felt physically unclean just watching him in those scenes, while also feeling helpless because I wasn't able to control Max as much as I normally could. The game did a really good job making you care about everyone involved even if they might not have been pleasant characters beforehand. Even Nathan's voicemail broke my heart. It was of course obvious that Max's powers were the cause of the weather anomalies, but even though this was literally the point of the game, I felt guilty anyway. The nightmare scenes were incredibly stressful and I was struggling with the maze in particular – I'm not good at spatial navigation or orientation in real life *or* in video games, and because of the darkness I was having severe problems figuring out where

to go to the point where I looked up the first part of the maze. Despite the stressful situation I took the time to collect the bottles in this scene in order to take the picture (I am frustrated that I wasn't able to get all the photos that I wanted to get though). I had said before that I suspected I would want to save Chloe at the end and already had a sense of pre-guilt about knowing that it would be the wrong decision, logically and morally speaking. After seeing the havoc the storm caused in Arcadia Bay, I didn't think I could save Chloe – I didn't think I could justify it, but walking through the scenes of their friendship and my attachment to Chloe through the prequel sealed the deal for me. I remember that last time I played the game I saved Arcadia Bay, this time I saved Chloe and I'm hoping I'll get to see her again in *Life is Strange 2*. It was a very emotional choice though and it actually made me cry a bit. I still feel guilty after the fact. A part of me also wanted to accept the choices that had been made for once; the game was so focused on going back and fixing mistakes and changing things around that this time, I wanted to face some responsibility for what I had done.

25 August 2020 (Post-Reflection) It's been a few days since I finished *Life is Strange* now and I noticed that my brain kept returning to the game over the weekend, so I wanted to write down my thoughts. No doubt because I essentially binge-played it within a week – anyone's brain would get back to it – but rather than just thinking about it, I first continued feeling really guilty about the choice I made. After a while I noticed I was justifying my choices for myself though; yes, I made a lot of choices throughout the game that I ended up regretting – telling Victoria about Nathan for instance, getting Nathan suspended, or telling David about Chloe's death – but the more I thought about the ending, the more I realised that I don't actually need to feel bad about those choices because they wouldn't have changed the overall outcome. The choices changed nuances of the game for sure – the way Max reflected on them in her diary, or certain dialogue choices, maybe even smaller to medium events, but in the end it boiled down to only two choices – 'Save Chloe' or 'Save Arcadia Bay' –, so nothing outside of those choices mattered anymore. They especially don't matter anymore because presumably everybody is dead now anyway, which is my fault too. Strangely enough, even though that should make me feel even more guilty, it is also a bit of a relief because I didn't have to face the consequences of my individual actions. I definitely did not make the morally just choice – I cannot justify saving Chloe over saving everyone else in my mind, but I did it anyway. Something about utilitarianism I'm sure. On the one hand it's frustrating knowing that in the grand scheme of things my choices throughout the episodes didn't really matter that much, but on the other hand I'm also relieved knowing that I didn't have as much agency as it felt I did. If only because that means I'm somehow less responsible – but it doesn't make that much sense either.

B.3 *Horizon Zero Dawn*

25 August 2020 I made the decision to start with *Horizon Zero Dawn* at this point because I felt I needed a break from the emotionally charged, heavily choice-based kind of game that I played last week. I played *Horizon Zero Dawn* last year I believe, so I do know the story roughly, but I don't remember all the details, only occasional quests. I guess it pays off that my memory of media I've consumed is not that great because it actually means I can replay things and still get a good amount of enjoyment out of them. What I do remember is the overarching narrative – Aloy's mother/clone, and the evil machine trying to take over the world, and I remember some of the main quests but nothing to a very detailed degree. In this case though, I feel that knowing the ending and the plot twists won't really impact my enjoyment of the game because it feels that that's not what you play these kinds of games for.

I was struggling getting motivated today though – I am extremely tired so my heart wasn't in it and it felt like I was just going through the motions at some point (though I still enjoyed playing the beginning again). The first thing I noticed was how surprised I was to basically slip into playing the game – I never really noticed before how you just automatically assume the perspective and take control of the player-character in a very natural way (given that the controls are not going to be *too* different from other games). It's like putting on a well-worn glove. The familiarity of gaming is somewhat soothing. Of course I didn't get too much further from the tutorial today – I did some side quests and errands, some because I wanted to do them, others because they happened to be conveniently next to me and I ran into them, so I figured I might as well do them before going ahead with the main storyline. I really, really enjoy stealth in this game, though a few times the machines detected me and I had a bit of a button-smashing massacre on my hands. Didn't die though. The game is quite good at feeding back what I'm supposed to be doing as well as what I've just done – both verbally and in writing – but I felt that often I don't even read the feedback that attentively. When I pick up things, for example, I tend to pick them up regardless of what they are, and only realise afterwards what I've picked up, unless I'm specifically looking for something like the medicinal herbs. It's interesting how you can be kind of absent-minded and just automatically do the things that the game wants you to do, though that might also just be because I'm so tired today. Maybe tomorrow I'll have some renewed energy.

26 August 2020 It was a busy day today, so I didn't get to play quite as much, a bit less than an hour and a half. I finished the side quests that I had picked up yesterday, and started following the main quest for a little bit. Rost said that I needed to prepare for the quest and I feel that I probably went in a bit overprepared, but better safe than sorry. I spent a bit of time looking at the crafting menu and expanding the capacity for the different satchels – I know that I tend to pick up everything I see in the beginning

of playing a game because I won't know what exactly I'll need and when, so I always go for the option to upgrade carry capacity as soon as I can. I also looked at crafting some health potions, which I needed to hunt different kinds of animals for – I ended up feeling a bit bad for killing all those animals because they look quite cute and some of them make cute noises. I noticed some things around how I'm playing the game today – main thing was the way I perceived my surroundings. Particularly when I'm on my way to another quest, I tend to run and my orientation is almost exclusively via the game interface – mainly the quest marker and occasionally other things that pop up, like resources to gather. I don't really pay that much attention to the actual game world unless something catches my attention, which mainly happens through sound. I may hear an animal or a machine and that's when I focus on my actual surroundings. I also use the map to navigate a lot but don't really pay attention to landmarks. I guess in real life my sense of direction is also quite bad, so I suppose it makes sense that this is reflected in gameplay as well. Quest markers in real life would be handy. I did get lost a few times in the game when I didn't need to get lost if I had just spent some more time actually looking at where I'm going and thinking about the route.

My style was quite stealthy again today. I particularly enjoy the skill that I picked when levelling up which means I can lure machines to my location. There is a strange sense of pleasure in calling a machine and then sitting there until it comes over, and taking it down silently. If the other machines don't notice and I can repeat this several times in a row, that's even more satisfying. It's not very confrontational, but it means that I generally don't lose a lot of health. The Sawtooth quest was the one where my fighting style had to become more offensive and I quite enjoyed that too – it gave me a different kind of satisfaction, to do with skill and adrenaline rather than cunning I suppose. I tried to trip it with my trip wires first before it detected me, and then I kept dodging out of the way and kept shooting it with my arrows. I was quite pleased with the result of that.

I haven't made that much progress story-wise today though; Rost was teaching me to defeat the Sawtooth and gave me a speech about how I need to be part of the tribe and protect the tribe. Rost saying goodbye to Aloy was a bit sad though – he's quite a cool character and I really like their relationship. Also, Aloy is nicely down-to-earth and I really enjoy playing her. Tomorrow I'll carry on with the main quest and run the Proving. I know the game is going to open up a lot more after that and I'm looking forward to that.

27 August 2020 I'm feeling a bit exhausted after today's session, which is interesting because it wasn't even as long as some of the *Life is Strange* sessions I did last week – I only did about 2.5 hours today but it felt longer. I wonder if maybe that is because I need to do more in this game – more navigating of the surroundings, more choice as to where I go and what I do and how. I was quite conscious today of the kind of

adrenaline rush during combat, maybe that also plays a part in it. It just feels physically more exhausting, so I might need to break it into smaller chunks of play, but I'll see how things go the next few sessions. A lot happened to me in the game today – like I said yesterday, I continued with the main quest and went into the village, which I found a bit overwhelming because of all the NPCs and all the sounds, which is in quite strong contrast to what I was experiencing before – maybe that's a way of me connecting with Aloy as well as she was a bit overwhelmed too. I quite like the Vanguard guy (though I already forgot his name), I think it's quite amusing how flirty he gets with me. He also just generally seems to be a cool character and I seem to remember that that was the case later in the game too. I made a few character decisions today – I found Bast really annoying (he reminded me a lot of Nathan in *Life is Strange*), but I ended up choosing the angry option when Vala talked to me afterwards. I didn't really like the result of that though, it made me look a lot more petulant than I'd meant to. I also chose the compassionate response when I talked to Resh, even though I wanted to punch him for talking to me in that way – but he was dishonouring the people who had just died and he didn't have a right to do that. I'd just gone through a lot in the Proving.

On the one hand I enjoy the world being open to me now that I'm a Seeker, but it's also a bit intimidating. I chose to go for one of the main quests since I only have two at the moment, but I got sidetracked by the Hunting Lodge – I like honing my skills and it always gives me a nice sense of achievement when I get good times in these things, so I enjoyed that and did it a second time to get the best result. Tomorrow I'll go follow the main quest some more looking for Sona, but I expect I'll end up getting distracted by sidequests again. I quite enjoyed thinking about what I want to do with the character in levelling up and already have a plan to get the skills I want in the end.

28 August 2020 Today, again, felt like a lot, but I think I accomplished a few things in the game, which made me more comfortable with it as well. On my way to the main quest to find War Chief Sona, I encountered Nil – who is a bit of a creep – and decided to do his quest first to take out a bandit camp. It wasn't on the way to where I had to go at all – I had to go a bit out of my way to do it – but I thought it'd be a good way to get some combat in, hone my skills and gain more XP so I can level up faster. I was going to be very sneaky taking out the bandits and had a bit of a plan, but it went awry immediately so it was a bit of a massacre, but not too difficult, everything considered. On my way to the quests that I wanted to do I also overrode the first Tallneck, giving me more information about the area, though I haven't really looked at what extra things there might be since I was too busy going after the main quest after that. Again, when taking out the killers' camp I wanted to be sneaky to minimise the stress, but failed at that straight away so it ended up being quite a bit more hectic than anticipated, especially when fighting the corrupted machines. I should get better gear and look at the modifications, but ideally I want to wait until I've got the Tinker skill so that I can

re-use them and experiment with everything properly. I then decided to carry on with this quest and go to the next site because I already felt immersed in it, and I didn't want to break my focus and go into something completely different. Unfortunately I ran into some Fire Bellowbacks and might have been too confident in my skills (at this point at least) because it was a *really* difficult fight and I ended up running out of my medicine pouch. The first Bellowback I killed with a bit of a plan (using my frost bombs), the second one was more button smashing, rolling around and trying not to get hit since I was pretty low on resources. I'm honestly surprised I didn't die in that bit and kept thinking how annoying it would be to reload and walk all the way again (though I would have wanted to avoid them the second time if that had been the case). I fought more Fire Bellowbacks that attacked some of the other Nora, but those were a lot easier because they had already taken them down a bit. I was on the fence about whether to help them though because my medicine pouch was so low.

Outside of combat I think most of my efforts were focused on hunting animals for potions or crafting and – more importantly – to gather more herbs to fill up the medicine pouch. I'm really glad I chose the bigger medicine pouch when levelling up because I definitely needed it now. I also tried to sneak around machine sites as much as possible at that point – I was exhausted from all the combat and I guess my game style really changes based on the availability of my resources; I'm a lot more confident when I have plenty of health to help me through combat, but try to avoid it if I'm low on those things.

Even though not that much happened narratively speaking – as in meaningful cut-scenes – I'm starting to feel closer to Aloy, probably because of all the stuff we've had to do together so far; especially today was quite intense. I'm enjoying the freedom of choice in terms of where to go and what to do, but I get a bit overwhelmed with all the information on the map, now that I bought some extra maps with collectibles on. I tried to find one of the ancient vessels and wasn't able to locate it and gave up because I got annoyed, *but* instead I found some random data points in the wild. I really enjoy those because they give insight into the way the world was prior to whatever happened to get the world in this kind of state.

So overall, I do feel a bit accomplished, but I don't feel that I was particularly skilled today, I was mostly lucky that I wasn't killed in the process. Next time I want to follow that quest some more and hit the smaller camps, but I couldn't be bothered to do that today.

1 September 2020 Coming back from the long weekend, I felt like I needed some time to figure out what my plans were for the game. I guess the disadvantage (or advantage) of open-world games is that they're open enough for you to have your own goals and priorities, but it means that there is never really a sense of urgency in anything you

do because you've got all the time in the world. The game's active quest objectives shown in the corner of the screen reminded me that I was going to do the main quest though and take out the camps to take out the killers, and I was also instantly reminded that I had wanted to sort out my inventory before doing that. The next merchant was really far away though, so I decided to do the first one immediately – of course after killing some Corrupted Watchers because they're everywhere those camps are. The first camp that I did went quite well and I managed to be mostly sneaky I think. I visited a merchant before doing the second one because I was annoyed at not being able to pick up all the loot, so I had to sell some of my items – I don't want anything to go to waste. With the second camp I failed at being sneaky and it just ended in a big fight, and I had a strategy for the third one that helped me be sneaky and remain undetected for quite a while, whilst taking out the enemies one by one (I really enjoy doing that, but I also wish the AIs weren't so stupid, as that would be much more of a challenge – maybe that's related to my difficulty level though). After that, it was time to take out the big camp, which went *very badly*. The first objective was to sneak to the blaze containers to blow up the Corruptors and let the other Nora in, but I was detected very, very quickly, which was bad because I had enemies and a load of really big corrupted machines on my back. I was pretty sure that I was going to die in that fight because in the stress of it all I lost track of where I had to go to set the blaze on fire. I did eventually find it, but only after a few rounds of running away and hiding and hoping the machines and enemies wouldn't find me. It was quite stressful and I ended up mostly hiding once the other Nora got there, alternating between shooting and hiding because I was pretty low on health. I didn't die in the end, but I don't really have a sense of achievement from this and am quite frustrated with myself. Maybe I'm not as good at video games as I think I am. I was also a bit disappointed by the end of that quest because it was quite abrupt – it was a big boss fight kind of thing, but there wasn't really a lot of story after that (apart from Varl seemingly hitting on Aloy). I was hoping that I'd find at least some data points to scan as a reward for doing all of this, but instead they were just like 'Ok, cool, thanks for helping, see you later.' I'm not sure what the point of that quest was for the sake of story, apart from the revenge motif.

I didn't have any other side quests open apart from the Hunting Grounds so I headed to Mother's Crown to follow the other main quest. Once I got there the map lit up with loads of exclamation marks signalling new quests, so I made sure to talk to everyone to pick up my quests before getting more information for the main one. For the main quest I need to first clear some corrupted zones, which I didn't really feel like doing today because I had just done so much difficult fighting already. Instead I ended the day with two of the side quests – because why not – that weren't that exciting, but were something to do. I really want to do the Cauldron next because the game is giving me more override codes after that, so that will be quite relevant for gameplay, and it's something different to do from the main quests.

Another big part of today was resource management. I finally upgraded all the pouches that I was able to at this point, and bought some new outfits and weapons that sound like they will be useful going forward. I also looked more properly at the different coils that I can put in my gear (really need to get the Tinker skill to be able to exchange them because now my good ranged damage coil is stuck in my old outfit). It makes me feel good because it makes me feel more prepared. Tomorrow I suppose it's time for the Cauldron, and probably main quest because that's the most interesting thing I've got going so far.

2 September 2020 I was quite tired when I started playing today so I expected that I would struggle a bit, but it turned out that I was much more awake by the end of the session. Adrenaline? I remembered straight away that I was going to go for the Cauldron today – of course on the way there I ran into another side quest that I figured I might as well do before heading in, and it took a lot longer than I expected and introduced me to a new machine – the Stalker is really annoying because of its cloaking device, but I managed just fine in the end. Actually, I'm realising that so far I have not died a single time in the game, except for that one time in the Proving when I accidentally stepped off the mountain – that makes me feel quite accomplished because I've definitely had a few close ones. It's probably also just that I try to avoid confrontation when possible anyway, and prefer to take out enemies sneakily rather than having a horde of them breathing down my neck – it's more skilful than just the button-smashing of close combat. The Cauldron was cool and not as difficult as I remembered, though the Fire Bellowback at the end was quite something and almost drained me of all my healing. In those situations I prefer to just run away to a safer spot, fire, and run again (but with that machine you kind of have to do that anyway). I quickly realised that I was having inventory issues again, this time with my modifications, and kept having to choose which ones to throw away to pick up some of the other ones. The modification pouch upgrade needed fox bones, which I didn't have, so I went fox hunting but they seemed quite rare and it took me ages to find the second one.

I then carried on with the main quest – the corrupted zones weren't that much of an issue after all, which might be because I understand the game better now, and also have upgraded my gear and levelled up certain skills. Rather than just fighting the machines, I now look them up frequently in the notebook to see what their specific weaknesses are, and there's a certain kind of satisfaction in doing these things right. I also bought some new weapons that are going to make this a lot easier. I picked up another side quest at Daytower and fast travelled to that location. I quite enjoy using fast travel in some situations because sometimes it just all feels a bit much and I know that if I go by foot I'll run into some machines again, and it'll take forever to actually get to where I wanted to go. Afterwards I bought the golden fast travel pack so I can keep doing that. Sometimes it's quite nice to walk and explore and take in the scenery though, I

even took a screenshot of one earlier that had quite a stunning view. (I normally don't do that.) I was actually able to test out my new weapons in that quest and was pleased with them, it makes me feel like I actually know what I'm doing and am becoming more of an expert at this game. Tomorrow I'll head to Meridian, which is quite a long journey and supposedly quite dangerous, so maybe that's where my first non-clumsy death will be.

Another thing I noticed today was that I really don't *see* Aloy when I'm just out exploring or running around; it's mainly in fights that I become more aware of her again. Somehow I take in everything else but my brain seems to blank out where she's on the screen. It's interesting.

One annoying thing: Aloy keeps telling me what to do when I come into a new situation. I hate it when games do that too quickly, it feels like I'm not able to actually do it myself – and it feels like it's not respecting me enough as a player to figure things out for myself. It's not as bad as in *God of War* but still annoying.

4 September Today was going to be the last session of *Horizon Zero Dawn*, but it was full of personal interruptions so I might pick this up again next week to at least finish the quest/storyline that I'm on at the moment. It was a very stressful session as well and I died twice, once on my way to Meridian – the Stormbirds (?) were just too tough and killed me pretty quickly, so on my next try I just tried to run through everything and run away from as many machines as possible. Not very glorious or satisfying, but I didn't feel like spending so much of my time fighting again – the last few sessions had been very combat-heavy and I wanted a break from that and actually get some story time in. There are also a bunch of new machines on the way to Meridian – really tough ones like the Ravager – and that just felt too intimidating and stressful today. I did make it to Meridian and thanks to meeting up with Erend I had two main quests to choose from, either going after Olin or helping Erend find out what happened to his sister. I chose to follow Erend's quest today because somehow it felt more urgent or personal to help someone else, rather than finding out something for Aloy and her tribe, though I know that that's the 'main' main storyline. I felt quite involved in Erend's storyline because I like him as a character, and I find that I really enjoy using the focus in quests that aren't just based on analysing machines. I did a bit of a side quest on the way to Erend, but then followed his quest once I got to him. There was a battle at the beginning of his quest and I was killed by a Ravager once – after that I did manage to kill them all by specifically targeting their top gun with my special arrows. It was really satisfying whenever the game told me that I had removed a component. I was quite low on health by the end of all that and after investigating the area, I went back to Meridian to meet up with Erend again and follow the quest further.

Once again I was impressed with how the music in this game communicates with me. Quite a few times throughout the week I only knew to look for a machine once the music changed accordingly, and that was often what enabled me to hide in time to avoid detection.

I might pick up Erend's quest next week before continuing with one of the other games.

7 September I followed Erend's quest today to the point where we find Ersä – I'm quite intrigued by that questline in general and would love to continue it, but for the sake of the autoethnography I am stopping after today for the sake of feasibility. I mainly wanted to carry on with it to get a little bit of closure, though the questline doesn't end there – so it was a rather short session. On the way there I ran into a bunch of new machines that I hadn't met yet and was instantly killed by the one that went underground. After that I just stuck with riding my Strider through it all. Normally I quite like encountering new machines and learning how to take them out most efficiently, but I wasn't into it today. I didn't exactly feel rushed on the way there, I just didn't want to engage in drawn out combat especially given my overall low healing situation after the previous session. I did fight two Shellwalkers though and was actually able to take them out relatively easily, though I got stuck between some rocks at some point. Running away from all those machines felt quite stressful and I was a bit scared that they might kill me, primarily because I didn't want to re-load. Infiltrating Dervahl's camp was quite tough and I only managed to do it on the third try. Every time I wanted to be better at stealth to help me through the beginning at least, but in the end it just all ended in manic running around, hiding and shooting wildly – I did manage eventually though and we found Ersä and had some nice moments between her and Erend before she died. I felt a bit sad about that because I quite like Erend and thought about how difficult it must have been for him.

I did have a few issues with the game's communication today. I always use the Focus a lot – it's a great tool – but today while I was using it to follow the tracks of Marad's agent, it picked up a shape behind a house and immediately identified it as Marad's agent – deceased – so it did give away a bit of the game there. At times I also couldn't really interpret the music today (and like I've written before, it is one of the main means by which I navigate the game and detect machines early).

Horizon Zero Dawn is a good game, but it feels very different from the *Life is Strange* kind of games because it's so open-ended. I could spend hours just exploring the wilderness, finding collectibles and fighting machines, and getting distracted by combat or side quests while you're trying to do a different quest can pull you out of the narrative a bit. It feels like there is a lot less urgency in games like this. I enjoy it though and I enjoy the freedom that it provides.

B.4 *Life is Strange 2*

14 September 2020 (partial Episode 1) I started the first episode of *Life is Strange 2* today, though I didn't manage to play as much as I wanted to because of various interruptions and some tech issues in the beginning. I've played the first episode last year, so I have some expectations coming in, but as opposed to the other games in my autoethnography, I have not played more than that. I know what happens in the first episode, but I have no clue what the others are like, so it will be interesting to contrast my behaviours and practices with those games that I did already have knowledge of.

I remember, of course, the events of the prologue very well – the events leading up to the shooting, partly because this is what my participants played in the study as well. I only remember bits and pieces after that – needing money to buy supplies, being caught stealing and locked up, and being helped by some guy who was researching something related to porn. Also the revelation of Daniel's powers at the end of the episode. The details of course are foggy, but the episode had left a strong impression on me the first time I played it.

Going in, I was a bit surprised at the small choices that I did make. For the most part I think I behaved in the way that I normally would – in dialogue choices, being the nice/funny guy and having a good relationship with the family –, but even knowing full well that I was going to need money later on, I did not steal money from the father. I didn't think Sean was going to be that kind of character. The same goes for not stealing the candy bar from the car – it didn't seem necessary. I'm not sure though if I had stolen it had it been healthier food (the candy bar doesn't seem like a very nutritious option). I did confront the neighbour because he was an awful character and I wanted Sean to stand up for his little brother. But despite knowing what would happen, and knowing that the outcome would be the same no matter what I did, I felt shocked, guilty and emotional when Sean's father was shot, especially coupled with seeing the way Sean and Daniel interacted while running away. Sean trying to keep it together and not telling Daniel what happened was heartbreaking. The game communicated that choices matter right after the prologue, and I like the way that the game highlights discussing things with Daniel as a separate kind of choice which, presumably, is going to make a difference in the long run. So far it's difficult to say how my choices impact the characters and the narrative (apart from making sure that Daniel wasn't eating anything poisonous), but I'm sure that it will become clear soon. I feel a bit stressed looking after Daniel and I found myself continually using LB to look for him and to make sure that he wasn't doing anything he shouldn't have. I did not see that I was able to help him over the tree trunk and he fell, and after that I made sure to stay closer in case he needed more help. I'm excited to play more tomorrow, and even more excited to see what will happen once I get into unfamiliar territory.

15 September 2020 (end of Episode 1) I finished Episode 1 today and I'm hoping that things will move more quickly now – I should have a good chunk of time carved out for playing this and next week. I had to re-play the last minutes of yesterday's playthrough because it hadn't saved when I stopped (even though I thought it showed the symbol for saving). I discovered the souvenir section in the backpack, so now I'm keen on collecting those, similar to the photographs in *Life is Strange*. In addition, there are the optional drawings, which I'm quite enjoying now that I figured out the controls for it – the first one yesterday was a bit of a pain to do and I felt the game wasn't that great at telling me how to move the left stick. I feel that throughout this episode I've been incredibly anxious about taking care of Daniel, especially because I don't know what kinds of things are going to have what effect on him. It was alright with the conversational things – don't let him eat anything poisonous, don't scare him – but when the game showed me the choices that I had made vs. the global choices at the end of the credits, it did say that Daniel didn't eat enough, so apparently that's something I need to be mindful of as well. I'm enjoying that we have the puppy now, she's very cute, but I'm already wondering how we'll afford to feed her.

I deliberately didn't steal anything from the gas station, and I didn't send Daniel to beg for food – first of all, I didn't think anything would come out of asking the family for food (they seemed a bit hostile), but I also didn't want to do that to Daniel (yet – I'm sure we'll have many more similar situations). The same goes for stealing, I didn't want to turn them into actual criminals and again it's not something I wanted to teach Daniel. I was tempted when we managed to escape though and wanted to steal the camping gear, but I didn't want to assault the guy, which I assume would have led to much more trouble (maybe not now, but further along in the game). It's difficult to say what the right thing to do is – it feels that in this game there is a very strong distinction between what is good in terms of gameplay objectives, and what would be good or right in terms of narrative and character development. I'll see how my morals hold up to whatever the next episodes throw at us. Knowing how emotional *Life is Strange* was, I have no doubt that this is going to be a rough one as well. It was very satisfying figuring out how to escape with Daniel's help, and I'm glad that Daniel knows about their father now because now they can both be on the same page. I'm quite curious to see what's up with his super power. I remember that you briefly see the two of them in *The Adventures of Captain Awesome*, but apart from that I know nothing about what will happen next. It makes me a bit anxious playing these parts 'on camera', but I also think this will be really valuable for the study.

I found that I make dialogue choices very quickly and don't reflect on them much. I tend to choose them more instinctively, and I think based on what kind of character I think Sean is (or what kind of character I'd like him to be).

16 September 2020 (Episode 2) Episode 2 ended up being a tough one, though I'm sure I'll say this about every episode. I felt quite anxious throughout and generally erred on the side of caution regarding everything, especially Daniel's powers. There are a lot of factors to take into consideration when making choices: keeping a low profile; making sure that Daniel grows up to be a good person; protecting Daniel; and trying to do the right thing, morally speaking. Of course things don't always work out that way and everything is a lot more complex in this game than it was for example in *Life is Strange*. It seems that choices that appear to be minor do have an effect on how Daniel behaves, and in my case he behaved generally alright. I cautioned him against using his power whenever possible, but did concede in some situations, for example when he was saving Chris – it did seem prudent though to keep emphasising that he has to keep his powers a secret. I quite liked staying with the grandparents and wanted to be on good terms with them as a character, so I did my chores and talked to them whenever possible, and shared Daniel's secret with Stephen because he seems like a nice, honest person. I did ask Daniel to help Stephen when the cupboard fell on him though because at that point, it already looked like Claire was going to throw us out, so might as well show her what Daniel can do. While I generally thought I was doing the right thing, Daniel blamed me for Chris getting hit by the car because he didn't use his power. I felt a bit guilty when he said that, but even more so when the global choices were shown, which emphasised that not only was it possible to save Chris, it was also possible to not have to save him at all – I don't know what choice led to the police chasing after us though. Maybe it was in this episode – talking to too many people at the market – or something I did last episode. I find I am having to constantly re-evaluate what kind of choice I want to make; after two episodes I'm still not entirely sure, apart from having to be strict with Daniel.

I was heartbroken when Mushroom died near the beginning of the episode. She was a great dog and I loved having her around – I was afraid of something happening to her because, well, I know how stories work. I didn't want Daniel to use his power because it wouldn't have changed anything, and I didn't want him to experience killing an animal with his powers.

There were a few times in the episode where I felt annoyed at having a lack of agency – when first meeting the grandparents, I wasn't able to get up from the table and had to wait for them, and specifically disobeying their rules by going to the market and going into Karen's room. I understand why it happened from a narrative perspective, but I felt annoyed at being coerced into it as well because it emphasises how some things don't make a difference at all. I didn't use the laptop however because I wanted to keep a low profile, and didn't use the phone because I didn't realise I could have – I'm torn with these things, because I think they're the right choices to make but I hate missing out on content like this. On the bright side, I've now figured out drawing properly, so this goes a lot more quickly. It's a bit strange that the game keeps telling me how to do

things that I already know how to do – it feels a bit patronising. Another thing that I really enjoy is looking at the sketchbook to get Sean’s perspective of the things that are happening.

I really have to figure out what I want to do with these characters.

17 September 2020 (Episode 3) When I woke up this morning, my first thought was “I only have 4 dollars left, this is bad, I guess I really need to steal something now” – I guess the game is occupying me more than I thought. It might also be because I am binge-playing it, I might wait longer between episodes normally. So I was pleased when I started Episode 3 and noticed that I did actually have quite a bit of money because of the things that happened off-screen, which I was able to read about in Sean’s journal. I’m feeling a bit conflicted about that because on the one hand it’s good to have his reflections, on the other hand I’m feeling a bit cheated out of making these decisions and figuring these things out myself. However, that would be a much longer game...

It’s annoying that the game keeps telling you how to do things, especially when you’ve just started an episode. I realise that this is probably to remind people – after all, the episodes were not all released at the same time and there might have been months between playing – but it’s annoying that you can’t turn the tutorial messages off. It feels like the game is patronising in that way.

Most of this episode was quite chill – it was nice to see that Sean and Daniel had made friends and were living in this hippie commune kind of situation. It was less nice to see that Daniel is having to work on the weed farm too as that’s clearly not good for him. I instantly felt hostile towards Finn though because it was obvious what kind of influence he was having on Daniel, who was getting more hostile and angry towards me. I was trying to behave as understanding as I could with Daniel, but with Sean being a teenager himself, I often disagreed with the dialogue options, and often in this game the actual delivery of the dialogue is not what I anticipated. I find that annoying too, it doesn’t feel like the game is giving me enough information to make informed decisions. Then again, that’s also what the game is trying to convey I suppose. A lot of times in this episode, and in the last episode, I felt that no matter what I chose, the overall outcome would be the same anyway, so in the end it didn’t really matter. As soon as Finn started talking about the heist, I knew he was going to rope Daniel into it no matter what, so I decided to spend time with Cassidy during the party and sleep with her. I knew it wasn’t the best decision – I didn’t want to leave Daniel alone – but I also knew it was the right decision for Sean’s character. Daniel would be jealous of her no matter what, I figured. When the heist did happen and I had to go after Finn and Daniel, I was primarily angry (both with Finn and Daniel) for being so irresponsible. I did make sure that Jo wasn’t able to follow us though, which I guess was optional. Once there, I wanted to de-escalate the situation but knew that it would happen anyway, and

it did. I did allow Daniel to use his power to save Finn, but at this point in the game I thought he would disobey if I hadn't told him to because our relationship doesn't seem to be the best – I was shocked that Daniel got hurt though and I'm worried that Daniel has run off, because the choice screen at the end pointed at the door when it showed Daniel's choices.

Apart from some things that I thought were important for Sean – because I can see that he's struggling with all the responsibility – I tried to be kind but firm with Daniel, but I was not always successful. It would have been nice if the training at the lake had more of an impact on how Daniel deals with his powers depending on what I chose to train (destruction, precision or control), but in the end I had to do all of them and it escalated anyway. The game is making me feel sad about my choices, because no matter what I try to do, it always goes wrong...

I quite enjoyed the skill element of this episode when timing LT and RT to cut the weed buds. I was a bit frustrated that I didn't do quite as well with it though, and I realised I really struggle with multitasking, like participating in the dialogue when trying to do this. Still, it felt really nice to have something other than simple straightforward dialogue.

I think I'm starting to understand Sean as a character a bit more and maybe that makes me feel more alienated from Daniel as well. I think that only really happened in this episode, maybe because it was a more friendly atmosphere. I'm also coming to accept that at the end of the day he is a traumatised teenager, so naturally he will say some things that I wouldn't.

21 September 2020 (Episode 4) Episode 4 was an exciting episode. I was a bit anxious when I started playing today – I've had the weekend between episodes, which means I occasionally found myself thinking about Sean and Daniel. As opposed to *Life is Strange*, I wasn't really thinking about how I would have done things differently, I was more thinking about it in terms of characters, reflecting on the kind of character Sean is and realising that I understood him much better now. I also started to understand Daniel better through that reflection – in the moment of gameplay, I often end up being annoyed with him because he behaves irrationally, and I slip into the 'older sibling' eye-rolling role easily. It feels like it takes being outside of Sean to connect with Daniel more. Either way I think this episode was a game-changer in terms of my relationship with both of them. I was surprised when I started the episode and was with Daniel, but then soon realised it was just a dream. Waking up in the hospital was uncomfortable – it has become my habit to check the journal to catch up on things, but I didn't have that now (though there were some pieces of paper catching me up on what happened since the incident). I felt so restricted and experienced a huge loss of agency when I had to

just stay in bed and wasn't even able to move around. I did enjoy doing the sight tests – I like the little mini games in this game because there is so little other gameplay.

It was exciting when I found out where Daniel was (I felt very hostile towards the FBI agent anyway and knew they weren't going to help or believe me), and I liked that I had various options about how to get out of the hospital. I tried to send the guard away, but that didn't work. I didn't want to ambush the guard though and I didn't want to get Joey involved because I really liked him and didn't want him to be in trouble, so I decided to escape through the window. I didn't talk to Finn – I am still quite angry with him for causing the huge mess at the end of last episode and was concerned that he would give me away. The journey itself went quite well apart from being stopped by the racist guys. Once again this was quite shocking and uncomfortable – I don't experience racism in my everyday life and it really drove that subject home – but I decided to trust the trucker, even though the way the game had gone he could have easily been a creep as well.

Haven Point made me feel really uncomfortable. It was quite obvious very quickly that they would have brainwashed Daniel and it was understandable that he had fallen for that – he must have liked the attention and he was well taken care of – but I found it really shocking that he rejected me that way – followed by the even bigger shock of meeting Karen. Once I got over that I decided to be civil and understanding with her, I understood Sean's anger but I didn't want him to behave that way. I think despite his anger, my version of Sean is glad to see her especially after losing his dad. Sneaking around Lisbeth's house was fairly standard exploration and it occurred to me that there is quite a big difference between what I felt on behalf of the character – stress, anxiety, urgency – and what I understood in terms of gameplay – that I had all the time in the world to look at everything because the story wouldn't progress until a specific point. The same after hiding from Nicholas – I felt a bit bad for telling Karen to cause a distraction, since I expected she might get hurt in the process, but once he left I had time to go through everything, and that was good because it gave me more information that I was then able to use when talking to Daniel. In that confrontation, I was so repulsed by the cult – Lisbeth is a horrible person and I felt physical hate for her – and the stakes felt really high, so I was quite anxious about convincing Daniel, wondering how my choices in previous episodes influenced the situation as well. I think I got the 'good' ending here – nobody got hurt and it was satisfying to see the church burn. In the preview for the next episode it's obvious that they made it to Mexico so I'm excited to see what the final episode will be like.

Oh, and I shared my money with Jacob. He clearly needed it for his sister and I was hoping (maybe naively) that Karen would be able to support us financially until we got to Mexico.

23 September 2020 (Episode 5) This episode was *hard*. I expected it to be that way – the last episode of *Life is Strange* was very intense as well, after all, so I knew what kind of emotional rollercoaster to expect. Still, overall I didn't feel as anxious about this episode as I was about others; I felt quite peaceful at the beginning, since a lot of the episode took place in Away and I liked the atmosphere and energy there. It was nice to see that they were finally doing well and got a good rest, and after the events of the previous episode Daniel has also had significant changes in character and was a lot easier to handle. I did run into a bug at some point where the game wouldn't progress because Daniel's treasure hunt hadn't been triggered, and I got so frustrated not realising that – there was no indication from the game what to do at all, and Sean referred to Daniel having said he would have to look outside (but he never did). I had to look this up to see if I missed something and started from the last checkpoint, and that was fine. I quite enjoyed the treasure hunt, it was a cute addition to everything and just felt normal. It was clear that something dramatic would happen to make them leave of course, so I wasn't too surprised when we heard about the police being on our trail. I enjoyed the time I got to spend with Karen – she's a cool character and having Sean accept what she did and have a good relationship with her was important for me, for his and Daniel's development both. It did feel strange when I realised that David was David from *Life is Strange* – he looked very different and hearing him talk about Arcadia Bay being destroyed made me feel guilty all over again. It was nice to get some closure about that too though, and it was nice to hear that he now had a good relationship with Chloe and Max. That was a really nice touch.

It feels like there wasn't that much gameplay in the episode, as a whole – even more cut-scenes and dialogue than normal. I noticed especially today that the controller was vibrating *a lot* whenever something happened like touching someone, being hugged, or Daniel's strong use of his power to destroy the wall. Not sure how I feel about that because I'm used to it being an indication that's important for gameplay in other games – here it's more to introduce a tactile element I suppose, maybe to enhance the embodied experience because you feel *something* in those moments. I was really shocked when Daniel got shot though and really hate those vigilante characters.

The police station made me feel very uncertain what to do – when I didn't know yet what my options would be. I realised that especially with everything going on in terms of racism in the US police force nowadays, I as player didn't trust the police to be helpful. I figured that they would try to hurt me or not listen to me at any rate, so I didn't know what to do with them. Still, I tried not to make Daniel use his power to kill or hurt people unnecessarily – I asked him to free the Mexicans but ignored the vigilantes because I didn't want them to cause me any more trouble (and especially didn't want to free them), and I only chose to hurt the other police officers. I'm glad Daniel didn't have to kill anyone. When we reached the wall again though... that was a difficult decision to make. Even though I was debating with myself I felt I didn't want

to ask Daniel to help us get to Mexico. I didn't want him to become that person, and the police officer *had* said that Daniel would get to be with the grandparents. At that moment, my main priority was Daniel's well-being and I didn't think I would be able to guarantee that without surrendering. The whole scene actually made me cry, but even afterwards I knew I'd made the right choice, especially when seeing the photos of Daniel's life afterwards. It was also good to see Sean get out after 15 years, and it was really strange seeing Daniel as a grown-up. I definitely don't feel as conflicted about this ending as I did about *Life is Strange* because the morality of the situation seems more clear-cut here.

B.5 *Detroit: Become Human*

8 October 2020 I only managed to play a little bit today – under an hour – because of meetings and deadlines, and I was having some technical issues playing so I'll see how far I'll get into my autoethnography. *Detroit* is very laggy at the moment and that makes it less pleasant to play. For some reason the trackpad is not working on PS4 Remote Play and changing the controller didn't work. I don't remember if I need it for anything other than reading optional things though.

One thing that really struck me was how intense and stressful the first chapter of the game is. I guess it's a very good way to introduce the player to the game, but it's interesting that Connor gets such a dramatic introduction in a coherent scene – the others will have dramatic stories too, but broken up. I especially noticed how fast-paced the music was, which added to the immediate stress of the scene and the time pressure, with the objectives saying that every second counts, made autoethnography difficult because I'm not very good at multitasking. I managed to get the 'good' ending I suppose – the deviant was killed and the hostage saved – but there was a lot to process in that scene – not only being told how to play the game, with the strange motion controls, but it also introduced software instability for Connor, which of course is not explained. Generally I tried to do as much as I could in the time, though I still took too long and there were casualties as a result. One thing that struck me was that the game maybe didn't communicate that clearly that the deviant was going to die anyway – though it does give the choice between reassuring and telling the truth, so it did indicate that. Generally very good exposition. The other scenes were very brief and I was struck by the powerlessness in Kara's first scene – being in the shop and only being able to look around, but not actually being able to interact with anything. Maybe that's why I normally feel so close with her. Markus's first scene – getting the paint supplies – provided more context for the society overall, especially the discrimination against androids, but I was already a bit annoyed at that point because of the issues I had with the controller.

I played this game myself last year, but I'm most familiar with this one – compared to the others – because I watched someone play it just this year, so I still generally know the storylines. But with *Detroit* being so nuanced, I am curious to see what kind of choices I'll make this time, and which ones I'll keep.

9 October 2020 I was able to spend a good few hours playing today and luckily today the touchpad was working mostly fine – which is good, because I immediately needed it to progress in one of the first scenes today. The motion sensors are still a bit unresponsive though and led to me not being able to escape from Todd when protecting Alice, but it didn't impact the game outcome too much because I got away in the end (after shooting him). Hopefully there won't be too many issues like this along the line. The characters and their stories were fleshed out more today. I feel closest to Kara, maybe because her story is so emotional.

I did get Connor killed and I knew I wasn't making a good decision when I made it. In previous playthroughs I had been diplomatic in the interrogation of the android, but this time I decided to probe its memory, which led to its attempt to self-destruct, which then led to it shooting Connor. I wasn't expecting that – I chose to probe the memory because I was curious to see what would happen, but I would never have done that on first playthrough, or with any of the other characters; I already know that Connor gets replaced by another Connor when he dies, however you then lose some of his software instability. From a character standpoint, it made a bit of sense, but probably not completely because while Connor doesn't see them as persons, he also wouldn't endanger the mission like that, so that felt like a failure to me. My relationship with Hank suffered from it as well and I'm having to be delicate around him. Normally in games I would attempt to explore every dialogue option possible, but I chose not to ask Hank about everything I found out because he was clearly getting touchy and I didn't want him to be more hostile towards me. I like Hank; he's probably my favourite character in the game. He's got depth.

I felt quite intrigued again by Markus's relationship with Carl and the philosophical implications of it – however I don't actually feel that close with Markus generally. I think the closeness with him is more on an intellectual level.

Generally, the game made some interesting choices for character-player closeness today, particularly in Markus's defective senses after being shot. It was surreal not being able to perceive the world around you properly. Physically, I also felt incredibly close with Kara particularly when she was fighting Todd and escaping across the busy road – both instances felt very threatening and the quick-time events were in rapid succession, so my heart rate was actually up and my palms sweaty. I rarely notice that in other games I think, at least not consciously, and it was interesting to see how the fictional threat can feel quite real.

The notion of self is also more complicated in this game, which I anticipated – there are three player-characters and one of them is playing against the other two, so there is bound to be some conflict. From an immersion point of view, it can sometimes feel a bit jarring switching from one storyline to the other – at other times, for example after the Todd scene, it was more of a relief because I felt I needed to take a deep breath after that. That's why when I'm talking about the characters, I still tend to call them by their names rather than using 'I' – but I noticed that I am more prone to using 'I' when I'm talking about Kara.

13 October 2020 After the weekend it took me a little while to get back into the game – I remembered what had happened previously but it still took a little bit to get in touch with the characters again. A lot happened in today's session, though overall it didn't feel as stressful as last session – I went after another deviant as Connor, escaped from creepy Zlatko who was trying to enslave Kara, and stole some supplies for the androids in Jericho as Markus. I remembered the scenes quite well so I already knew the overall outcome. I tried to build a better relationship with Hank and was very conscious of approaching him differently than how I would normally play – so far Hank got very annoyed when I asked too many personal questions, especially given Connor's inability to, well, make non-awkward conversation (I agree with Hank – who *did* design that guy, given that the other androids seem perfectly capable of not being awkward?), so I felt that remarking on his diet or the company he keeps would alienate him more. Of course that didn't even compare to how much I alienated him right after that, when I chased the deviant and chose to pursue the deviant rather than Hank. In that moment especially, I felt very conflicted about my decision. From a gameplay point of view, I knew that I had messed up the previous investigation a bit by letting the android self-destruct, so I figured if I pursued this one, I might get more crucial information – and Hank's survival was rated 89% so I figured that was pretty good. I didn't think the game would let him die anyway. From a character/narrative standpoint though, I wanted to save him because I like him and I want to develop their relationship more. In that split second, my gameplay focus won and Hank ended up being really angry with me, and dropped down to being hostile – I felt especially attacked when he asked if he was 'just a statistic' because... yes, in that moment he was and I felt guilty about it. That scene felt like a huge failure, especially given that the deviant committed suicide, so I didn't actually get anything in exchange for alienating Hank. Finding him passed out drunk at his house later felt very personal and I tried my best to be civil towards him hoping that our relationship will recover a bit. On a character side, going after the deviant also reduced Connor's software instability and I wonder what kind of effect that will have on his character.

Kara's and Markus's scenes felt a lot more 'gameplay'-y or skilful than other scenes, especially Kara's because I actually had to sneak around in order to not get caught

after restoring my memories. Despite it taking me ages to realise that I could just walk past Luther at first instead of having to sneak past him, everything went quite smoothly I think, and as always it was very satisfying to see the android monsters kill Zlatko. He was a repulsive character. What is it about most male human characters in this game being creepy/aggressive/unpleasant? Markus's warehouse scene was fairly standard, but I did enjoy having to figure out how to get past the guards to get the key, and I was pleased that I managed this without any casualties or confrontation.

Today, then, I felt most connected with Connor, primarily because I cared more about his storyline and I feel like I'm messing up his character more than the others and feel very conflicted about that. It's a weird disconnect where I can see where the game might take Connor's personality, but I don't want to go in that direction because I find it more meaningful for him to have a personal relationship and be less robotic.

14 October 2020 Today wasn't as emotional as yesterday; once again I felt close to Connor and realised that my closeness to Connor was to a large extent because a lot of things had gone wrong in his storyline – the relationship with Hank is up from hostile now (and is now tense, so doesn't feel that much better), and Connor's software instability is up which I'm aiming for I guess – I just think it'll be a more interesting story if he does have that instability but of course I don't know what it would be like if it was very low. I deliberately didn't shoot the android at the sex club because the loving gesture towards her android girlfriend made me feel for them – of course I'm aware that from a gameplay perspective I would have needed them for information. So far, my investigation is not going very well and Amanda is very suspicious of me now. Hank did approve of me not shooting the android though and I feel like showing Hank the humanity of androids is an important aspect of the game. The investigation at the TV station was frustrating however; I wasn't aware that I wouldn't be able to check the roof after dealing with the androids in the kitchen (and maybe I could have, had I been faster). I was conflicted about going to the roof anyway because I knew I would find Simon and didn't want that from Markus's point of view, but I figured that would end the scene and I wanted to investigate the other angle first. I didn't remember what would happen with the androids in the kitchen, so I was surprised when I was attacked and had only very limited time to save myself – paired with the difficult controls in that moment (probably to mimic Connor's difficulty) I ended up taking too long, resulting in a mediocre ending of the scene. That scene felt like such a clear failure, though I know it could have been worse.

Markus's attack on the TV station was fairly straightforward – I opted for a non-violent approach towards the guards because I thought that would be the most appropriate to actually get to Markus's goals. However, I chose to end the speech in a determined way, and that (maybe paired with the lowered public opinion by burning down Zlatko's house in Kara's storyline) now means that the humans perceive androids as a threat

and are hostile towards them. That wasn't my intention and I feel anxious about how that will affect the rest of the game. I find that overall I don't care that much about Markus or his storyline because it seems too grand; I know it's crucial for the narrative, but I feel more connected to the more personal storylines of Connor and Kara. I think I also really like Connor's one because it is the funniest (Hank's reactions to Connor crack me up a lot).

Kara's scene at Rose's house was probably the most positive of the ones I played today; there were quite a few things I didn't find because I was running out of time (without knowing that I was – sometimes it would be helpful to know this), but I hid all the evidence in time and the police officer was not suspicious of Kara. So that scene feels like more of a success because it is quite clear how I could have failed that.

I was having a lot of technical issues today, with PS Remote Play not connecting after the update and I spent a lot of time figuring that out, so I was already a bit annoyed when I started playing. I also had to finish earlier than I intended because it kept losing its connection; I hope that the next session will go more smoothly.

15 October 2020 I hate PS Remote Play and its connection issues. Once again I wasn't able to play for very long today, it started losing connection at some point and while it was still doable for a while, the disconnects became so frequent that they were really disruptive to my gaming experience. I don't have that much of the game left I think, probably another one or two sessions, but very much depending on whether it will actually allow me to play consistently.

The constant disruptions made it difficult for me to properly get into the game because the experience kept being interrupted. Today was very Connor and Markus heavy, I only got to play Kara towards the end of my session. I felt quite conflicted but also a bit more at peace with the decisions I've made. I have made the decision to definitely take Connor down the deviant route because I think there has been enough evidence of that in his personality and from his experience with other androids – maybe especially because he died and was reset, it feels like it's a bit more personal to him now and he's trying not to lose a part of himself again. That's how I'm interpreting him, anyway. When I went to see Kamski, I already knew what was going to happen – I've thought a lot about this scene since I first played the game. I knew Kamski was going to ask me to shoot Chloe in order to get information, or spare her, showing empathy but not getting any information. To be honest, I thought my investigation was going badly enough as it was already. I knew before that scene what I was going to do, and although I'm really interested in knowing what he would tell me if I shot Chloe, I really didn't want to take Connor down that route. The fact that Hank specifically told Connor not to do it helped me justify that decision from Connor's perspective as well. Seeing Chloe was actually really jarring, because she's the android in the main menu as well. Kamski was also a

massive creep and I don't want to know what he's doing with all his look-alike android women. My relationship with Hank went up to neutral, but I never realised that this would mean he wasn't going to help me find more evidence about Jericho when the FBI took over the investigation. I wonder if that means that Hank will not be helping me any longer at all – which would be a real shame, I like Hank a lot. (It was nice to see that I did get enough evidence after all though.)

Markus's scenes were primarily focused on getting the protests started. North was quite hostile toward me, especially after the non-consensual kiss to avoid police detection (fair enough, I suppose, that was probably uncalled for), but I managed to have a good ending to that scene and made sure to leave a peaceful message. I don't think that violence was going to be the answer here because I think public opinion is going to be crucial in determining how the game will end. After the android march, public opinion went up to sympathetic, particularly after the police kept killing androids. I do regret not having done something different then – I should have at least sacrificed myself (I definitely didn't want to launch an actual attack because that would have probably just started a war). Partly, however, I was keeping an eye on public opinion and saw it was going up the more I stood my ground – in the end I panicked and ran though because I didn't want Markus to potentially die. Thinking back on it now, I don't think he would have died anyway.

The beginning of the scene at Jericho was interesting. This is where all the characters are finally in one space, and it feels a bit jarring being pulled away from one character to the next. I'll probably have to replay that beginning tomorrow anyway. Another very interesting thing happened when I restarted after the initial connectivity problems – menu Chloe actually said that maybe we shouldn't continue. This was definitely the boldest intervention from her so far, and it really does remove an element of “this is just a game.”

16 October 2020 Once again, the connection issues were overwhelming today – after researching it and finding out that apparently this is a common problem since the latest software update a few days ago, I realised I couldn't continue this way with the game being interrupted every other minute. I knew I was going to be able to finish the game today though, so my last bit of research was done with a very makeshift recording setup, pointing my webcam at the TV screen and recording it this way. It wasn't pretty, and probably will have a lot of issues because it also captured its own reflection in the screen (how meta), but at least I was able to finish the game this way. Given that I have no way of knowing when or if the software issues were going to be fixed, I really didn't want to have this drag on forever. For future research I will definitely want to focus on PC games only to avoid these kinds of issues.

All of this put me in quite a bad mood when I started playing properly, but I got back into the game fairly quickly. The Jericho chapter was quite exciting, basically consisting of a lot of rapid quick-time events – there was a strong sense of satisfaction when I did them well, and I noticed that when those events happen, my mind seems to put the narrative or even the characters to one side, instead focusing on remembering where the buttons are and reacting to them as quickly as possible. It gets especially confusing when the events change from just using the normal buttons to using the stick or using the trigger buttons. I wonder how long it takes for new players to learn the controller layout in a way that they can do this quickly enough.

Connor becoming a deviant was a definite highlight of the game and felt really good. I had aimed for him to become that for a long time – I just think it's more interesting and it makes more sense in terms of the narrative, so when he was finally able to break his programming properly it was so satisfying. My heart really went out to Connor and I was really proud of him – though it's strange to feel proud of a character that you also control. It's not pride in myself, but in the player-character, while at the same time thinking about the fact that *I* was becoming a deviant. Soon after that, I noticed that when I was talking about the android population and their plans and chances I did so from a 'we' perspective – thinking along the lines that I didn't trust the humans to treat *us* fairly. I was a bit torn between whether to start a revolution or a protest. I did think though that Markus was not the kind of character to launch an attack like that, at least not the way I played him, and I also thought that showing the humans that we were peaceful would be more fruitful than being openly hostile. I did stand my ground as Markus throughout the protest. Public opinion turned supportive, and kissing North made the humans stop – this is probably the best ending, where the androids are liberated.

Kara's storyline was more frustrating. I did make it to the bus terminal, but chose the less risky route even though I knew it meant missing the bus. I'm not sure why I did that, but didn't think that going through a checkpoint was going to work. Maybe I would have needed to not save Luther in order to get there in time? I failed Kara's storyline with one single choice and I'm still frustrated about it because I don't think I had enough information to know that this was going to be a 'final' choice – with a lot of the other storylines it seemed to be a matter of failing quick-time events. I could have used Luther as a distraction, but didn't, and that was my mistake. It is a bit frustrating that Kara's storyline ended so abruptly and... unceremoniously. The frustration immediately lowered my interest in the main storyline as well, but I'm not sure why. Maybe it is being disappointed and annoyed with the game itself.

I did love the scene at the Cyberlife tower, especially because it focused on my relationship with Hank once the second Connor took him hostage. I felt quite proud of myself when I managed to make him see that I was the correct Connor through bits of the 'personal information' that I got out of him throughout the game. (Note that I feel

proud of *myself* here.) Hank went up to being a friend, and it was nice to see him hug Connor in the credits. Given that for the majority of the game he was hostile or tense towards me, that feels like a big achievement, and somehow I'm more happy about this little personal outcome than the overall outcome of the story even.

I will eventually go back to the game out of curiosity to see how some of the scenes could have ended differently. I won't do this as part of my autoethnography – that was supposed to be one normal playthrough. Letting menu Chloe leave in the end felt like actually finalising this playthrough.

My feeling of identity was so conflicted so often throughout playing, but I still feel the strongest connection with Connor. When I think of the game, I immediately think of *his* scenes, and I think part of that is because I had such a big impact on how to develop him as a character – becoming a deviant or not becoming a deviant is a very big decision and he was definitely the most interesting to play. The choices I made on Connor's behalf seemed to have a much bigger impact on his character than it did with the others. This sense of identity was really confusing in the confrontation between Markus and Connor since I controlled both sides of that conversation, which didn't feel right, it felt like I had too much control. But when I saw Markus again and he said 'We did it', I actually did say to myself 'Yes, *I* did it, freeing the androids at the warehouse.'

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